

11.7%

Share of Seattleites within a 10-minute walk of a *legal* off-leash area. 99% live that close to a park of any kind.

Seattle has one of America's best park systems. For dogs, it's one of the worst. This site is a sourced, reproducible public-data reference: every number links back to where it came from. The [opinion page](#) is clearly marked; everything else is factual. [Download the full PDF](#).

OFF-LEASH SPACE / DOG

5.4_{sq ft}

Footprint of a doormat. 30.7 designated off-leash-area (OLA) acres (12 fully fenced; Magnuson and I-5 Colonnade partial) ÷ ~249,000 dogs (American Veterinary Medical Association estimate). [src](#)

CITATIONS OUTSIDE OLA WALKSHED

71.9%

3,089 of the 4,299 enforcement records placed at 37 geocoded parks fell outside the walkshed (the area within a 10-minute walk) 2014–2026 (via public records request, PRR). [src](#) · [script](#)

YEARS SINCE LAST NEW OLA

13

Kinnear, 2013 → West Seattle Stadium, now expected 2028. [src](#)

FEWER / CAPITA THAN PORTLAND

3.2×

Seattle 1.82 vs Portland 5.74 per 100,000 residents. [src](#)

RECENT UPDATES

September 2026 · [Five headline figures corrected, two records releases ingested, and every page cut to its finding](#)

Asked directly, Seattle Parks produced the off-leash share of the parks-maintenance budget this site had said could not be known. The OLA-only figure is \$328,345 for 2023, not the \$126,000 carried here, and about \$1.57M in 2025 once construction money is counted — of which \$1,053,037 of \$5,625,926 has actually been spent. The OLA gap is thirteen years, not seventeen; the two funded sites are expected in 2027–28, not 2026; and the City was billed \$456,173 in 2024 for three officers it did not field. Sources and methodology now live on a single [Data & Methods](#) page.

[See all updates →](#)

The reports, *in short*.

Seven sections covering the OLA system: counts, access, what's working, enforcement, budget, peer-city comparisons, and the author's opinion. The first six are factual; the last is opinion. Sources and scripts are linked throughout.

Part I — The Gap. Seattle has added zero net dog parks since 2013, and the two funded sites are now expected in 2027 and 2028. Since 2010 the city's population has grown 34% while the OLA count went from 11 to 14. Per capita, Seattle runs at about one-third of Portland and San Francisco's OLA density.

Part II — Access. 11.7% of Seattleites are within a 10-minute walk of an OLA. (the [Trust for Public Land \[TPL\]](#) says 99% are within a 10-minute walk of any park.) Seven of 14 OLAs are below the [American Kennel Club \(AKC\) 1-acre minimum](#). [2 of 14 have lighting](#); [5 have small-dog areas](#); water access varies by site.

Part III — Forward. Three questions worth pressing on: which of Seattle's existing OLAs actually function well and why, what shared-use looks like in cities that have run it for decades, and which public lands outside Seattle Parks & Recreation (SPR), such as WSDOT right-of-way, Seattle City Light corridors and Port of Seattle property, could host off-leash space without new Park District dollars.

Enforcement. 7,015 off-leash enforcement records (2014–2026): 3,151 citations and 3,191 verbal warnings. Six of the top ten cited parks have no designated OLA. Citations cluster in areas without OLAs, or where the OLA that exists is below the AKC 1-acre minimum.

Budget. SPR's reported budget grew from \$168M (2018, operating only) to \$507M proposed (2026, all funds). About a quarter of the apparent jump is a 2019 reporting shift from operating-only to all-funds, not real growth. The dedicated-OLA line ran about \$106,000 a year in Park District Cycle 1, 0.068% of SPR's total. Cycle 2 is several times that: \$328,345 in 2023 and roughly \$1.57M in 2025 once construction money is counted. About a fifth of the Cycle 2 money has been spent.

Peer Cities. Per-city detail on how eight peers actually run their off-leash systems: Portland, San Francisco, Vancouver BC, Washington DC, Minneapolis, New York, Austin, and Boise. Counting methodology, governance, funding, operating rules, and at least one design choice per city that Seattle hasn't tried.

Opinion & Recommendation. Author's policy recommendation: a time-zoned shared-use model for existing parks (NYC-style off-leash hours), with enforcement redirected to clean-park compliance.

AI DISCLOSURE

This site was built by [Claude](#), Anthropic's AI assistant. The underlying data was collected by the author: public records requests, SPR budget documents, census data and peer-city research. The author reviewed the output before publication. The [editorial](#) reflects his personal views.

CORRECTIONS AND CONTRIBUTIONS WELCOME

We stand behind this work and publish every source so it can be verified, disputed, or improved. If you find an error, we want to know: a wrong number, a stale figure, a methodological flaw, or a better primary source. Known gaps where outside help would be especially useful: current dog-population estimates, per-OLA usage data, and SPR's internal budget split between OLAs and P-Patches.

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(preferred, because corrections stay public and auditable) or email us at seattledogparkdata@ozymandi.as. The site will be updated and the change noted.

Seattle added *zero* net off-leash areas in thirteen years.

The last off-leash area (OLA) opened in [2013](#). Since 2010 the city's [population has grown by roughly 208,000](#) and its [parks budget by 37%](#) on an apples-to-apples baseline. The two funded sites, West Seattle Stadium and Othello, are now expected in [2027 and 2028](#).

OLAS IN 2010

11

Per SPR's 2017 *People, Dogs & Parks Plan*; Denny, Magnolia Manor and Kinnear were added in 2012–13. [src](#)

OLAS IN 2025

14

Unchanged since 2013. Othello is expected fall 2027, West Seattle Stadium winter 2028. [src](#)

POPULATION, 2010→2025

+34%

608,660 → 816,600 residents. [src](#)

SPR BUDGET, 2019→2025

+37%

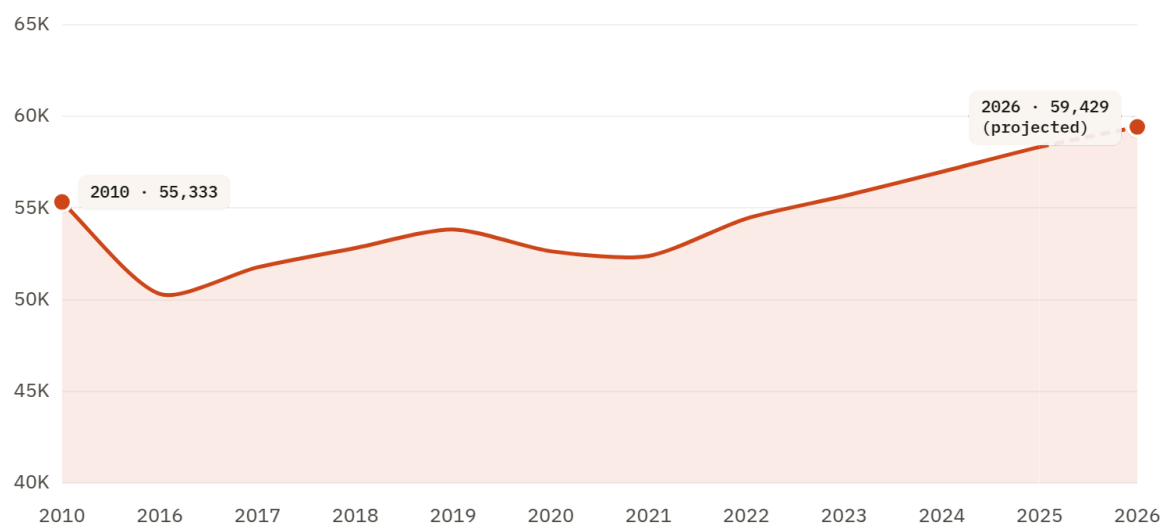
\$247.7M → \$339.4M all funds (apples-to-apples baseline). [src](#)

Residents per off-leash area keeps climbing.

Dividing [Seattle's population](#) by its [OLA count](#): in 2016, the first full year the site's data covers after the 2013 additions, one OLA served about [50,300 residents](#). In 2025 it served [58,329](#), a 16% increase with the count fixed at 14. In 2010, with 11 OLAs, the figure was about 55,300; three additions in 2012–13 brought it down, and thirteen years of growth have pushed it back past that point.

Residents per OLA, 2010-2026

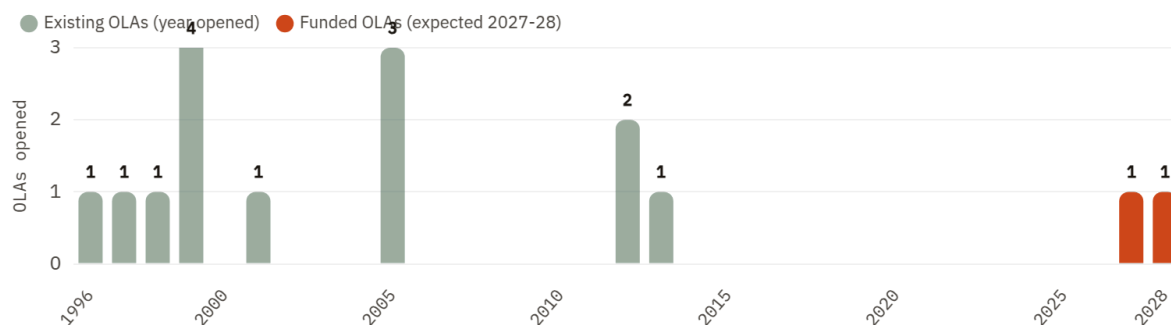
The last OLA opened in 2013 (Kinnear). The two funded sites, [West Seattle Stadium](#) and [Othello Playground](#), are in design and expected in 2027 and 2028, so 2026 projects with no change in the count.



Source: WA OFM April 1 population estimates · OLA count per SPR People, Dogs & Parks Plan (2017) · planned sites per SPR project pages (archived Sept 2026) · data in [data/seattle-timeseries.csv](#)

When Seattle's 14 OLAs opened, and when the next two are due

Count of OLAs opened per year, from SPR's own chronology. Eight came out of the 1996–99 pilot, three were added in 2005, and the last three in 2012–13. The funded sites are expected in fall 2027 (Othello) and winter 2028 (West Seattle Stadium).



Source: year opened per [SPR People, Dogs & Parks Plan \(Aug 2017\)](#), pp. 11-12 and Section 7 · planned sites per [SPR project pages \(archived\)](#) · data in [seattle-olas.csv](#) + [planned-olas.csv](#)

OBSERVATION

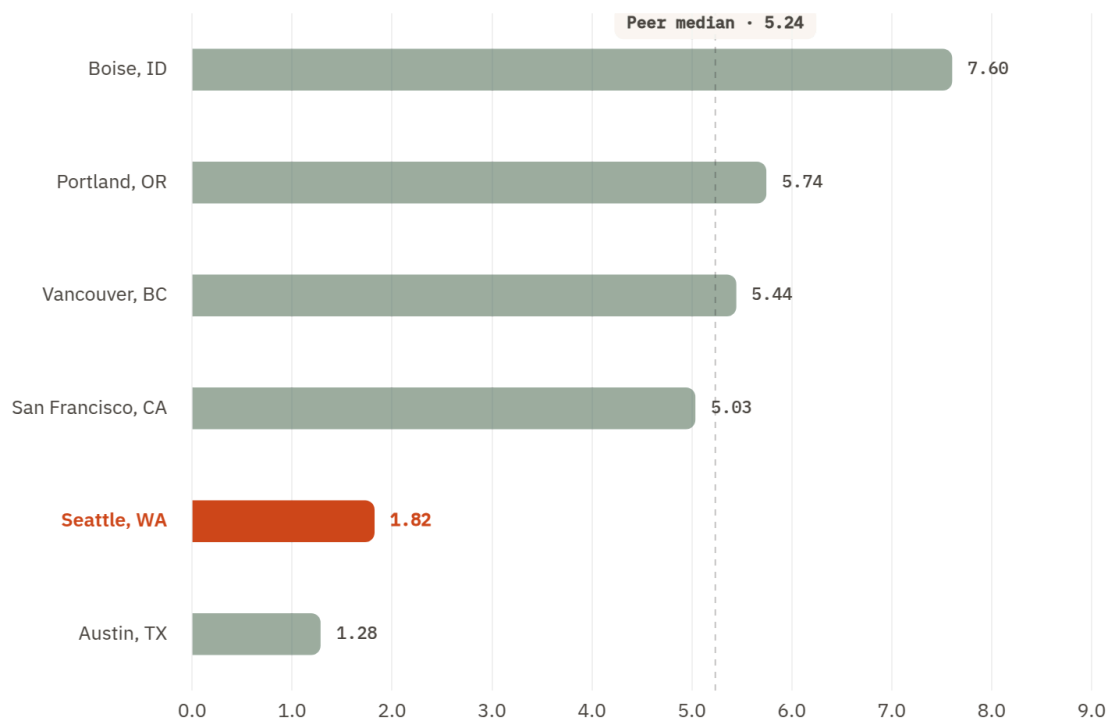
No OLA has opened in the twelve full years from 2014 through 2025. SPR's 2023 Expansion Study acknowledges demand "has grown since the pilot program was launched in 1997," and SPR's own enforcement agency told the City Council in 2022 that [the shortage pushes owners to run dogs off-leash in regular parks](#).

Seattle has about a third of its West Coast peers' dog parks per capita.

[Trust for Public Land's 2025 ParkScore](#) counts dog parks per 100,000 residents across the 100 largest U.S. cities. Seattle sits below every major West Coast peer; [Portland](#) has roughly 3.2× Seattle's per-capita supply. Full per-city detail and counting caveats are on the [Peer Cities](#) page.

Dog parks per 100,000 residents, 2025

Comparable and aspirational cities. Vancouver BC is not in ParkScore, so this uses its self-reported count of 36 OLAs from the [People, Parks & Dogs Strategy](#) and the Statistics Canada 2021 census population.



Source: [Trust for Public Land 2025 ParkScore Index](#) · [Vancouver Park Board People, Parks & Dogs Strategy \(2017\)](#) · data in [data/peer-cities.csv](#)

OBSERVATION

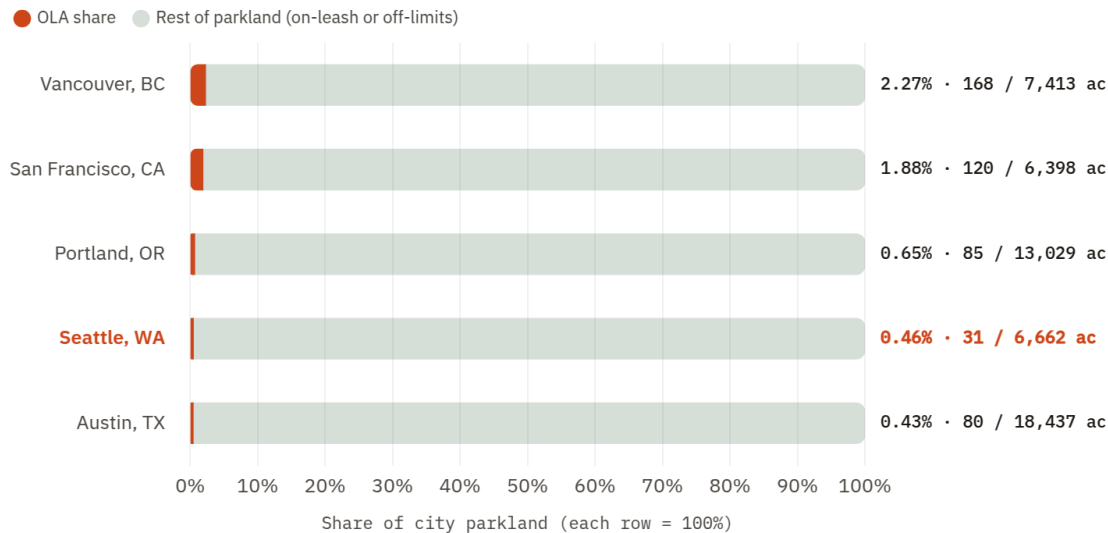
Counting rules differ: Portland includes unfenced voice-control areas and Vancouver BC includes time-restricted shared-use areas. Normalizing for those differences narrows the gap without closing it. The City's own comparison agrees on Seattle's position: in its [June 2022 report to Council](#) (PRR C266465, Bates 00524), the Finance and Administrative Services department put Seattle at 1.9 OLAs per 100,000 residents against Portland's 4.9 and San Francisco's 6.5.

Less than half a percent of Seattle's parkland is legal off-leash.

Per-capita supply is one measure. How the city allocates the park system it already runs is a second. Of Seattle's [6,662 acres](#) of municipal parkland, [30.7](#) are legal off-leash, about **0.46%**. Vancouver BC allocates roughly five times that share and San Francisco about four times.

OLA acreage as a share of total municipal parkland

OLA acres divided by total parkland acres in each city, using each city's own published count and the same counting caveats as above. Portland's 0.65% includes ~85 acres of mostly unfenced voice-control areas. Austin's 0.43% uses its ~80 fenced acres and excludes the much larger Walnut Creek voice-control natural area.



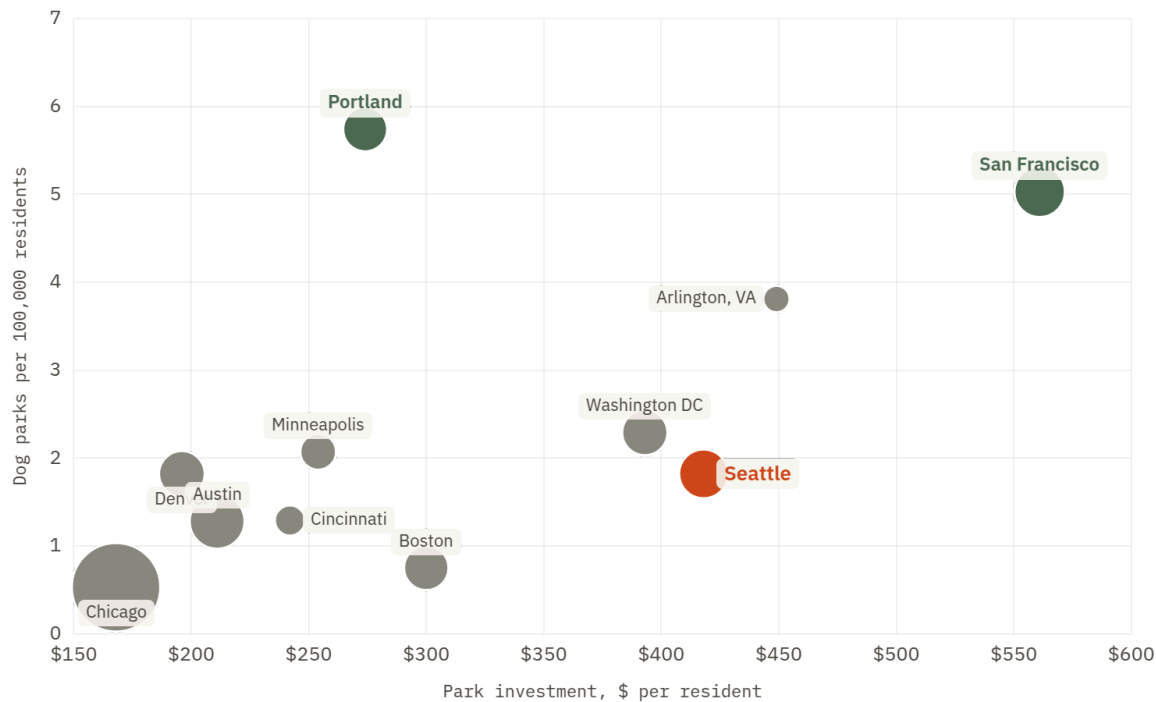
Source: total parkland acres from [TPL 2025 ParkScore](#) (US) and [Vancouver Park Board](#) · OLA acres reconciled to each city's own inventory · data in [data/peer-cities.csv](#)

High park investment, low dog-park density.

Seattle is one of the [best-funded municipal park systems in the country](#), at [\\$418 per resident per year](#) in TPL's investment category. [San Francisco](#) spends more (\$561) and has roughly 2.8× the dog-park density; [Portland](#) spends less (\$274) and has 3.2×. Funding is not what separates Seattle from its peers.

Park investment per resident vs. dog parks per 100,000

Each city's three-year average park investment (TPL ParkScore methodology, all agencies), plotted against its dog-park density.



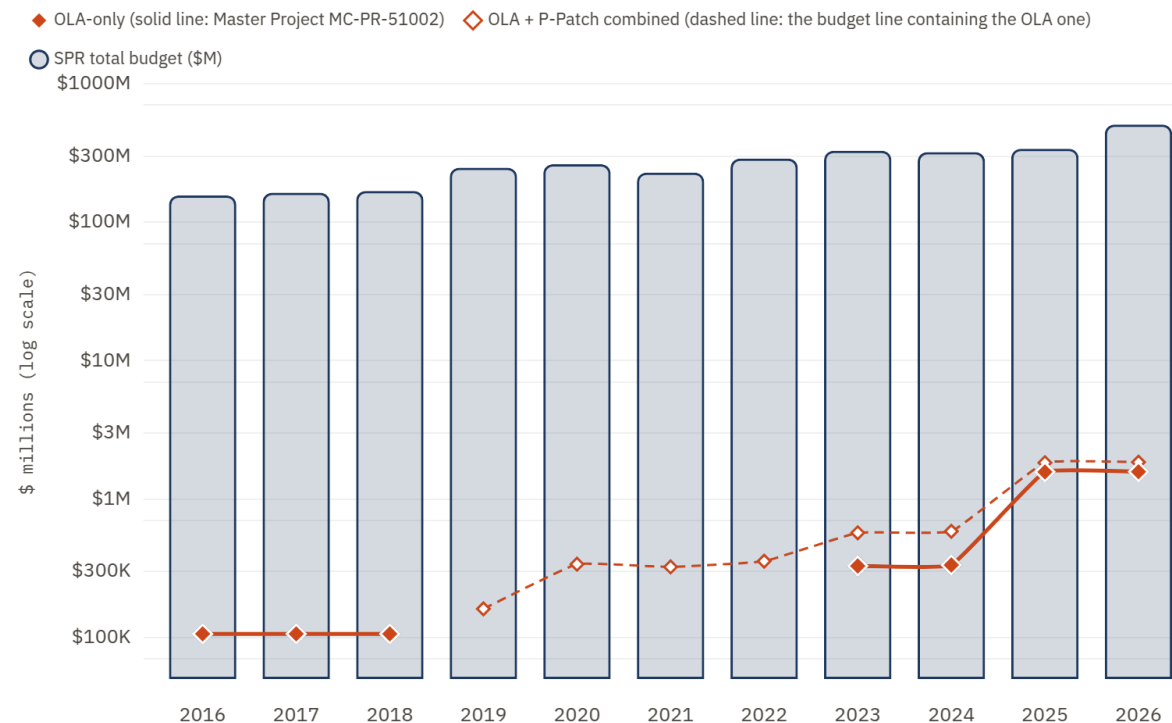
Source: [TPL 2025 ParkScore](#) (three-year average spending across all park-providing agencies) · data in [data/peer-cities.csv](#)

The parks budget, and the sliver of it that goes to OLAs.

[Seattle Parks and Recreation's budget](#) rose from \$156M in 2016 to \$506.9M proposed for 2026. During Park District Cycle 1, SPR's 2017 plan put the dedicated OLA line at [\\$103,000–\\$117,000](#) a year, costed at \$106,000 through 2020. Since 2019 the published budget reports OLAs and P-Patch community gardens as one line, but SPR tracks them as separate Master Projects and released the split in July 2026: the OLA-only figure is [\\$328,345](#) in 2023, rising to about \$1.57M in 2025 as Cycle 2 construction money lands inside it. Of the [\\$3,103,000](#) for the two new OLAs, roughly \$600,000 had been spent by July 2026, all on planning and design. The full breakdown, the per-dog math, and the playground comparison are on the [Budget](#) page.

Seattle Parks budget vs. dedicated OLA improvement funding

All values in millions of dollars on a single log-scale axis. **Solid orange diamonds** mark years where SPR publicly disclosed the OLA-only amount. **Hollow orange squares, dashed line** show the combined OLA + P-Patch line; the OLA share inside it is smaller by an undisclosed amount.



Source: [Seattle City Budget Office archives](#) · [Parkways](#) (SPR blog) · [Seattle Park District Cycle 1 & Cycle 2 financial plans](#) · data in [data/budget-detail.csv](#)

Cycle 1 versus Cycle 2 funding, the playgrounds-for-children versus OLAs-for-dogs comparison, and the per-dog spending calculation now live on the [Budget](#) page, in one place.

Most Seattle dogs are unlicensed, and the share is falling.

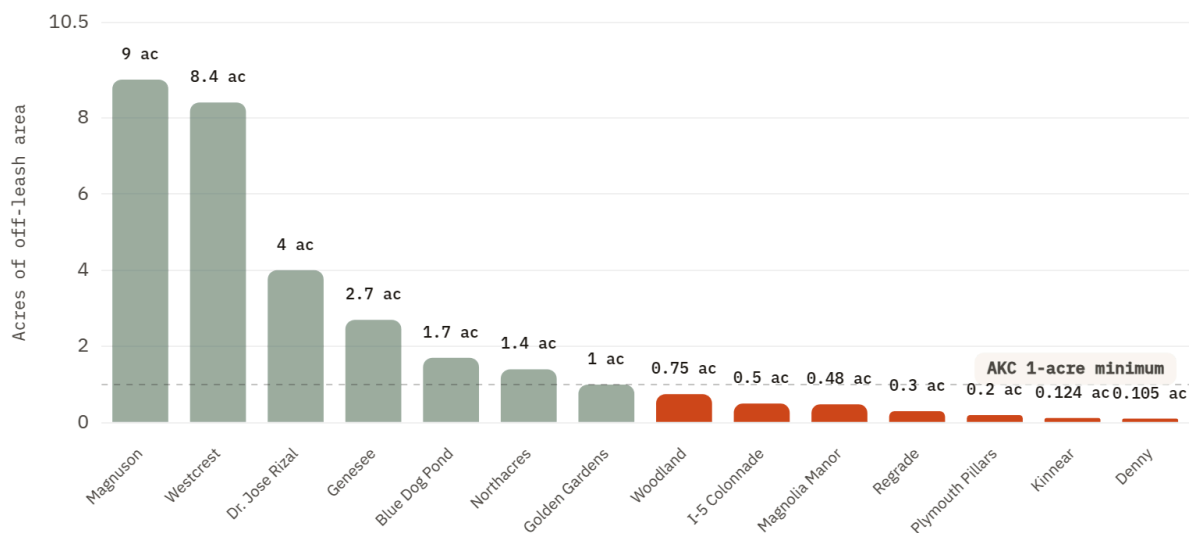
Part of why the dog population is hard to pin down: Seattle licenses only a small fraction of its dogs. About **26,700 dogs** held a current license in the [April 2026 Open Data snapshot](#), which is 7–18% of the 150,000–400,000 population range and about 11% of the site's canonical ~249,000. A 2026 records release from the Seattle Animal Shelter ([PRR C264029](#)) shows licenses issued fell about **21%** from 24,309 in 2014 to 19,219 in 2025 while the city grew. Asked directly, the Shelter holds **no compliance estimate and no dog-population figure of its own**, so the share here is ours.

Half of Seattle's OLAs are under an acre.

The four largest sites hold [~79% of total OLA acreage](#); [Magnuson](#) alone holds nearly a third. Seven of the 14 sit below the [American Kennel Club \(AKC\) 1-acre minimum](#), and the two smallest ([Denny](#) at 0.105 and [Kinneer](#) at 0.124) are roughly a tenth of an acre. What "too small" means in practice is quantified under [size standards](#) in Part II.

OLA acreage concentration

Share of Seattle's ~31 total OLA acres by park. Acreages from SPR's ArcGIS feature service (reconciled April 2026); see [data/seattle-olas.csv](#).



Source: [SPR off-leash area inventory](#) and ArcGIS feature service · data in [data/seattle-olas.csv](#)

11.7%

99% of Seattleites live within a 10-minute walk of a park. 11.7% live within a 10-minute walk of one where dogs are legal.

11.7% of Seattleites are within a 10-minute walk of a legal off-leash area (OLA). 76.6% are within SPR's published 2.5-mile OLA standard. This report measures the gap between "a park" and "a park where dogs are legal."

10-MIN WALK TO ANY PARK

99%

Seattle residents, Trust for Public Land (TPL) 2025 ParkScore.

10-MIN NETWORK WALK TO AN OLA

11.7%

Seattle residents, osmnx network + 2020 Census block groups. src

SEATTLE'S DOG-PARK DENSITY

1.82

Dog parks per 100,000 residents (TPL 2025), below every West Coast peer.

DOG OWNERS REPORTING ILLEGAL OFF-LEASH USE

38%

Blended across settings, per SPR's 2015 survey.

PART ONE

The walkability paradox.

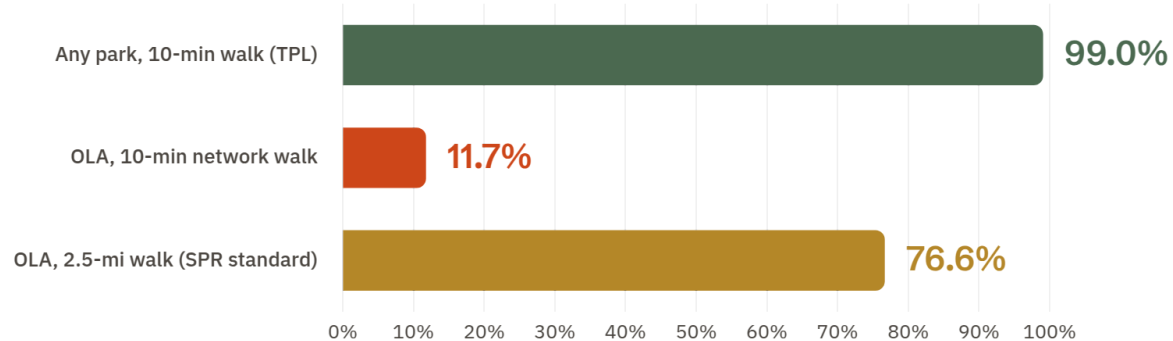
Seattle ranks among the top U.S. cities for park access: 99% of residents live within a 10-minute walk of a park, per TPL's 2025 rankings. Measured the same way, the off-leash system covers 11.7% of residents.

Any park, versus a park where dogs are legal.

[Trust for Public Land's access metric](#) uses a half-mile walk along the street network, the distance most people will walk before driving. By that measure [99% of Seattle residents](#) are within a 10-minute walk of a park. Applying the same measure to the 14 off-leash areas gives [11.7%](#), roughly 86,000 of the city's 738,000 residents in the 2020 Census. SPR's own OLA standard is 2.5 miles, about a 50-minute walk one way, and covers 76.6%. Both OLA figures are modeled here from Seattle's street network and Census block groups (method in [Data notes](#)).

Share of Seattle within a 10-minute walk

All three bars are **population** coverage. TPL's 99% for any park is their published figure. The two OLA bars are computed on this site: an osmnx network walkshed around every OLA ([compute_walkshed.py](#)) intersected with 2020 Census block-group population ([population_coverage.py](#)), area-weighted.



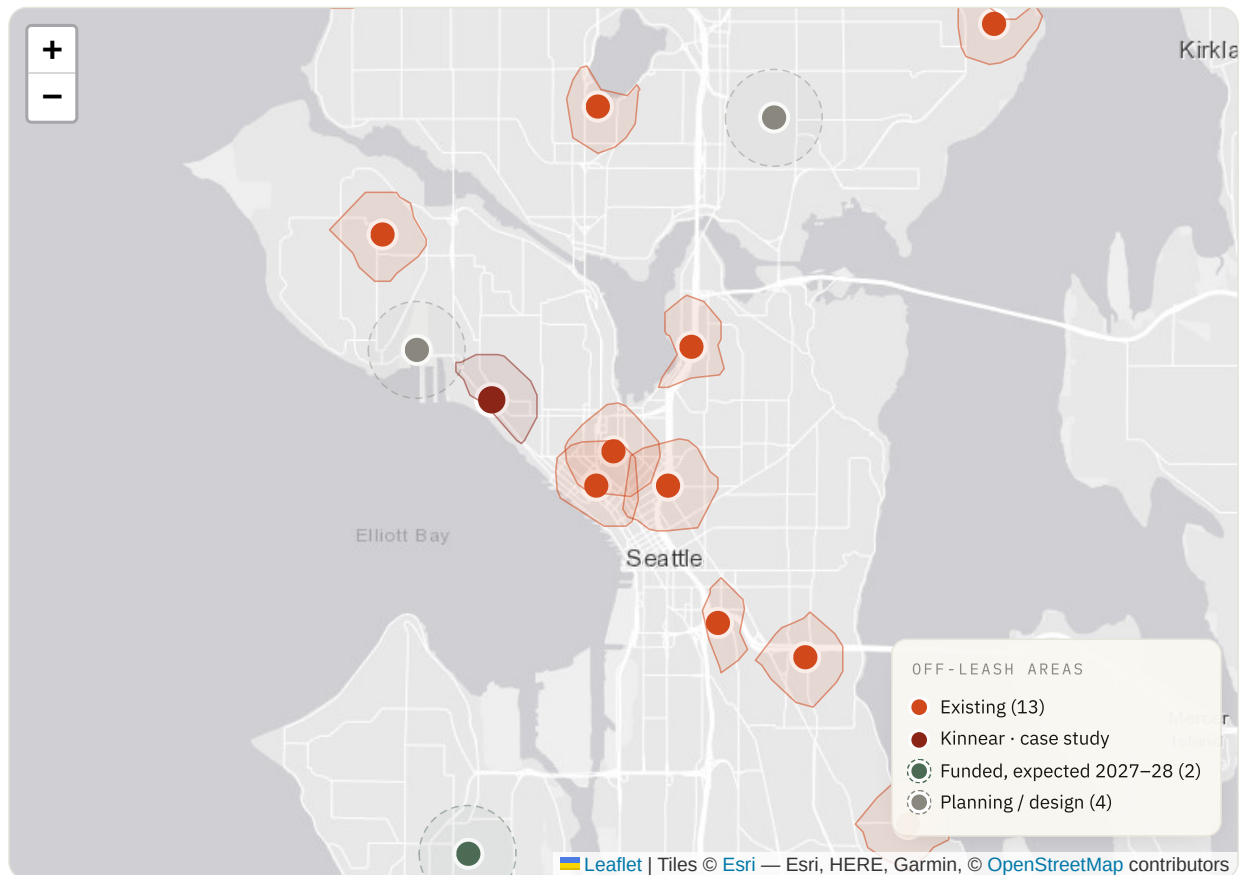
Source: [TPL 2025 ParkScore](#) (all-parks 99%) · OLA walksheds computed in-repo (osmnx + 2020 Census). Full method & scripts in [Data notes](#).

Where the gaps are.

The map shows the 14 existing OLAs with their half-mile walking areas, the two funded sites now expected in [2027 and 2028](#), and four sites in longer-term planning. The walk areas follow the pedestrian street network and stop at barriers such as I-5 and the Ship Canal. Even with all six built, central and north neighborhoods (Ravenna, Wallingford, Green Lake, Phinney, Maple Leaf) remain largely uncovered, and the closest legal OLA for most of Queen Anne and Magnolia stays Kinnear, at 0.124 acres.

Seattle off-leash areas, with half-mile walksheds

Half-mile network walking-distance areas along Seattle's pedestrian street network. Funded and planned sites (walk area not yet computed) are shown as dashed straight-line half-mile circles.



Source: [SPR OLA inventory](#) · [SPR Off-Leash Area Expansion Study \(2023-24\)](#) · [SPR project pages \(archived Sept 2026\)](#) · isochrones from [data/walkshed/ola_isochrones.geojson](#) · map tiles from [Esri](#) / [OpenStreetMap](#) · data in [data/seattle-olas.csv](#) and [data/planned-olas.csv](#)

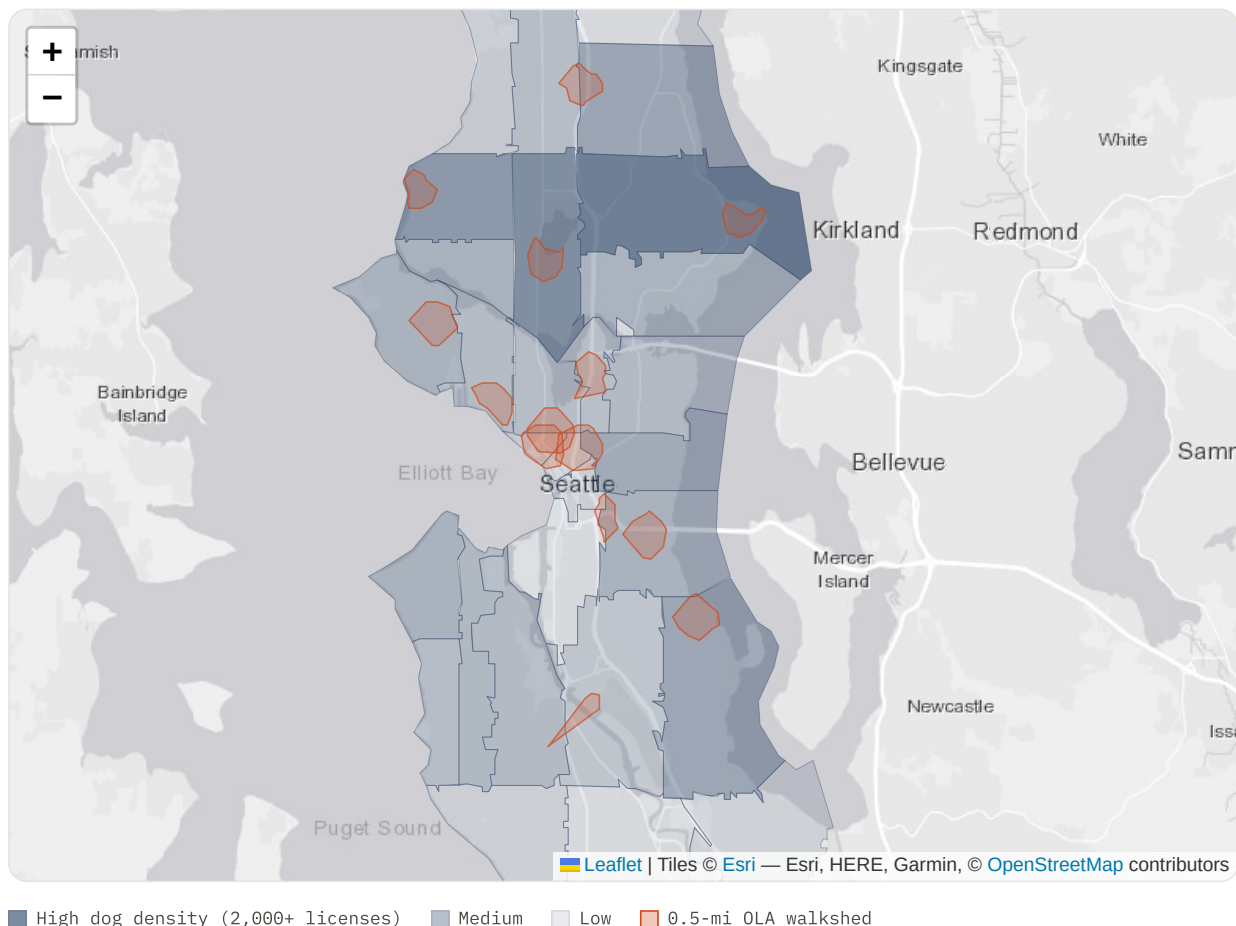
Two independent checks point the same way. **Enforcement:** [71.9%](#) of off-leash enforcement records placed at a geocoded park (2014–2026) fall outside any OLA's 10-minute walkshed, clustering in Capitol Hill, Queen Anne, Wallingford, Maple Leaf, and Ravenna; the analysis is on the [Enforcement](#) page. **Equity:** cross-tabbed against TPL's park-priority index, OLA coverage is highest in the top-priority tier (44%) and lowest in the middle tier (15%), where most of those hotspots sit (method in [Data notes](#)).

Nearly every ZIP is below its fair share of OLA acreage.

Access measures distance. A second measure is whether the acreage inside each ZIP matches the dogs registered there. Joining the ~26,700 active dog licenses ([Seattle Open Data](#), April 2026) to OLA acreage by ZIP, and sizing each ZIP's fair share by its licensed dogs (about one acre per 800 dogs citywide), only four ZIPs sit above their share: Westcrest's (+7.3 ac), Magnuson's (+5.7), Dr. Jose Rizal and Blue Dog Pond's (+4.3), and Genesee's (+0.8). The deepest acre shortfalls are [Fremont / Wallingford / Green Lake \(98103\)](#), [Capitol Hill / Central District \(98122\)](#), [Ballard \(98107\)](#), [Alki / Admiral \(98116\)](#), and the [U District \(98105\)](#); the last four have no OLA acreage at all. Queen Anne (98119) and South Lake Union (98109) rank tenth and twelfth by acres short, but first and second by *dogs per OLA acre*, because each has a single OLA of roughly a tenth of an acre.

Seattle: licensed-dog density × OLA walksheds

ZIP polygons shaded by licensed-dog count (darker navy = more dogs). Orange polygons are the 0.5-mile network walksheds around each OLA. High-density navy without orange is the under-served area.



Source: [Seattle Pet Licenses](#) (April 1 2026) · ZIP polygons [seattleio/seattle-boundaries-data](#) · join via [analyze_pet_licenses.py](#) · ZIP table in [dogs-and-olas-by-zip.csv](#). Method in [Data notes](#).

SOUTH LAKE UNION · 98109

7,876

licensed dogs per OLA acre in SLU / Uptown, the highest ratio in Seattle.

827 licensed dogs. Denny Park's OLA: 0.105 acres, 4,574 sq ft, roughly one basketball court for the neighborhood.

QUEEN ANNE · 98119

7,016

licensed dogs per OLA acre in Queen Anne, second-highest in Seattle.

870 licensed dogs. Kinnear OLA: 0.124 acres, 5,401 sq ft, about one basketball court for the neighborhood.

Licensed-dog counts are floors: [most Seattle dogs are unlicensed](#), so the deficits above understate demand. ZIPs are the finest geography the license dataset provides and don't map cleanly to neighborhoods; labels lead with a primary neighborhood and cite the ZIP. ZIPs that extend past the city line are excluded from the fair-share calculation because OLA acreage is Seattle-only.

PART TWO

Acreage, not just count.

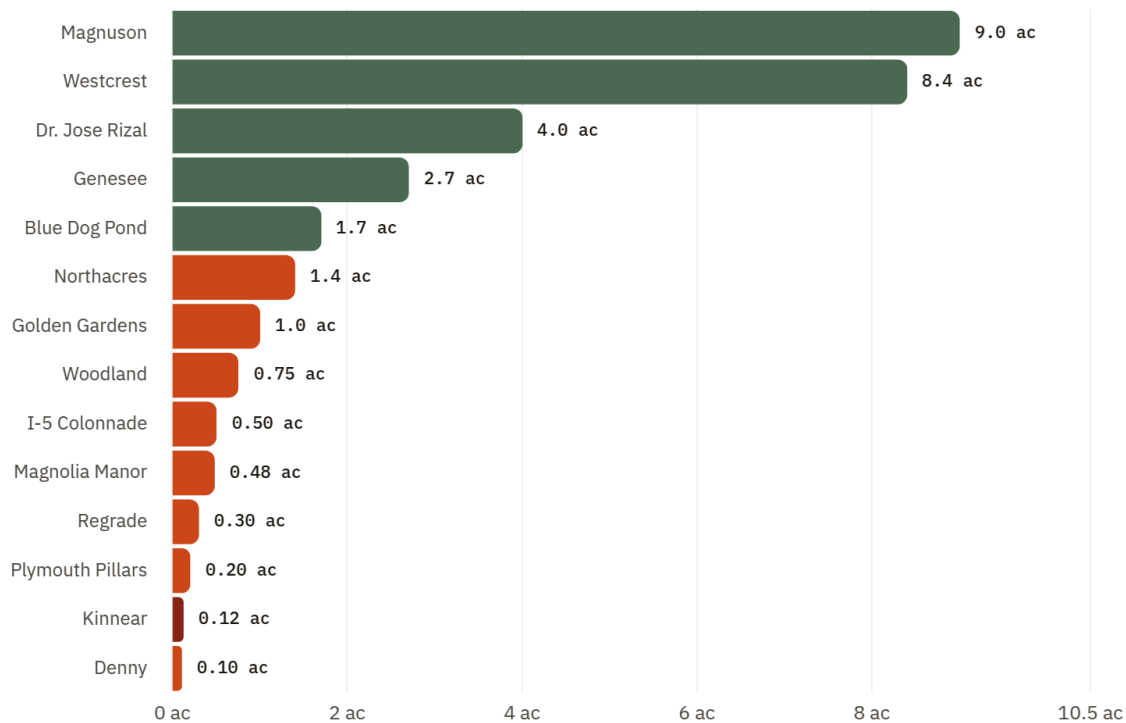
"14 OLAs" is the headline count. Half are under one acre and three are under a quarter-acre; the four largest hold ~79% of the total.

How small is small?

The median Seattle OLA is under one acre. The two smallest, [Denny](#) at 0.105 acres and [Kinnear](#) at 0.124, are each roughly the footprint of a basketball court. The bottom seven together hold under 10% of the city's [~31 OLA acres](#).

Seattle OLA acreage, ranked

Acreages from SPR's Dog Off-Leash Areas ArcGIS feature service (April 2026), cross-checked against SPR site pages and the OLA Expansion Study.

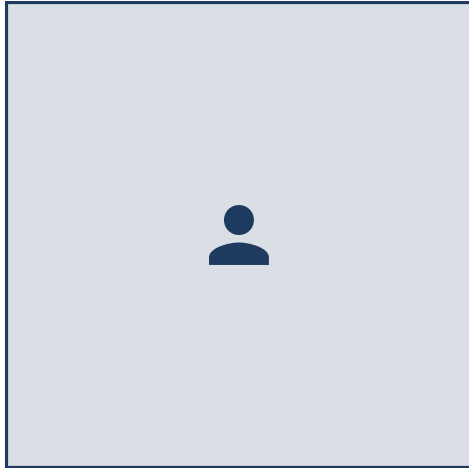


Source: [SPR OLA inventory and ArcGIS feature service](#) · [SPR OLA Expansion Study 2023-24](#) · data in [data/seattle-olas.csv](#)

Space per resident, space per dog.

Divide Seattle's parkland by its people, and its OLA footprint by its dogs, and draw both at the same scale.

DRAWN TO SCALE • 1 PX = ~0.4 SQ FT



EVERY SEATTLE RESIDENT'S SHARE OF PARKLAND

355 sq ft

About the footprint of a small studio apartment



EVERY SEATTLE DOG'S SHARE OF OLA

5.4 sq ft

About the footprint of a doormat

A Seattle resident has roughly **66× more parkland per person** than a Seattle dog has dedicated off-leash space per dog. At the conservative 150,000-dog floor the ratio is **40×**. Dogs are allowed in Seattle parks on leash; the comparison is off-leash space only, and 99.5% of the city's parkland is off-limits to off-leash dogs.

Math: 6,662 ac total parkland ([TPL 2025 ParkScore Seattle](#)) ÷ 816,600 residents (WA Office of Financial Management (OFM) 2025) = 0.00816 ac/resident = 355 sq ft. 30.7 ac OLA total ([seattle-olas.csv](#)) ÷ 248,858 American Veterinary Medical Association (AVMA)-estimated dogs ([illegal-use-indicators.csv](#)) = 5.37 sq ft/dog. Ratio 355/5.37 = 66.1.

Amenities: lighting, water, small-dog areas

What the 14 OLAs offer beyond a fence. The water figure is the City's own; the lighting figure comes from a 2021 user survey and has not been confirmed by SPR.

HAVE WATER ACCESS

1 of 14

"Only one OLA provides water," the Finance and Administrative Services department told the City Council in June 2022 ([PRR C266465](#), Bates 00524). The one is Magnuson.

HAVE LIGHTING

3 of 14

Plymouth Pillars, Regrade, Golden Gardens, per a [2021 COLA user survey](#). Unverified by SPR; fall and winter evenings after work are unusable at the rest.

HAVE SMALL-DOG AREAS

5 of 14

Magnuson, Westcrest, Genesee, Golden Gardens, Magnolia Manor, per [seattle-olas.csv](#) (SPR ArcGIS attributes).

Source: FAS SLI response to Council, June 30 2022 (PRR C266465, Bates PKS_C266465_01_00524) · [sources/nextdoor-qa-playfield-2021.md](#) · [data/seattle-olas.csv](#)

What "too small" means, quantified

Three independent authorities publish overlapping standards for the size of a functioning neighborhood dog park and the per-dog capacity a park of a given size can support.

AKC RECOMMENDATION

≥ 1 acre

Minimum size with 4–6 ft fence, per [American Kennel Club \(AKC\) *Establishing a Dog Park in Your Community*](#).

INDUSTRY DESIGN CONSENSUS

1–5 acres

Community dog-park sizing, with 1 acre as the practical floor. Per [Parks & Rec Business](#) and municipal design guidelines ([Ann Arbor](#), [Fairfax County](#)).

PER-DOG CAPACITY

75–100 sq ft

Recommended planning density at peak use. Below this, injury and behavioral-conflict risk rise. [Dog Park Size Guide](#).

Applied to Seattle: **seven of 14 OLAs are below the AKC 1-acre floor**, and three are below a quarter-acre. At 100 sq ft per dog, Kinnear (~5,400 sq ft) implies a peak of about **54 dogs** and Denny (~4,600 sq ft) about **46**. SPR signage at Kinnear asks owners with more than three dogs to use another OLA. Kinnear is the closest designated OLA for most of Queen Anne, though most of the hill lies outside its 10-minute walkshed.

ON THE GROUND AT KINNEAR · JULY 2019

Park signage asking 3+-dog owners to use another OLA.	Park entrance, July 2019. Encampment tarp visible (intermittent).	Tent against the OLA's back fence (July 2019); intermittent.
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Photos by Andre Vrignaud, July 2019. Click any image to view full size. The site's 20-year incident record is in the [Kinnear timeline CSV](#) (Seattle Weekly 2007, Seattle Times 2008, KOMO 2025).

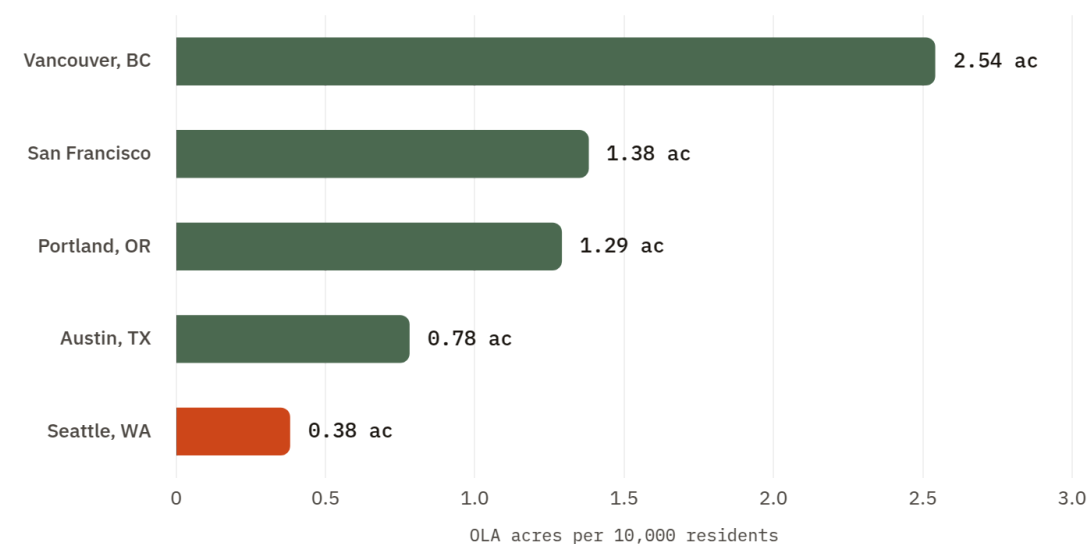
Sources: [AKC](#) · [Parks & Rec Business](#) · [Ann Arbor Dog Park Guidelines](#) · [FCPA Dog Park Standards](#) · [Seattle OLA acreage from data/seattle-olas.csv](#)

Peer-city acreage per resident.

Comparing OLA acreage across cities is harder than comparing counts, because cities define "off-leash" differently: Portland's 38 sites are mostly unfenced voice-control areas, San Francisco's 42 include small dog play areas inside larger parks, Vancouver BC's 36 include time-restricted beaches and fields, and Seattle counts only dedicated sites (12 fully fenced, two partially). On a best-effort, methodology-adjusted basis Seattle sits at the bottom of the five-city set: Vancouver BC has about [6.7×](#) Seattle's OLA acreage per resident, San Francisco 3.6×, Portland 3.4×. The per-city detail, governance, and funding models are on the [Peer Cities](#) page; the adjustments are in [Data notes](#).

OLA acres per 10,000 residents, methodology-adjusted

Excludes outlier off-leash hiking areas (Thousand Acres OR, Walnut Creek TX). Vancouver BC includes time-restricted beach/field access. Austin uses its ~80 fenced acres.



Source: SPR OLA inventory · Portland Parks & Recreation DOLA list · SF Rec & Parks DPA list · Vancouver Park Board People, Parks & Dogs Strategy (2017) · peer-city numbers in [data/peer-cities.csv](#)

PART THREE

Illegal off-leash use: what the data shows.

Three sources bear on the scale of illegal off-leash use: SPR's 2015 owner survey, Find-It-Fix-It complaints, and the City's own enforcement agency, which told the Council in 2022 why it happens.

What Seattle's own data says.

OWNERS ADMITTING ILLEGAL OFF-LEASH USE

38%

Blended from [SPR's 2015 survey](#) (p. 17): 39% in local parks and 38% in large parks (weekly to monthly), 36% on park trails.

FIND-IT-FIX-IT NUISANCE-DOG REPORTS, 2025

3,010

"Nuisance Dogs in a Park" complaints, first full year of the record ([PRR C263990](#)), roughly 11 per off-leash enforcement record that year. Analysis on [Enforcement](#).

OFF-LEASH CITATIONS, MAR-AUG 2016

543

Citations issued over the first six months of the full-time patrol program ([enforcement-citations.csv](#), [PRR C049204](#)).

In 2015, as part of the research behind the *People, Dogs and Parks Plan*, SPR surveyed 3,970 dog owners; about 38% admitted illegal off-leash use, a self-reported figure given to the enforcing agency and likely an undercount. Residents now file about 3,000 "Nuisance Dogs in a Park" complaints a year. The complaint category was only created in 2024, so there is no longer trend to read; the [Enforcement](#) page sets complaint volume against enforcement output over the overlapping months.

FAS DIRECTOR TO THE CITY COUNCIL, JUNE 2022

"The lack of available Off Leash Areas could encourage pet owners to take their dogs off leash in regular City parks where other park users are affected." ... "Dog owners consistently share with SAS that OLAs aren't within walking distance and are overcrowded." — [FAS response to Council Statement of Legislative Intent FAS-003-B-001](#) (PRR C266465, Bates 00524)

That is the City's enforcement agency stating the supply explanation, not this site inferring it. The same report told Council that "achieving compliance ... requires a holistic approach, involving enforcement, an increase in Off Leash Areas and more robust educational campaigns," and that without a legal option nearby, owners weigh a 25-minute drive against the park down the street. The [enforcement records](#) show the result: contacts concentrate in neighborhoods without a nearby OLA, or where the OLA that exists is a tenth of an acre.

Kinnear Park.

Queen Anne's only nearby OLA is Seattle's second-smallest, at 0.124 acres (only Denny, at 0.105, is smaller). At the bottom of a hillside greenbelt on the southwest slope of Queen Anne Hill, it is the closest legal off-leash option for most of Queen Anne and large parts of Magnolia, home to tens of thousands of residents and roughly 2,000 licensed dogs across the two ZIPs. Approved in 2007, it opened in 2013 and was made permanent in 2014. In SPR's own 2016 capital-priority list it is ranked [LOW](#), with \$6,000–\$11,000 of identified need.

0.124 ac **20+ yrs**

FENCED AREA

INCIDENT RECORD

CONTEXT

A small OLA with long-running site-adjacent issues.

Kinnear's OLA is at the far side of Lower Kinnear Park from the parking lot and main entrance. The park has been the site of documented encampment activity and clearance cycles for over 20 years; the record is in [kinnear-timeline.csv](#).

2000

Kinnear is not included in Seattle's \$198 million Pro Parks Levy.

1999 & 2003

Beating deaths reported in Lower Kinnear. Quoted in 2007 Seattle Weekly feature: “Everyone in Queen Anne knows that lower Kinnear Park is just a place you don't go because it's not safe.”

2007

A new dog run is approved for Kinnear, the 12th in the city. Initial reporting notes two issues: no construction funding, and “the area just below where the dog run is supposed to be situated is currently occupied by regular encampments of the homeless.”

2008

City crews clear the Queen Anne greenbelt near Kinnear over multiple days, filling multiple garbage trucks. SPR spokesperson Dewey Potter to the Seattle Times: “We try to be as laissez-faire as we can. Because life is tough with these folks. We try to look the other way.”

2013–14

The OLA opens (2013) and is made permanent (2014), per SPR's 2017 plan.

2020

Dog-owner review notes the encampment along the access path: “You have to walk past it to get to the off-leash area and we didn't feel super safe doing so... I would recommend not going when it's dark and not going alone.”

2023

Investigative reporting identifies Kinnear as part of a “hidden encampment network” in Seattle's wooded parks.

APRIL 2025

City clears a Kinnear encampment. Tents reappear within days. KOMO News: “It's unclear how many people were living in the park this time, but the garbage left behind is extensive.”

MAY 2025

Memorial Day cleanup: ~100 volunteers remove an estimated 10,000 lbs of trash from Kinnear and the adjacent greenbelt.

Implications for access counts. Kinnear is counted as Queen Anne's OLA in SPR's gap analysis. Many Queen Anne dog owners drive to Magnuson or Magnolia Manor instead, or use Kerry Park, Rodgers Park, Queen Anne Bowl, or nearby school playfields, where off-

leash use is not authorized. Plymouth Pillars (Capitol Hill), Denny Park (SLU), and Regrade (Belltown) sit in or adjacent to similar site-safety patterns. The nominal count of 14 assumes all 14 are practically functional for their neighborhoods.



What works, and what Seattle *hasn't tried*.

Parts I and II document the supply gap and the access gap. Part III looks forward through three questions: which of Seattle's existing off-leash areas (OLAs) function well and why, what shared-use looks like in cities that have run it for decades, and what public land outside Seattle Parks' portfolio could host off-leash space without new Park District dollars.

SECTION 3A

01

What works

Three Seattle OLAs that draw sustained community support, and what they share.

SECTION 3B

02

Shared-use

The off-leash-hours model: what New York's record shows, and what it doesn't.

SECTION 3C

03

Non-SPR land

WSDOT, Seattle City Light, Port of Seattle: public land SPR does not manage but Seattle hosts.

What works: three OLAs with a steward, a structure, and room.

The [Enforcement](#) data shows where the system is failing. Three of Seattle's 14 OLAs show what holds up, and all three have organizational structure behind them: a site-specific nonprofit at Magnuson (now dormant), system-wide stewardship by COLA at Genesee, and a recent Park District-funded renovation at Westcrest. Each has enough physical area to absorb demand (9.0, 2.7 and 8.4 acres against Kinnear's 0.124). Part II measured distance. What separates these three is size and stewardship.

Magnuson — the site-specific steward model, now dormant

ACRES

9.0

Largest OLA in Seattle; includes Lake Washington shoreline; the only OLA with water access per [FAS to Council, 2022](#)

OPENED

1996 / 1999

1996 pilot trial · 1999 permanent designation · former NAS Sand Point

STEWARD

MOLG

Volunteer group formed 1999, 501(c)(3) since 2011 (EIN 91-2059268); public presence now dark

Magnuson is a structural outlier on land area, physical features (shoreline, gravel paths, woods), and governance. For roughly two decades it was stewarded by the Magnuson Off-Leash Group (MOLG), an all-volunteer 501(c)(3) that raised donations, ran volunteer maintenance days, and partnered formally with Seattle Parks, the closest Seattle parallel to the Portland or San Francisco "dog park friends" model. MOLG's website and public presence have since gone dark (last visible activity late 2023), so the site-specific model it represented is, for now, dormant.

The 367 citations logged at Magnuson 2014–2026 ([Enforcement top-20](#)) count the whole park. Magnuson is the biggest park with the biggest footprint and draws traffic from across the region, and the enforcement records name the park, not the fence, so they cannot say how many contacts were inside the OLA versus on the athletic fields and shoreline outside it.

DATA GAP

Still open: MOLG's records from its active years (IRS 990s, the MOLG–SPR memorandum, any usage counts); confirmation of the group's current status.

SOURCES · [SPR: Magnuson Off-Leash Area](#) · [HistoryLink: June 15, 1996 trial opening](#) · [data/seattle-olas.csv](#)

Genesee — the COLA-steward model

ACRES

2.7

Fourth-largest Seattle OLA; small-dog area separated

OPENED

1999

Genesee Park & Playfield, Columbia City / Rainier Valley, per [SPR's 2017 plan](#)

STEWARD

COLA

[Citizens for Off-Leash Areas](#), 501(c)(3), SPR's system-wide partner since the 1990s

[COLA](#) is the system-wide advocacy and stewardship group for Seattle's OLAs, and Genesee is one of the sites where its volunteer stewardship is most visible. SPR's 2017 plan credits COLA with the initial list of pilot sites for the 1996–97 program and records a standing umbrella agreement with the group dating from the late 1990s; steward volunteers continue to show up at Genesee, Westcrest, and other OLAs. Where MOLG was site-specific, COLA works across the whole system.

Genesee's physical design has held up: a separated small-dog area, multiple gates, drainage that handles Seattle winters. The 152 citations logged there 2014–2026 name Genesee Park & Playfield as a whole, athletic fields included, not the OLA.

DATA GAP

Still open: COLA organizational documents (current board, current SPR memorandum); verified quotes from Genesee users on what works about the site and what does not.

SOURCES · [Citizens for Off-Leash Areas \(seattlecola.info\)](#) · [SPR People, Dogs & Parks Plan \(2017\)](#), pp. 11 and 27 · [Seattle City Council blog \(2011\) on COLA](#) · [SPR: Genesee OLA](#)

Westcrest — the recent-investment model

ACRES

8.4

Second-largest OLA; 2021–2022 renovation

INVESTMENT

\$505,000

Park District Major Maintenance & Asset Management Fund, 2021–2022

PARTNERS

HPAC + COLA

Highland Park Action Committee on-site; COLA credited for ongoing stewardship

The [2021–2022 Park District renovation](#) at Westcrest addressed drainage, erosion control, access and parking, and accessibility, reopening June 10, 2022. Scope was maintenance-driven, not a rebuild: rock-lined swales, piping and outfalls, sediment traps, regraded high-use areas, accessible pathways. Community input came through the Highland Park Action Committee; ongoing stewardship is credited to COLA. Its 122 enforcement-data citations 2014–2026 are lower than the four biggest host parks¹.

DATA GAP

Still open: post-renovation usage or satisfaction data.

SOURCES · [Parkways blog \(June 13, 2022\): reopening and scope](#) · [SPR: Westcrest Park](#) · [Highland Park Action Committee](#)

WHAT SPR ITSELF HAS NAMED

SPR's own 2016 capital-priority list ([PRR C266465](#), [Bates 00168](#)) priced \$1.15M–\$2.22M of deferred work across the 14 OLAs in 2016 dollars, against Park District OLA maintenance of \$103,000–\$117,000 a year. In its February 2024 Expansion Study deck ([Bates 00416](#)), SPR named Capitol Hill, Ballard and Northgate as unaddressed gaps and listed East Queen Anne Playfield as a recommended future site, pending field-scheduling discussions with the community. Those are SPR's words, not this site's.

Shared-use: the off-leash-hours model.

Several U.S. cities designate time-windowed off-leash access in existing parks rather than building new fenced OLAs. New York has run it formally since 2007 and informally since roughly 1986. Adopting it in Seattle would change the coverage figure without new capital.

New York City: formal since 2007, functional longer

NYC Parks [codified its Off-Leash Hours policy on April 10, 2007](#). In designated areas of participating parks, licensed and vaccinated dogs may be off-leash from park opening until 9:00 AM and from 9:00 PM until park closing; normal leash rules apply otherwise ([NYC Parks](#)). It runs alongside NYC's fenced dog runs, not instead of them, and the off-leash footprint, sections of Central, Prospect, Riverside and Van Cortlandt plus dozens of neighborhood parks across all five boroughs ([directory](#)), dwarfs Seattle's 14 fenced OLAs.

NYC publishes no longitudinal evaluation of the policy: no official citation, complaint, or injury tracking. What stands in for it is longevity, nineteen years of formal operation renewed through administrations with different parks politics, and no reversal. The National Recreation and Park Association treated it as the mature U.S. example in a November 2018 *Parks & Recreation* law review; Boston and Chicago run parallel time-based systems, and Chicago's fenced Dog-Friendly Areas sit alongside them. None of this proves clean transfer to Seattle, with its different density, topography, rainfall, enforcement institutions, and parks-homelessness dynamics. What it shows is that a city of eight million has run time-zoned shared-use for nearly twenty years without catastrophic failure.

DATA GAP

Still open: NYC Parks operational data on off-leash-hours enforcement, injury and complaint statistics 2007–present; Boston and Chicago operational documents; any city that formally evaluated a similar policy.

RELEVANCE TO SEATTLE

Seattle's 14 OLAs cover 11.7% of residents within a 10-minute walk ([Part II](#)). Time-windowed access to existing large parks such as Green Lake, Volunteer Park, Lincoln Park, Seward Park and Discovery Park would change that figure without the multi-year capital timelines of new dedicated OLAs.

SOURCES · [NYC Parks Dog Friendly Areas](#) · [NYC Parks 2007 press release](#) · [NYC Public Advocate directory](#)

Non-SPR land: public space SPR does not manage.

Seattle's OLA supply is bounded by SPR's real-estate portfolio, but two existing OLAs already sit on other agencies' land: I-5 Colonnade on WSDOT right-of-way and Magnolia Manor on a Seattle Public Utilities reservoir site, and SPR's 2017 plan records two City Light sites considered in the 1996–97 pilot ([pp. 11–12](#)). The precedent exists; what's missing is an inventory. COLA raised this in its comments on SPR's 2023 Off-Leash Area Expansion Study, which did not consider non-SPR public land.

WSDOT: state highway right-of-way

WSDOT manages land adjacent to every state-numbered road in the city. Some is unusable (active lanes, on-ramps), but a portion is landscaped setback, substantially fenced, and distant from traffic. I-5 Colonnade, under I-5 on WSDOT land, is the functioning precedent.

DATA GAP

Still open: inventory of WSDOT-managed parcels inside city limits that could host off-leash use without a lane closure; WSDOT's formal policy on recreational use of right-of-way; the I-5 Colonnade agreement as a template.

Seattle City Light and SPU: corridors and utility property

City Light owns transmission corridors across the city, several already hosting informal recreation (walking trails, community gardens); they are typically fenced, signed, and maintained on a schedule. SPU's Magnolia Manor site shows a utility parcel can host an OLA outright.

DATA GAP

Still open: City Light's recreational-use policy for transmission corridors; identified corridors with at least one acre of contiguous flat ground; the Magnolia Manor SPU–SPR arrangement as a template.

Port of Seattle: waterfront and industrial-adjacent

The Port owns substantial waterfront property. Most is industrial and security-restricted, but edge parcels (landscape buffer, parking, unused waterfront) may be compatible with off-leash use within the Port's operational constraints.

DATA GAP

Still open: Port asset inventory inside city limits; the Port's public-access policy; precedent for Port–SPR partnerships on recreational use.

FRAMING OBSERVATION

Framed as "where can SPR build a new OLA on SPR land?" the answer is a multi-decade capital cycle. Framed as "where inside city limits is there public land where dogs could be off-leash without a new capital project?" the answer involves agencies SPR has partnered with before, on two of the existing 14.

Open lines for primary source material.

Each section above names the primary sources that would strengthen it. Materials on any of the three, Magnuson stewardship records, NYC, Boston or Chicago operational data, or WSDOT, City Light and Port recreational-use policies, can be submitted via the [project issue tracker](#). The [Opinion page](#) is where the policy argument lives; this page documents the case studies and the options.

13 years of off-leash enforcement in Seattle:

rising cost, falling output.

Seattle Animal Control's records cover 13 years of off-leash ("Dog Loose in Park," DLP) enforcement: 7,015 contacts, of which 3,151 were citations and 3,191 verbal warnings. Contacts peaked in 2018 and never recovered; actual citations fell 95% from 2018 to 2024. From 2023 the City was billed for three officers on invoices computed from a calendar, while the staffing agency reported it could field one and a half to two. And in ten years the City has produced no evaluation of whether any of it changes behavior: both agencies, asked directly, hold none.

SOURCE: SEATTLE ANIMAL CONTROL PRRS [C049204](#) (2014–2018) AND [C263949](#) (2019–2026-04-17) · STAFFING AND COST: THE [2016, 2021, 2023, 2025 AND 2026 MEMORANDA OF AGREEMENT \(MOAS\)](#) AND THE SPR DECISION RECORD AND LEDGER BACKUP IN [PRR C266465](#) · DEPLOYMENT STATUS: [AXIOS SEATTLE, APRIL 2026](#) · COORDINATES APPROXIMATE FROM PARK NAMES

THREE NUMBERS THAT ARE EASY TO CONFLATE: FUNDED, BILLED, DEPLOYED.

Funded. The Seattle Park District approved three park-patrol officers in **2023**, a maximum of \$454,652/year, re-priced to **\$528,279** by the 2026 MOA. **Billed.** The 2023 agreement charged a flat 240 hours per pay period for three officers regardless of hours worked, and SPR's ledger shows it paid accordingly: **\$456,173 in 2024** and \$226,528 in the first half of 2023, on invoices built from the number of weekdays in each month ([PRR C266465 ledger](#)). Only the 2025 MOA switched to billing on actual hours. **Deployed.** Seattle Animal Shelter told SPR in February 2025 it could commit "closer to 2 FTEs," possibly 1.5 ([Bates 00541](#)); as of April 2026 SPR said one officer was working parks with two still being hired ([Axios](#)); and parks are a minority of these officers' work (33% of calls in 2021). The maintenance worker the program was designed to pair with each officer left in 2023 and was never replaced ([SPR memo, Sept 2024](#)).

So for 2023–24 the City paid for three officers it did not field. Through July 2026 this page said the three-officer ceiling had not been reached; the ledger released that month shows it was exceeded in 2024. The funded-versus-deployed gap is real; the money was spent anyway. Wherever this page shows program cost, 2023–24 is what SPR was billed, and every other year is the one-officer deployment model described in the [cost note](#).

7,015

“Dog Loose in Park” (DLP) contacts: **3,151 citations, 3,191 verbal warnings**, 673 blank, voided or dismissed. Warnings appear in the record only from 2018. [src](#)

84–96%

Share of citations that are 1st offenses. The mix never shifted toward repeat offenders.

–95%

441 citations in 2018, 21 in 2024, 23 in 2025. Total contacts fell less (1,276 → 447, then 267) because most contacts now end in a verbal warning.

\$456_K

\$456,173 on calendar-derived invoices, while the staffing agency said it could field 1.5–2 and about one worked parks. See the cost note above.



WHAT THIS PAGE FOUND

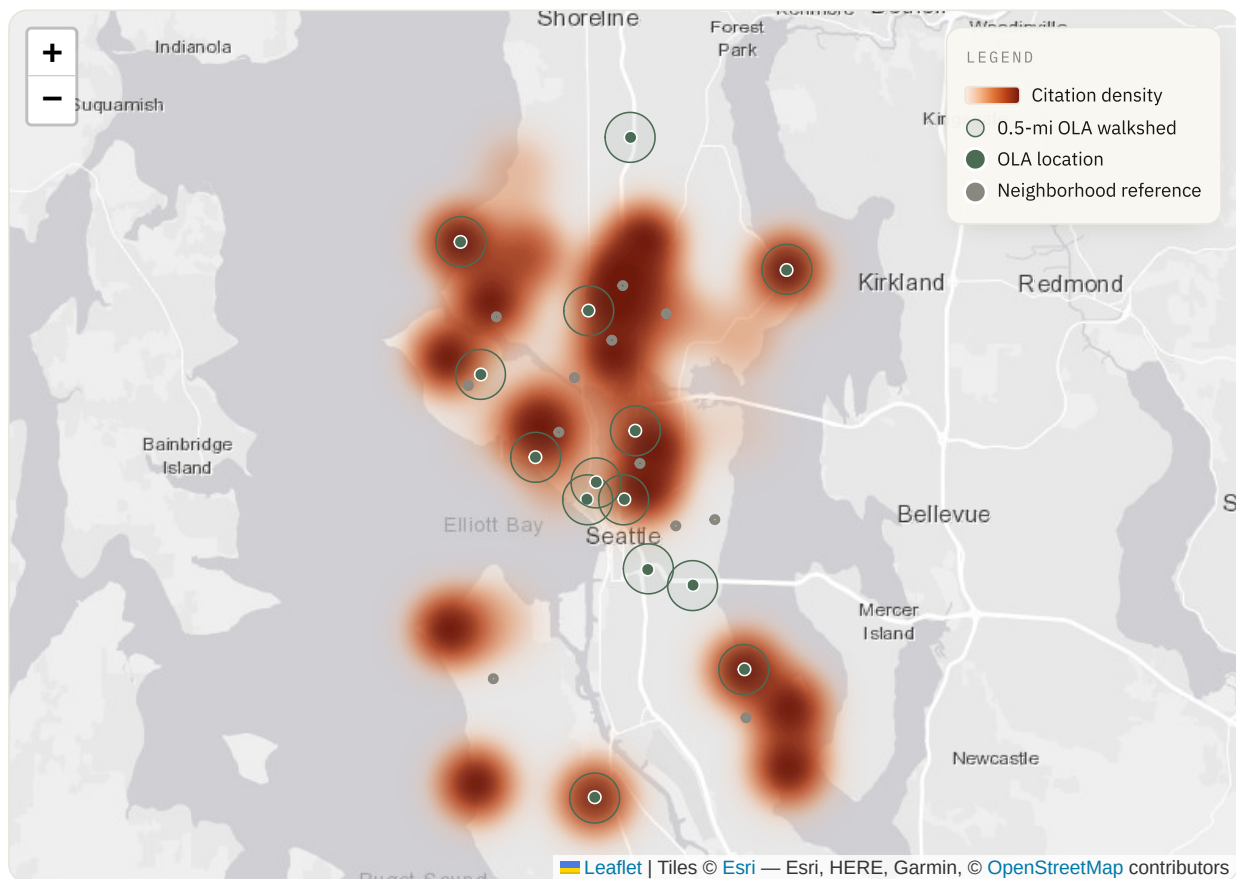
- **Contacts fell and never recovered; actual citations collapsed.** Off-leash (“Dog Loose in Park”) contacts peaked at 1,276 in 2018; the best year since (2024) reached 447. Citations, as distinct from verbal warnings, went from 441 to 21. [↓ cost and output](#)
- **Cost per citation keeps rising.** Fee revenue (\$294,885 over 13 years) has covered ~9% of the program’s ~\$3.38M cost; the cost per contact ran \$229 in 2018 and \$1,021 in 2024, and the cost per actual citation \$663 and \$21,723. [↓ cost and output](#)
- **The city paid for three officers it did not field.** Billed \$456,173 in 2024 on calendar-derived invoices for three officers; the staffing agency said it could supply 1.5–2. [↓ funded, billed, deployed](#)
- **Officers can’t compel ID, so most contacts end in a warning**, which caps citation output no matter how many officers patrol. [↓ funded, billed, deployed](#)
- **Contacts cluster where there’s no nearby legal off-leash area**, and residents now file about 11 complaints for every contact. [↓ geography and complaints](#)
- **Nobody has measured whether any of it works.** Asked directly, neither SPR nor the Animal Shelter holds an evaluation; the one internal review recommended cutting the program, and leadership overrode it. [↓ what the City never measured](#)

Enforcement concentrates in the areas without a walkable off-leash area.

The clearest single picture of this program. Citation density is overlaid on the half-mile walksheds around every existing off-leash area (OLA), the [Trust for Public Land 10-minute-walk standard](#). The heat sits where the coverage does not. Everything after this section is the cost, the output and the record behind it.

Citation density and 0.5-mile OLA walksheds

Heat = DLP citation density (a smoothed heat surface across geocoded park locations, weighted by citation count). Green rings = 0.5-mile walksheds around each of the 14 OLAs. Green dots = OLA locations. Grey dots = neighborhood reference points.



Sources: [enforcement-citations.csv](#) · [seattle-olas.csv](#) · walksheds per [TPL ParkScore](#) · [Leaflet.heat](#) · tiles: [Esri](#) / [OpenStreetMap](#)

OBSERVATION

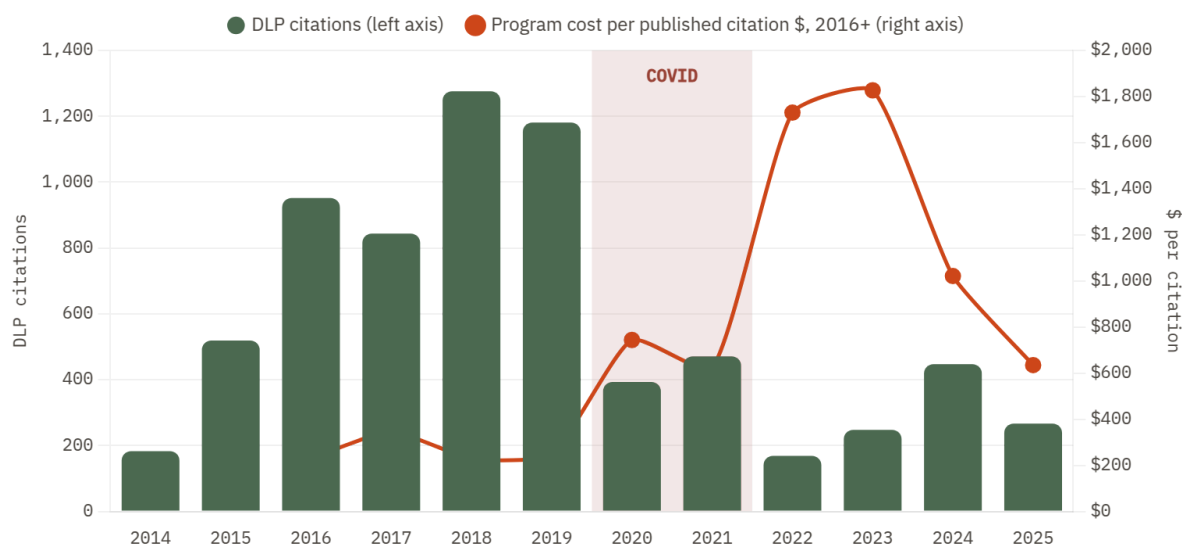
Citation density concentrates outside OLA walksheds. North of the Ship Canal (Wallingford, Ravenna, Maple Leaf, Green Lake and Laurelhurst) shows heavy density with little walkable OLA coverage. The Queen Anne / Magnolia core has Kinnear (0.124 acre) and Magnolia Manor (0.48 acre), both below the [AKC one-acre minimum](#), and a citation band through Discovery, West Queen Anne Playfield, and Smith Cove. Lincoln Park (West Seattle) carries 173 cumulative citations; the nearest OLA, Westcrest, is [3.4 miles](#) away.

Contacts fell, citations collapsed, and the cost of each one rose.

Two things happened to the program's output. Total enforcement contacts fell well below their 2018 peak and stayed there. And within those contacts, the share that were actual citations, rather than \$0 verbal warnings, fell from about a third in 2018 to under 5% by 2024, because officers cannot compel identification and now warn on every first contact ([detail](#)). Set against what the program cost, one officer and a maintenance worker through 2022 and the billed three-officer invoices from 2023, the cost per contact rose from \$229 to \$1,021 and the cost per actual citation from \$663 to \$21,723. The lines below are ratios (annual program cost ÷ that year's contacts or citations), not the price of writing one ticket.

DLP citations vs. program cost per published citation, 2014-2025

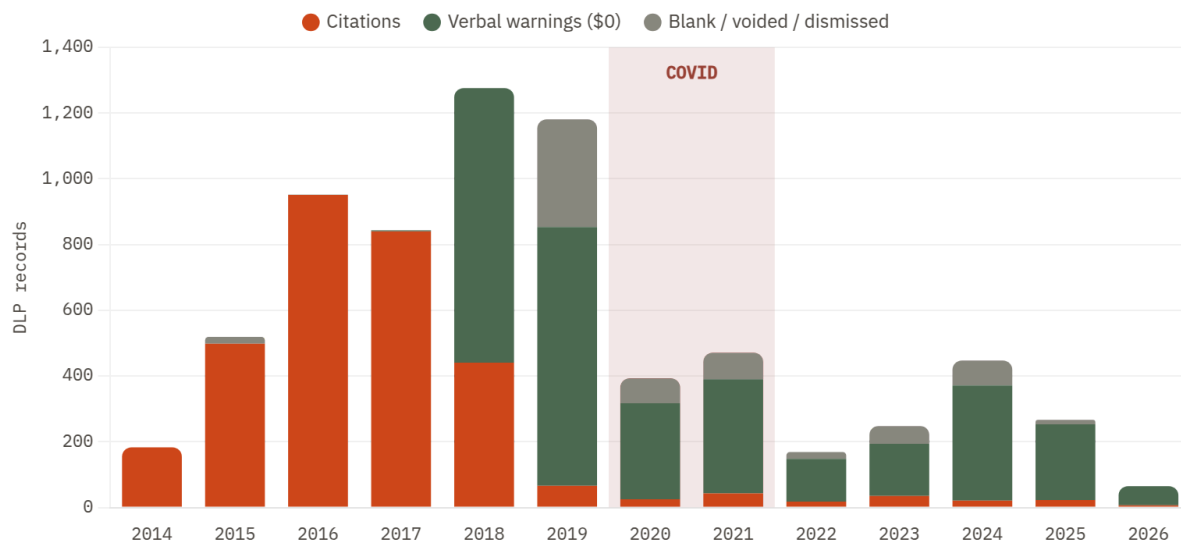
Green bars (left axis): DLP enforcement contacts per year, 2014–2025. Orange line (right axis): annual program cost ÷ that year's contacts. Cost basis: 2016–2022, one Animal Control Officer at the 2021 MOA rate plus a paired Facilities Maintenance Worker (author estimate); 2023–2024, what SPR was actually billed for three officers; 2025, one officer at the 2025 MOA rate (ledger not produced). The line begins in 2016, the first year with a documented cost basis. COVID period shaded; 2026 is partial and omitted. All dollars nominal.



Contacts: [enforcement-citations.csv](#) · cost: [2021 MOA Attachment A](#) (\$152,399/yr per ACO II), [SPR ledger backup 2023-24](#) (PRR C266465), 2025 MOA (\$169,565/yr per ACO II) · FMW pairing ~\$140,000/yr through 2022 (author estimate) · model and per-year values in [enforcement-year-metrics.csv](#)

Citations vs. verbal warnings, 2014-2026

Each year's DLP contacts split by recorded result. Orange = citation issued. Green = verbal warning (\$0). Grey = blank, voided or dismissed. Verbal warnings first appear in the 2018 records; the 2014–2017 files (PRR C049204) record citations only, so the absence of warnings there means unrecorded, not zero. 2026 partial-year.



Source: case_result in enforcement-citations.csv · per-year split in enforcement-year-metrics.csv

OBSERVATION

Across 2014-2026, fee revenue (\$294,885 cumulative, off-lease violations only) covered roughly 9% of the program's estimated \$3.38M cost. Cost per contact was lowest in the peak-output years (\$229 in 2018) and highest in the trough (\$1,730 in 2022); 2024's recovery to 447 contacts (35% of the 2018 peak), priced at what SPR was actually billed that year, still comes to \$1,021. Cost per actual citation is the sharper series: \$663 in 2018, \$16,244 in 2022, \$21,723 in 2024, \$7,372 in 2025. The 2023-24 figures are real invoices for three officers, not a model; how that came about is just below.

ON COST RECOVERY

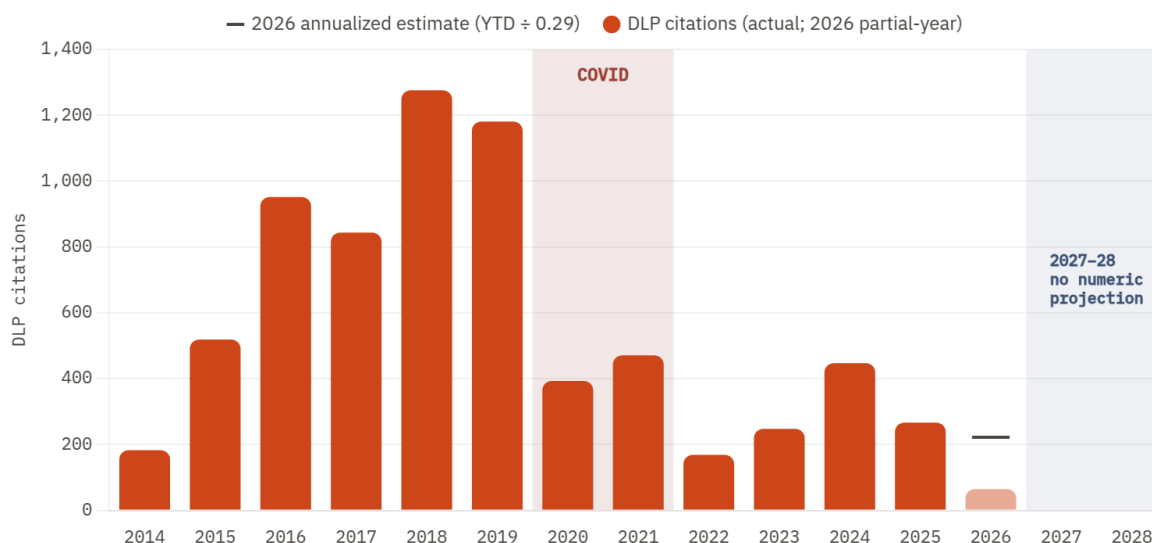
Public-safety programs are not generally expected to pay for themselves through fees: police patrols, fire response, and park rangers all run at a net cost by design, and that is a legitimate use of public money. Cost recovery is included here as one measurable input, not as a standard the program is failing to meet. The question this page raises is narrower: the program's cost is rising while its measurable output falls and its offense mix shows no shift away from first-time violations, and that combination is worth examining before doubling the program's size. Policy recommendations are on the [opinion page](#); this page stays with the data.

The arc over time, and what the city funded, billed, and deployed

COVID was a clean break in this series, so the story that matters now is what happened *after* it. Before COVID, the 2016 officer team drove contacts to a 2018 peak; since 2021 output has stayed low and flat, and the 2023 decision to fund and bill for three officers did not change that. The chart marks 2027–2028 as an outlook zone with no numeric projection.

Annual DLP enforcement contacts, 2014–2026

Orange bars: DLP contacts (citations plus warnings). 2026 (lighter) is partial-year through April 17; the dashed marker shows its annualized full-year equivalent (~222). The shaded zone at right marks 2027–2028: neither prior staffing increase produced sustained output growth, so the page shows no numeric projection. COVID period shaded.



Source: [enforcement-citations.csv](#) · staffing baselines: 2016 MOA, 2021 MOA, 2023 MOA, Axios Seattle April 2026

OBSERVATION

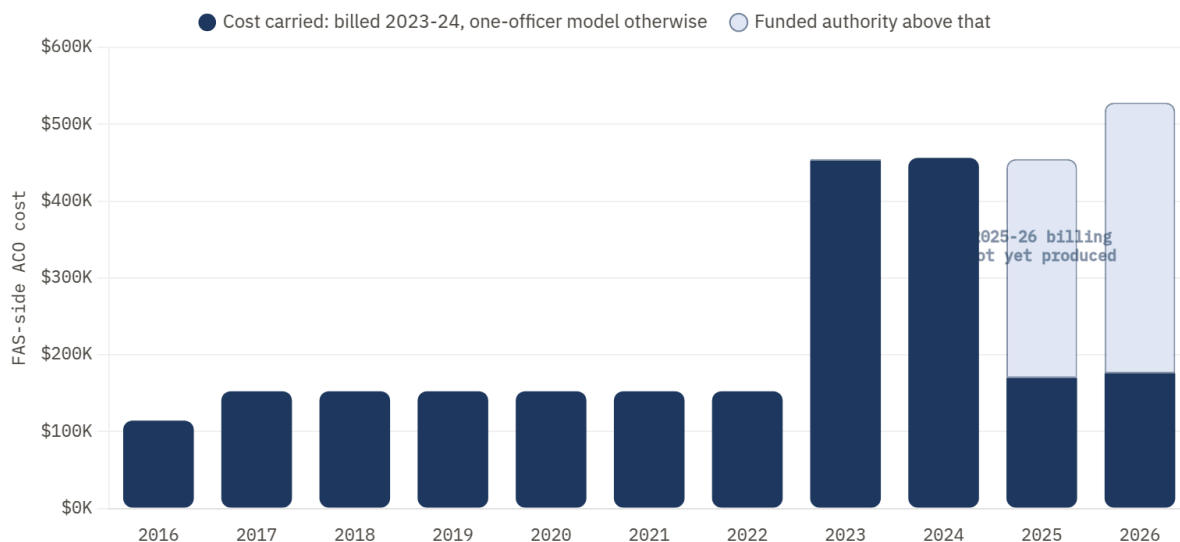
Read the two eras separately. **Before COVID**, the 2016 officer team drove contacts from 183 (2014) to a 1,276 peak (2018). **COVID was the break**: 2020 fell to 393 (~67% from 2019). **Since then is the live story**: output has stayed low and flat, with 2022–2025 at 169, 248, 447, and 267, at or below the old single-officer years, even though the city funded and was billed for three officers from 2023. The money rose; contacts did not, and deployment (per the cost note above) reached at most two. So this page makes no 2027–28 projection. For scale: Seattle dog-license issuance fell about 21% from 2014 to 2025 ([PRR C264029](#)) while contacts fell roughly 80% from peak. One documented reason output stays low regardless of patrol effort is below: officers can't compel identification, so a contact that yields no name ends in a warning, not a citation.

WHY CITATION OUTPUT CAN FALL WHILE PATROLS CONTINUE.

Animal Control Officers are not police: they cannot compel identification from someone who refuses, and cannot detain, and a name is required to write an infraction. By Finance & Administrative Services' own September 2022 report to Council, Seattle Police "recently... have been unable to assist" in obtaining IDs, so officers now "issue verbal warnings on all first contacts." When refusing to identify yourself carries no consequence, and residents share patrol locations online, fewer contacts become citations regardless of how many dogs are off-leash. [Full quotes and source →](#)

What the Park District funded, and what SPR was billed, 2016-2026

FAS-side Animal Control Officer dollars. Navy = the cost this page carries each year: one officer at the MOA rate through 2022 and in 2025–26, and the actual billed amount in 2023–24 (\$453,056 annualized from the first half of 2023; \$456,173 for 2024). Light blue = funded authority above that. In 2023–24 the two are the same, because the 2023 MOA billed the full three-officer amount whether or not officers were fielded. For 2025–26 the ledger was not produced, so the gap between the \$508,695 / \$528,279 caps and actual-hours billing is unknown. Officer cost only; the maintenance-worker pairing ended in 2023.



Funded: 2026 MOA (\$528,279/yr, 3 ACO II), 2023 MOA (\$454,652/yr) and 2021 MOA (\$152,399/yr, 1 ACO II) · attributable floor & method: enforcement-year-metrics.csv

OBSERVATION

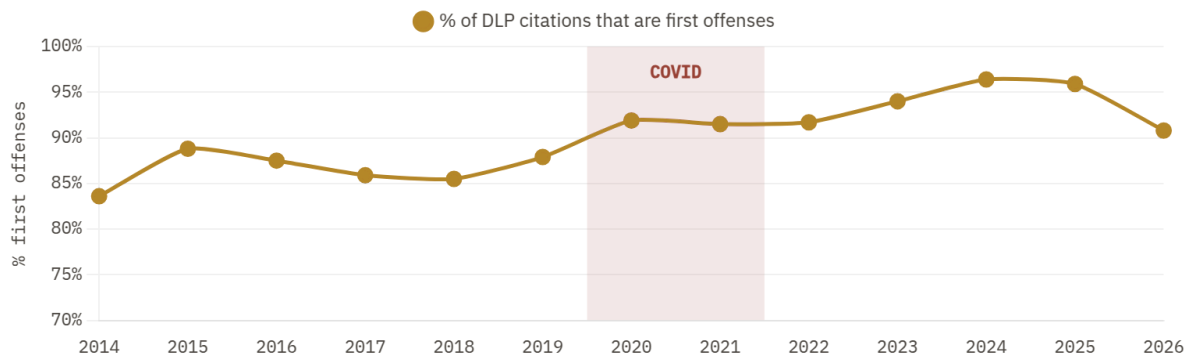
Through 2022 the funded program and the actual program were the same: one officer at \$152,399. In 2023 the city **tripled the funding** (\$454,652/yr; \$528,279 under the 2026 MOA) **and was billed for all of it**: the 2023 agreement charged 240 hours per pay period for three officers with no actual-hours qualifier, and SPR's own budget staff noticed in December 2023 that "we pay on an annual hourly basis not on actual work performed" ([Bates 00469](#)). What the money bought is a separate question: the Animal Shelter told SPR in February 2025 it could field "closer to 2 FTEs," possibly 1.5, and SPR said one officer was on parks as of April 2026. Contacts in 2023-25 (248, 447, 267) sat at or below the single-officer years. In September 2024 SPR's own manager reviewed the output and recommended cutting to two officers or one; in February 2025 the Interim Deputy Superintendent sent the draft back at three "given AP's priority with off leash" ([chronology, PRR C266465](#)). The 2025 and 2026 MOAs fund "up to three" and bill on actual hours; what SPR has been billed since is not yet in the record. Because the cap on citations is officer *authority* (they can't compel identification), not headcount, filling the positions is unlikely to raise output in step. Officer dollars only; the SPR-side partner (a maintenance worker through 2022, vacant from 2023, an existing Park Ranger under the 2026 MOA) is carried separately (see [opinion O1](#)).

No measurable shift away from first-time offenders.

If enforcement were deterring repeat violations, the share of citations going to people cited before would be expected to grow over time as a stable population of repeat offenders accumulates contacts. Instead, first-time offenses have stayed the overwhelming majority every year, and their share has risen, not fallen.

First-offense share of DLP citations, 2014-2026

Share of each year's DLP citations that are first offenses (vs. 2nd, 3rd, or 4th+ under Seattle Municipal Code (SMC) 18.12.080's escalation schedule). COVID period shaded. 2026 partial-year.



Source: offense levels in [enforcement-citations.csv](#) · [SMC 18.12.080\(A\)](#)

OBSERVATION

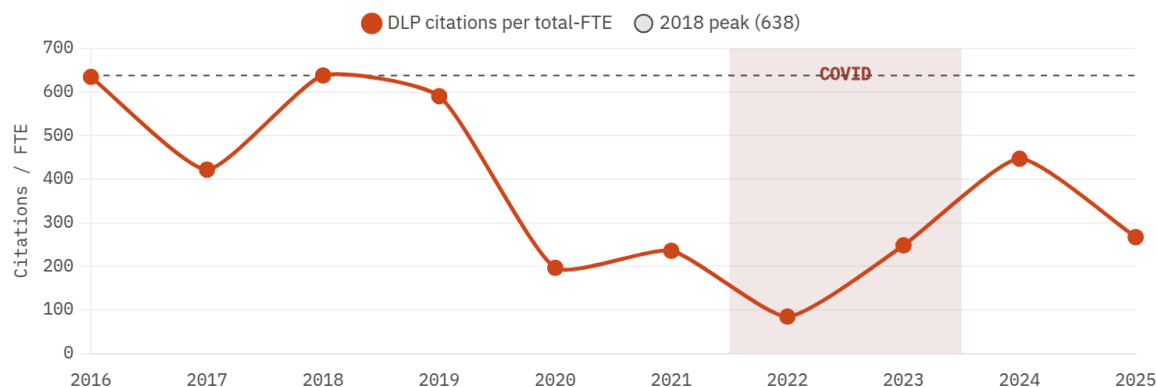
First offenses have ranged from about 84% to 96% of DLP citations in every year of the record, rising over time rather than falling. One reading is that enforcement is deterring repeat offenses. A second reading is that lower total citation volume mechanically reduces the chance of an officer encountering the same person twice, which would push the first-offense share up regardless of behavior. The two cannot be separated here: neither PRR includes owner identifiers that would let us track individuals across citations. What the data does show is that the offense mix never shifted toward repeat offenders. The pattern is consistent with a program issuing fresh first-time contacts year after year, not one drawing down a shrinking pool of repeat violators. Seattle Parks & Recreation's (SPR) own 2015 owner survey found about 38% of dog owners admit illegal off-leash use (39% local parks and 38% large parks weekly to monthly, 36% trails); no follow-up survey has been published (see [what SPR has not measured](#)).

A KEY LIMIT.

The citation records carry *no owner identity*, partly by privacy design and partly because officers usually can't obtain identification ([Finding 1](#)). "First offense" is only what the officer recorded; we cannot follow individuals across years. So we can describe the offense *mix* the city recorded, but cannot tell genuine deterrence apart from simply not catching the same person twice. [Why several explanations fit →](#)

Citations per officer-FTE per year

A productivity view of the same record: DLP contacts divided by the total ACO+FMW FTE attributable to off-leash enforcement. Shown from 2016 on (the MOA-documented full-team era); pre-2016 part-time FTE is imputed and not directly comparable. Per-FTE output peaked at 638 in 2018 on a two-person team. From 2023 the denominator is one officer, because the paired maintenance worker left and was never replaced, so 2024's 447 per FTE is on a smaller team, not a recovery in output. 2026 partial-year excluded.

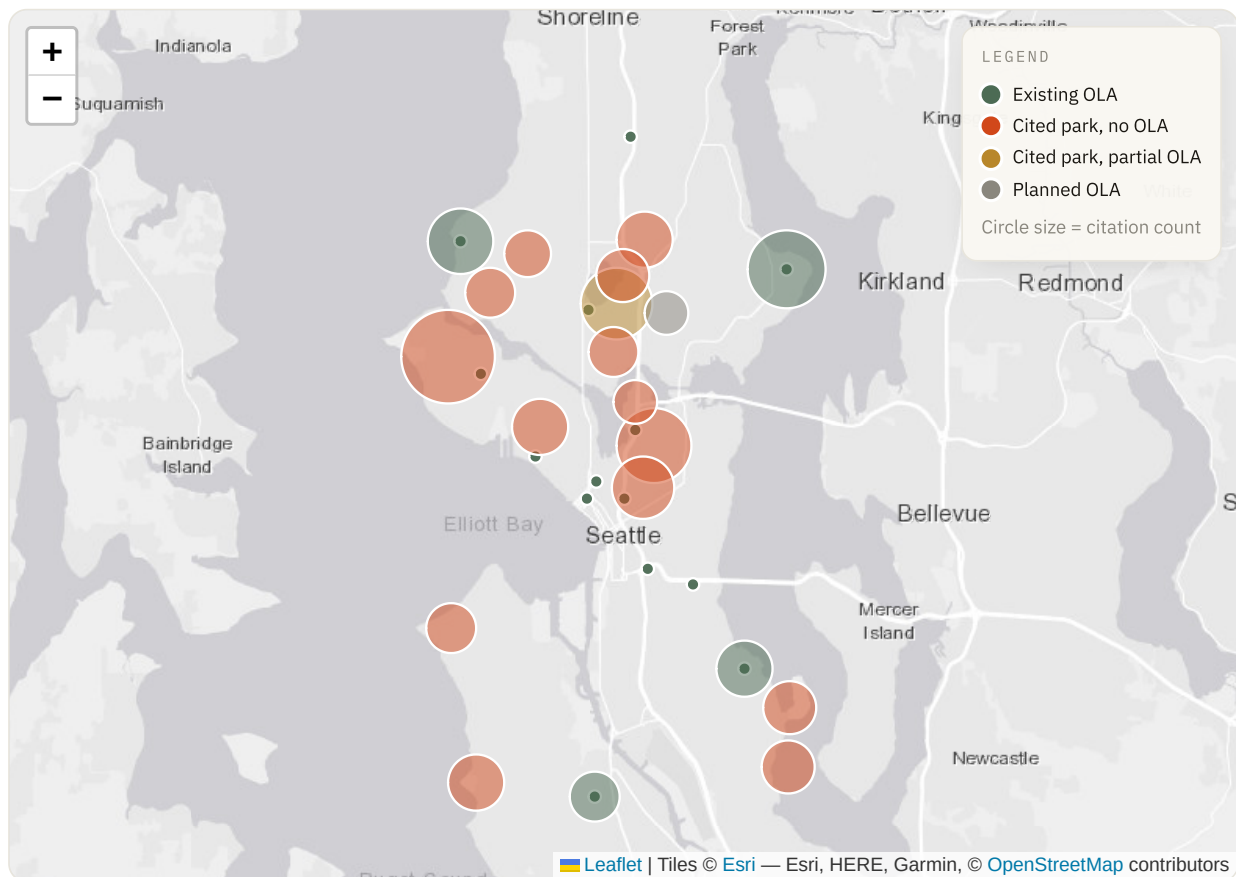


Where contacts happen, and where residents complain.

Citations cluster in a handful of large, heavily-used parks, mostly ones without a nearby legal off-leash area, while resident complaints concentrate somewhere else entirely. This section maps both: the citation hotspots and their pre/post-COVID persistence, and the full per-park table. Throughout, the records show *where* citations were issued, not *why* officers were there.

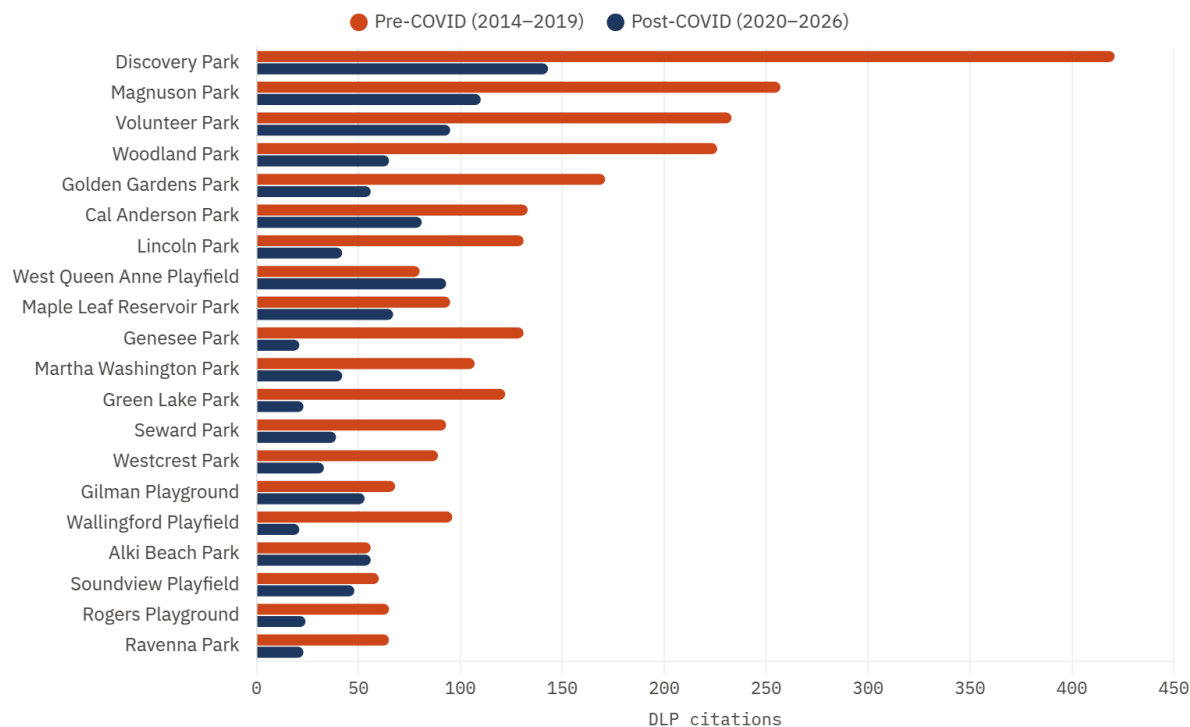
Where off-leash citations were issued, 2014-2026

Circles sized by DLP citation count at the cited park. Green dots mark all 14 existing off-leash areas (OLAs). Hover a marker for details.



Top 20 cited parks: pre-COVID (2014-2019) vs post-COVID (2020-2026)

Orange bars: 2014–2019 DLP citations. Navy bars: 2020–2026 DLP citations. Parks ordered by combined total.



Source: `enforcement-by-park-year.csv`

OBSERVATION

Citations cluster in areas without a designated OLA. Discovery, Volunteer, Cal Anderson, Lincoln, Martha Washington, Wallingford Playfield, Seward, and Maple Leaf Reservoir all rank in the top 20 and none has a dedicated OLA on site. Magnuson and Westcrest appear as hotspots because the non-OLA portions of those large host parks are used off-leash. The top 10 parks accounted for 46% of citations before COVID and 40% after. Concentration eased somewhat but the same handful of parks still dominate. **The data records where citations were issued, not why officers were there**, so it cannot establish whether a given park is a hotspot because of higher violation rates or because patrols were directed to it.

Complaints by park type. The 2024-26 complaint data ([Finding 4](#)) sharpens this: destination and natural-area parks (Discovery, Woodland, Golden Gardens, Magnuson) stay roughly balanced between complaints and citations (the ones Animal Control patrols) while dense-neighborhood playfields run 5:1 to 100:1 complaints-over-citations (West Queen Anne Playfield 255 complaints, Maple Leaf Reservoir 147, Beacon Hill 108). Where officers go and where neighbors object are structurally different places.

The full top-20 table

RANK	PARK	NEIGHBORHOOD	CITATIONS 2014-2026	PRE-COVID	POST-COVID	COMPLAINTS 2024-26	OLA?
1	Discovery Park	Magnolia	564	421	143	109	No
2	Magnuson Park	Sand Point	367	257	110	140	Yes
3	Volunteer Park	Capitol Hill	328	233	95	99	No
4	Woodland Park	Green Lake	291	226	65	62	Partial
5	Golden Gardens Park	Ballard	227	171	56	44	Yes
6	Cal Anderson Park	Capitol Hill	214	133	81	95	No
7	Lincoln Park	West Seattle	173	131	42	97	No
8	West Queen Anne Playfield	Queen Anne	173	80	93	255	No
9	Maple Leaf Reservoir Park	Maple Leaf	162	95	67	147	No
10	Genesee Park	Columbia City	152	131	21	68	Yes
11	Martha Washington Park	Rainier Beach	149	107	42	8	No
12	Green Lake Park	Green Lake	145	122	23	93	No
13	Seward Park	Seward Park	132	93	39	26	No
14	Westcrest Park	Highland Park	122	89	33	28	Yes
15	Gilman Playground	—	121	68	53	24	No
16	Wallingford Playfield	Wallingford	117	96	21	35	No
17	Alki Beach Park	Alki	112	56	56	23	No
18	Soundview Playfield	Crown Hill	108	60	48	9	No
19	Rogers Playground	Eastlake	89	65	24	35	No
20	Ravenna Park	Ravenna	88	65	23	9	Planned

New column. Citation columns span 2014–2026; the complaint column is 2024–26 only (the complaint record begins in 2024), so the two are not the same window. Read the column for the within-park *contrast* between enforcement and resident reporting, not as a like-for-like total.
Source: [complaints-vs-citations-by-park.csv](#) (PRR C263990).

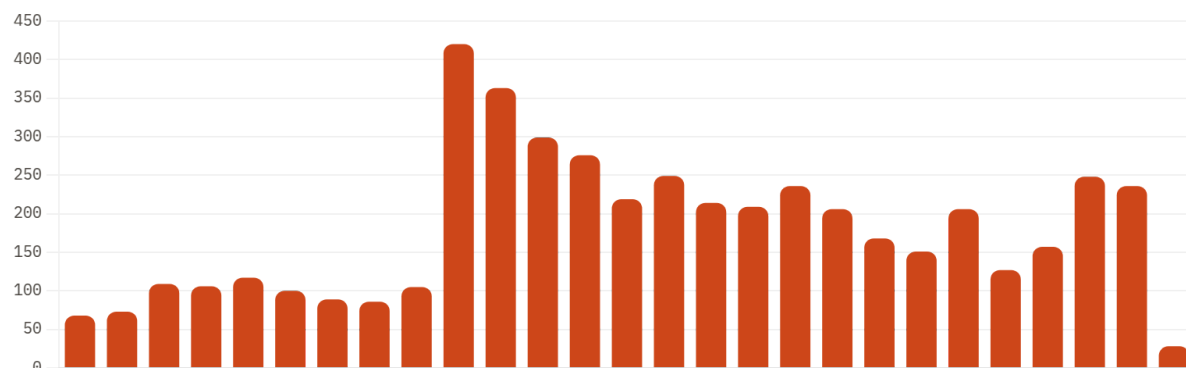
More complaints, fewer contacts, and no link between the two.

In 2025, the first full year of the complaint record, residents filed about **3,010** “Nuisance Dogs in a Park” reports through Find It Fix It, roughly **11 for every dog-loose-in-park citation** the city issued that year. As complaints rose, citations fell, and after mid-2025 citations went nearly silent while complaints held steady. Complaints are resident-reported, tracking who files rather than only where dogs run off-leash, so they are read here as a behavior proxy, not an incident count. This is the independent proxy the [data-gap note below](#) had flagged as pending.

Resident complaints vs. dog-loose-in-park citations, 2024-2026

Top panel (orange bars): monthly Find It Fix It complaints. Bottom panel (navy line): monthly DLP citations, same months. Two stacked panels on one shared timeline, deliberately not a dual-axis chart, which would imply a correlation the data does not support.

MONTHLY RESIDENT COMPLAINTS



MONTHLY DOG-LOOSE-IN-PARK CITATIONS



Complaints: [Open Data 5ngg-rpne](#) (PRR C263990) · citations: [enforcement-citations.csv](#), DLP only · monthly series: [complaints-citations-monthly.csv](#)

OBSERVATION

Month to month, complaint volume and citation volume **move independently**: a heavy month for complaints is no more (and no less) likely to be a heavy month for citations. (For the statistically inclined: the correlation is $r = 0.13$ over April 2024 to June 2026, near zero on a scale where 1.0 would mean the two rise and fall in lockstep; the last two months carry no citation data because that record ends April 17, 2026, and excluding them gives 0.08.) Complaints roughly **tripled** from 2024's nine recorded months to 2025's full year, while contacts *fell* about 40% (447 to 267), then dropped to near zero for the second half of 2025. With one to two officers on parks, enforcement output cannot scale to complaint volume; the two systems operate in parallel, not in sequence. This neither proves nor disproves that complaints lead to enforcement: the records show citation volume, not what happened after any individual complaint.

No one has measured whether the program works.

WHAT THE CITY NEVER MEASURED, NOW CONFIRMED BY BOTH AGENCIES

Contact counts measure *enforcement activity*, not violation rates. A drop could mean fewer violations *or* fewer patrols. SPR's 2015 owner survey found about 38% of dog owners admit illegal off-leash use; no follow-up survey has been published. In 2026 two records requests asked each agency directly for any evaluation, deployment log, or trend analysis of the program. **SPR** ([PRR C266465](#), answered July 2026) produced no deployment logs and no compliance or complaint-trend analysis; its one internal review, a September 2024 memo, counted raw output, found it falling, and recommended cutting the program to two officers or one. **FAS / the Animal Shelter** ([PRR C266744](#)) said its only responsive records are officer truck logs and dispatch broadcasts. Across ten years and roughly \$3 million in officer billing, no evaluation exists anywhere in the City. The Animal Shelter's own tracking for 2023–24 shows what the program produces: 1,540 officer contacts, 70 citations, 4 written warnings, 0 park exclusions ([enforcement-program-activity.csv](#); a different record system from the citation data on this page, kept separate on purpose). Still open:

- ~~SPR program evaluation, deployment logs, and 2026 expansion decision record (PRR #8)~~ — **received** as [C266465](#): no evaluation or deployment logs exist; the decision record and 2023–24 ledger backup did. Still open: Q3–Q4 2023 and 2025–26 billing.
- ~~Find-It-Fix-It “dog in a park” complaints by year — an independent behavior proxy —~~ **received** ([PRR C263990](#)); see [Finding 4](#) above. Still open: the free-text “General Inquiry – Animal Shelter” export, and the cause of the mid-2025 citation drop-off.
- ~~Current SPR/SAS MOA and budget lines for the expanded staffing —~~ **received** ([PRR C265341](#) and [C265589](#)): the 2023 Park District MOA funds three ACO IIs at \$454,652/yr, re-priced to \$528,279/yr by the 2026 MOA; see the cost footnote below. Still open: the MOA \$5 monthly parks-data reports ([PRR #9](#), filed; SPR responding), which would show per-park patrol activity, and the narrowed July-2025 truck-log installment on C266744.

This page can describe enforcement output and cost. It cannot prove or disprove that the program changed behavior, and neither, on its own records, can the City. Policy implications are on the [opinion page](#).

The Seattle Parks budget, and the *off-leash* share of it.

Seattle Parks & Recreation's (SPR) reported budget grew from \$168M (2018, operating only) to \$507M proposed (2026, all funds). About a quarter of the apparent jump is the 2019 shift from operating-only to all-funds reporting, not real growth. The off-leash area (OLA) line went from \$106,000 a year in Park District Cycle 1 to \$328,345 in 2023 and about \$1.57M in 2025 once Cycle 2 construction money is counted, a figure SPR released in July 2026 in response to a [public records request](#). Roughly a fifth of the Cycle 2 money has actually been spent. These charts put both series on one page with the methodology caveats intact.

SPR TOTAL, 2018

\$168_M

2018 adopted budget, **operating only**. Pre-2019 books did not consolidate Park District and Capital Improvement Program (CIP).

src

SPR TOTAL, 2026 PROPOSED

\$507_M

All funds including Park District + CIP. Apples-to-apples 2019→2025 is \$247.7M→\$339.4M (+37%). src

OLA-ONLY BUDGET, 2025

\$1.57_M

MC-PR-51002 adopted; \$368,398 of it spent. src

OLA-ONLY SHARE OF SPR

0.46%

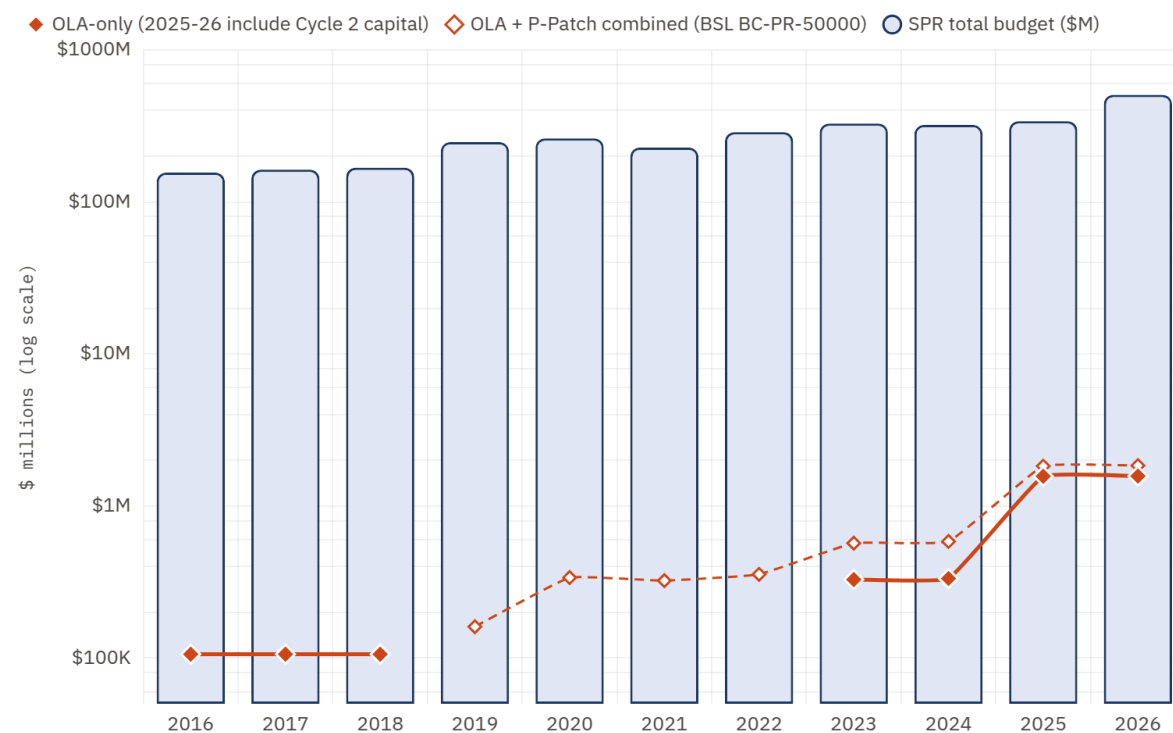
2025, the highest year. Cycle 1 ran at 0.068%; 2023–24 at about 0.10%.

The parks budget and the OLA line, on one axis.

Bar = SPR total (\$M). Lines = the OLA-related series. Solid orange markers are the OLA-only figures; the dashed orange line is the combined OLA + P-Patch “Maintaining Parks & Facilities” BSL that contains them. A log axis lets the OLA series remain legible alongside the SPR total; a linear version would render the OLA line as a flat sliver on the baseline.

SPR total budget vs. OLA-related budget line, 2016-2026

Navy bars = SPR total (\$M). Solid orange line = the OLA-only Master Project. Dashed orange line = the combined OLA + P-Patch BSL that contains it. The Cycle 2 OLA capital sits inside the OLA line from 2025, which is why it steps up; it is not a separate series. Single log-scale axis.



Source: Seattle 2016-2026 proposed/adopted budget books · OLA-only 2023-2026 from [PRR C264837](#) (MC-PR-51002) · Cycle 1 from the [2017 People, Dogs and Parks Plan](#) · data in [data/budget-detail.csv](#)

OBSERVATION

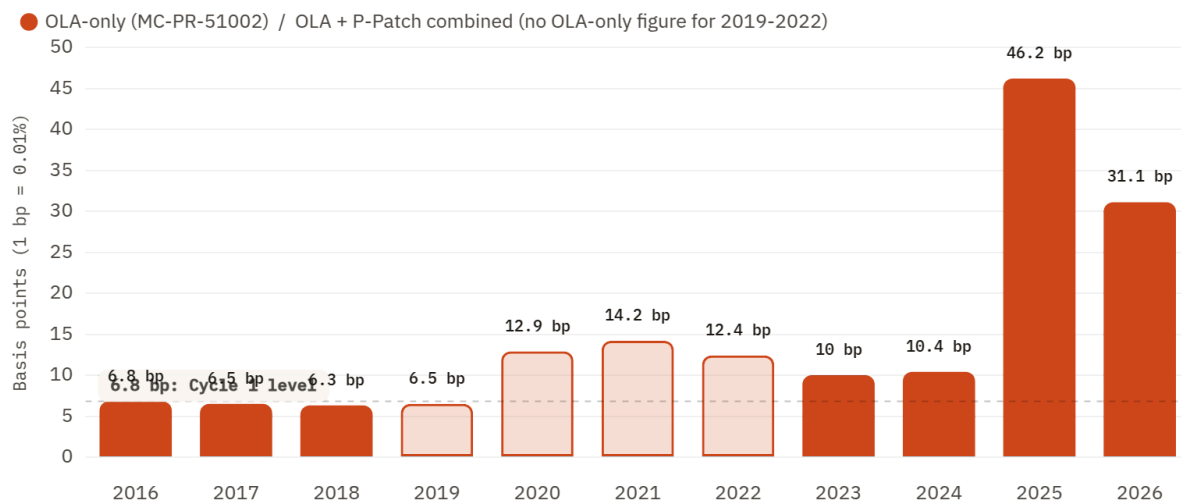
SPR's total budget rose from \$168M (2018) to \$507M (2026 proposed, all funds). Every OLA series on the same chart sits 2-3 orders of magnitude below it. The OLA-only line runs \$106,000 a year in Cycle 1, \$328,345 in 2023 and \$333,478 in 2024, then steps to about \$1.57M in 2025 and 2026 as the Cycle 2 construction money lands inside it. There is no OLA-only figure for 2019-2022: the city reported the joint BSL in those years and the records request that produced the split covers 2023 onward.

At its Cycle 2 peak the OLA line is still under half a percent of SPR spending.

Same series, expressed as a share of SPR's total budget and scaled in basis points (1 bp = 0.01%). Solid bars use the OLA-only Master Project; dashed-outline bars use the combined OLA + P-Patch BSL for 2019–2022, where no OLA-only figure exists. A reference line marks the Cycle 1 level of 6.8 bp (0.068%).

OLA-related budget as a share of SPR total, 2016–2026

Bars in basis points (1 bp = 0.01%). Solid = the OLA-only Master Project. Dashed-outline = combined OLA + P-Patch BSL for 2019–2022, an upper bound because it also carries P-Patch. The 2025–2026 solid bars include the Cycle 2 capital, which is booked inside the OLA line.



Source: Seattle budget books (SPR total) · SPR People, Dogs and Parks Strategic Plan (2017) · raw calculation in [data/budget-detail.csv](#)

OBSERVATION

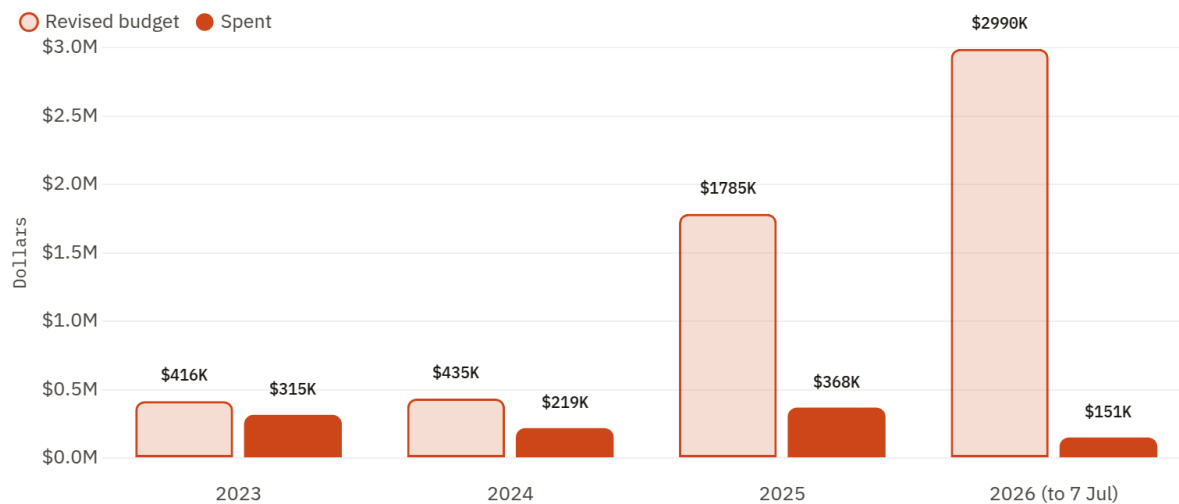
Cycle 1 sits at 6.8 bp (0.068% of SPR spending) in 2016, 6.3 bp by 2018. Cycle 2 is markedly higher: 10.0 bp in 2023, 10.4 in 2024, then 46.2 in 2025 and 31.1 in 2026 as the construction money lands. Even that peak is under half of one percent. The rise is real and it is mostly capital, which is spent once; the 2023–24 operating level of about 10 bp is the recurring figure. For scale, SPR's own 2017 plan puts Seattle's dog population at [150,000](#), roughly one dog for every four residents at the time, and its 2015 survey of dog owners found 67% of respondents use an OLA weekly to monthly. (Earlier versions of this page said "25% of residents use OLAs"; the survey covered dog owners only, and the sentence was corrected in September 2026.)

Cycle 2 funded off-leash areas. It has not spent the money.

Seattle Parks and Recreation (SPR) books off-leash areas as Master Project MC-PR-51002 inside the Maintaining Parks & Facilities budget line, and in July 2026 released four years of budget and spending against it. The budget quadrupled in 2025, when the construction money arrived. Spending did not follow: the share of each year's budget actually spent fell from 76% to 21%, and 2026 is running at 5% through 7 July. Across the four years, **\$1,053,037** of a **\$5,625,926** revised budget has gone out the door, leaving **\$4,362,265** unspent.

Off-leash area budget vs. spending, 2023-2026

Master Project MC-PR-51002 “Improve Dog Off Leash Areas.” Outlined bars = revised budget. Solid bars = expenses recorded against it. 2026 is year-to-date through 7 July 2026 and is not comparable to a closed year.



Source: [PRR C264837](#), SPR response of 15 July 2026 · data in [data/ola-ppatch-master-projects.csv](#)

OBSERVATION

The unspent balance is the finding, not a comparison with community gardens: the P-Patch Master Project in the same budget line spent 32.0% of its revised budget across the closed years 2023-2025, against 34.2% for off-leash areas. Both underspend at about the same rate. What is distinctive about the off-leash line is the size of the balance and the direction of travel, and that the money involved is construction money for two specific parks. Of it, roughly \$600,000 had been spent by July 2026, all on planning and design; SPR estimates construction at West Seattle Stadium and Othello begins in early 2027. The 2026 revised budget of \$2,990,479 is nearly double the \$1,574,370 adopted, which is what carrying an unspent balance forward looks like.

The other side of the ledger: dog-license revenue vs. OLA spending.

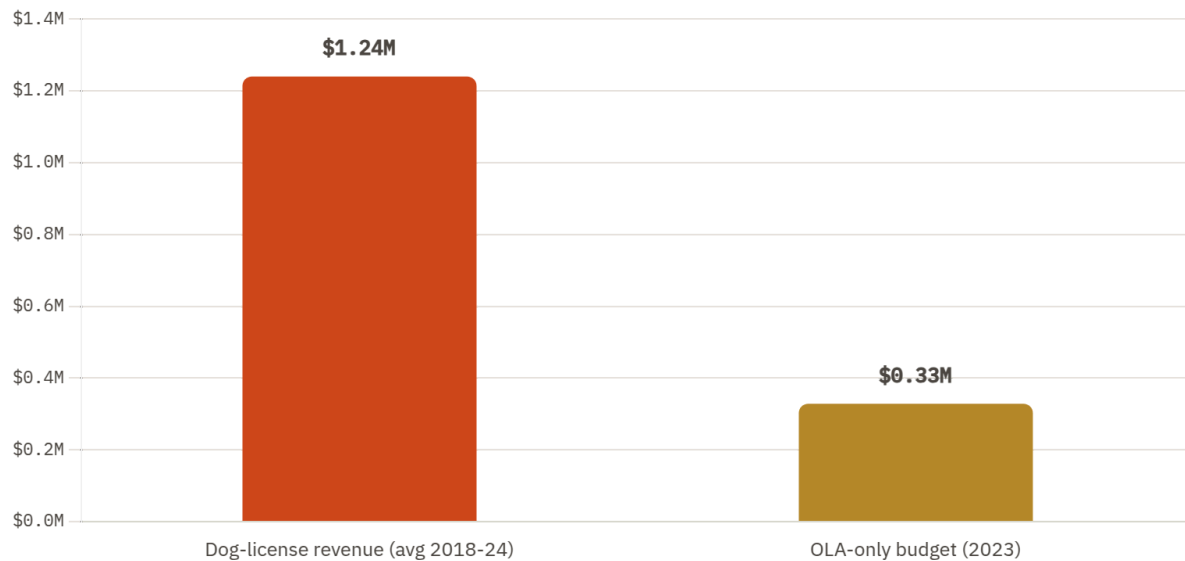
The figures above track what the city *spends* on off-leash areas. A 2026 public records request ([PRR C264029](#)) lets us add what the city *collects* from dog owners. The two are an order of magnitude apart.

SCALE, NOT ACCOUNTING: THESE ARE DIFFERENT DEPARTMENTS

Dog-license revenue goes to the Seattle Animal Shelter (Finance & Administrative Services) and funds *all* of its animal services (sheltering, cruelty response, adoptions, licensing and citywide animal control), **not** Seattle Parks & Recreation's OLA budget. License money does not, and is not meant to, fund OLAs. This is an honest contrast of two dog-related public-money flows, not a claim that one should pay for the other.

Annual dog-license revenue vs. OLA-only operating budget

Dog-license General Fund revenue averaged about \$1.24M/year over 2018–2024 (PRR C264029; 2015 and 2017 were partial/incomplete and are excluded). The OLA-only budget was about \$106,000/year in Park District Cycle 1 and \$328,345–\$333,478 in 2023–2024. Both in nominal dollars.



Revenue: [PRR C264029](#) (Seattle Animal Shelter [SAS] dog-license revenue), see [data/licensing-revenue.csv](#) · OLA-only budget: [data/budget-detail.csv](#) (2024 disclosed figure)

OBSERVATION

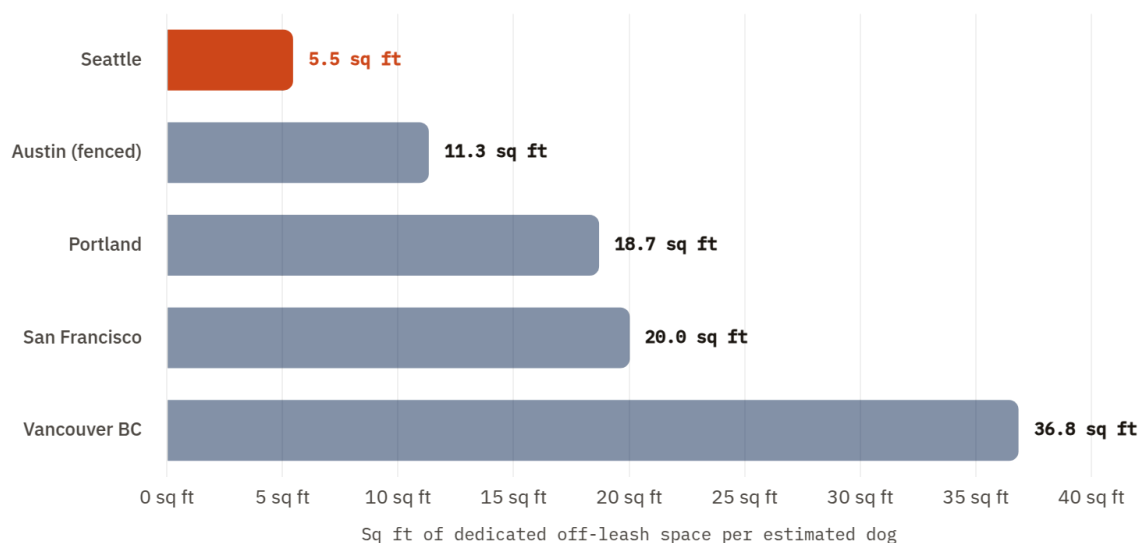
The city collects roughly **\$1.24M a year** in dog-license fees, about **four times** the \$328,345 budgeted for off-leash areas in 2023. Dog-license revenue also dwarfs the ~\$24,500/year in off-leash fine revenue on the [Enforcement](#) page. The enforcement *program* is a much larger number, and since July 2026 the site can say what it actually cost: SPR was billed **\$456,173 in 2024** for three park-patrol officers, on invoices computed from a 40-hour week rather than from hours worked, while the staffing agency reported it could field one and a half to two ([Enforcement, cost note; PRR C266465](#)). The 2026 agreement caps the line at \$528,279 and bills on actual hours.

Off-leash space per dog, peer cities.

Few major U.S. or Canadian cities publish a dog-park-specific operating line, which makes a dollars-per-dog peer comparison impossible without public records requests to each parks department. What every city does publish is OLA acreage. Divided by an estimated dog population (city population × 0.30 dogs/person, AVMA-derived), that yields square feet of dedicated off-leash space per dog.

Off-leash space per dog, five West Coast & peer cities

Published OLA acreage divided by estimated dogs (pop × 0.30). Reported in square feet per dog. Portland's 85 acres and San Francisco's 120 acres include unfenced voice-control sites that Seattle does not count; Austin's 80-acre figure is the fenced-comparable subset (the oft-cited 682-acre Austin total is inflated by Walnut Creek Metropolitan Park voice-control area).



Math: OLA acreage from [data/peer-cities.csv](#) (Seattle 30.7, Austin 80 fenced-comparable, Portland 85, SF 120, Vancouver BC 168). Populations: WA Office of Financial Management (OFM) 2025 (Seattle), US Census ACS 2023 (Portland/SF/Austin), Statistics Canada 2021 (Vancouver BC). Dog-ownership rate: AVMA 2025 Pet Ownership & Demographics Sourcebook applied uniformly at 0.30 dogs/resident.

OBSERVATION

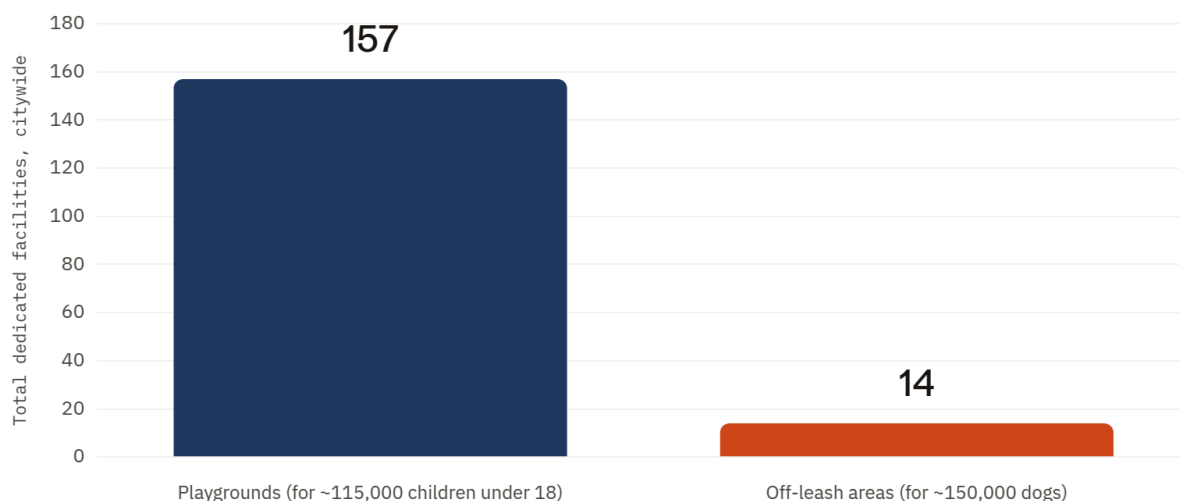
A Seattle dog has about 5.5 sq ft of legal off-leash space at the cross-city 0.30 dogs/resident rate, roughly the footprint of a doormat. Portland sits at ~19, San Francisco ~20, Vancouver BC ~37; Austin's fenced-comparable figure (~11) is about twice Seattle's. Because peer cities use wider definitions of off-leash space than Seattle does, these bars likely understate the gap. (The 5.4 sq ft figure elsewhere on the site is the same calculation via a more granular AVMA-by-household derivation; the gap is rounding against two equivalent denominators.) Per-OLA detail is in [Part II — Access](#).

Dedicated facilities: playgrounds for children, OLAs for dogs.

A different scaling: the count of dedicated facilities per user. Seattle has 157 playgrounds (Trust for Public Land [TPL] 2025 ParkScore, includes joint-use schoolyards) for roughly 115,000 residents under 18. It has 14 fenced OLAs for at least 150,000 dogs (Seattle Humane / Cascade PBS conservative floor; SPR's 2023 Expansion Study cites estimates up to 400,000), so dogs outnumber children under 18 roughly 1.3 to 1.

Dedicated facilities, Seattle, 2025

Count of dedicated facilities citywide. 1 playground per ~733 kids, 1 OLA per ~10,700 dogs at the 150,000 floor (about 14.6× more users per facility).



Source: [TPL 2025 ParkScore Seattle](#) (playground count) · [SPR OLA inventory](#) · Seattle Humane / Cascade PBS (dog-population floor) · data in [seattle-olas.csv](#)

OBSERVATION

At the 150,000 dog floor, Seattle has one dedicated off-leash area per ~10,700 dogs and one playground per ~733 kids, a ratio roughly 14.6× higher for dogs. Using the higher 400,000 estimate from SPR's 2023 Expansion Study, the ratio widens to about 39×. Per-OLA acreage and site sizes are charted in [Part II — Access](#); the full opening-year sequence is in [Part I — The Gap](#).

Cycle 1 vs. Cycle 2, and the backlog neither one touches.

The Seattle Park District runs in six-year cycles. Cycle 1 (2015–2020) funded OLA operations at about \$106,000 a year, and built nothing. Cycle 2 (2023–2028) is a different order of magnitude: \$3,805,011 appropriated to the OLA Master Project across 2023–2026, including construction money for West Seattle Stadium and Othello. The comparison can now be made on money actually spent rather than money voted. Cycle 1 spent [\\$635,000](#) on OLA major maintenance across 2017–2021, about \$127,000 a year. Cycle 2 spent \$902,443 across the three closed years 2023–2025, about \$301,000 a year, and \$1,053,037 in total through 7 July 2026. Note the scope gap: the Cycle 1 figure is major maintenance, the Cycle 2 figure is the whole Master Project including design work, so the comparison runs in Cycle 2's favour and the real ratio is smaller than 2.4×.

SPR's 2026 capital program across all projects is [\\$87.7M](#); the OLA construction line is about 3.5% of that. SPR's project pages give that line as [\\$3,103,000](#) for West Seattle Stadium and Othello. Ravenna Park was selected for design only, and its construction is unfunded: it would need a future appropriation ([Parkways](#)). Of the construction money, roughly \$600,000 had been spent by July 2026, all of it on planning and design; SPR estimates construction begins in early 2027.

The backlog the capital line doesn't touch. SPR's own 2016 capital-priority list, released in July 2026 ([PRR C266465](#), [Bates 00168](#)), itemized [\\$1,150,000–\\$2,220,000](#) of deferred capital work across the 14 existing OLAs in 2016 dollars, against Park District OLA maintenance the plan states as \$103,000–\$117,000 a year: an 11-to-22-year backlog at 2016 prices, before inflation. SPR told Council it spent about [\\$635,000 on OLA major maintenance over 2017–2021](#) (Bates 00681). The Cycle 2 capital builds two new sites; it does not address the list.

PEER-CITY FUNDING MECHANISMS

Of the six peer cities the site tracks (Seattle, Portland, San Francisco, Vancouver BC, Washington DC, Minneapolis), only Minneapolis Park and Recreation Board publishes OLA operating costs as a separable line: an [Enterprise Fund](#) funded by user permits (\$38 a year for a resident's first dog). Portland, SF, Vancouver BC, and DC bundle OLA operating inside general parks ops. Capital vehicles differ: Seattle has its Metropolitan Park District, SF uses GO park bonds, Portland uses the 2020 Parks Levy, Vancouver and DC use standard CIP lines, and Minneapolis uses the MPRB capital budget for new OLAs while permits fund ongoing ops. Per-city detail in [Peer Cities](#).

How eight peer cities *run* their off-leash systems.

Per-city detail on Portland, San Francisco, Vancouver BC, Washington DC, Minneapolis, New York, Austin, and Boise. Counting methodology, governance model, funding mechanism, operating rules, and at least one design choice per city that Seattle has not used. The aggregate comparison is in [Part I](#) and the funding-mechanism note on the [Budget](#) page; this page carries the per-city detail. Most of it rests on each city's own web pages as read in April 2026, linked but not archived here; three claims with known recency risk are flagged inline.

[PORTLAND](#)[SAN FRANCISCO](#)[VANCOUVER BC](#)[WASHINGTON DC](#)[MINNEAPOLIS](#)[NEW YORK](#)[AUSTIN](#)[BOISE](#)

Portland, OR: the voice-control model

Portland Parks & Recreation operates a mix of fenced and unfenced off-leash sites, with unfenced voice-control areas making up the majority. The city's own page describes ["over 30 dog off-leash areas — both fenced and unfenced"](#); [Trust for Public Land \(TPL\) ParkScore 2025](#) counts 38. The 5.74 / 100,000 and 3.2× per-capita figures throughout this site use the TPL count for apples-to-apples comparison; the fenced-only / voice-control mix is the methodological difference from Seattle's fenced-only count.

30+ DESIGNATED OFF-LEASH AREAS

3.2×

Portland's per-capita rate is 3.2× Seattle's on TPL's counts (38 vs 14); on Portland's own "over 30" it is closer to 2.7×

MOST ARE UNFENCED

voice-control

The majority of Portland's 30+ sites operate on voice-control rather than fencing.

VOTER-FUNDED

2020 Levy

Five-year levy approved by voters in November 2020 at ~\$47M/yr citywide; no dedicated OLA line item. Its term ran through 2025; renewal status not re-verified for this page.

Governance

City-run by Portland Parks & Recreation (PP&R). Volunteer advocacy runs through long-standing groups such as DOG PAC (Dog Owners Group Political Action Committee); there are no formal co-management Memoranda of Understanding (MOUs) at the scale of Seattle's Citizens for Off-Leash Areas (COLA) or DC's Friends-of-park system. Day-to-day maintenance is PP&R staff.

Funding

PP&R general fund plus the voter-approved [Parks Local Option Levy](#) (approved November 2020, five-year, ~\$47M/yr citywide; the term ran through 2025 and its renewal has not been re-verified for this page). A dog-park-specific line item is not broken out. Dog license fees flow to [Multnomah County Animal Services](#) rather than to PP&R, so license revenue does not fund dog parks.

Access standard

Portland uses the general **half-mile / 10-minute walk** standard for parks overall. There is no published OLA-specific walkshed standard. Because the count is larger and many areas are unfenced voice-control, a typical Portland dog owner has multiple legal options within a 10-minute walk.

COMPARISON WITH SEATTLE

Portland's framework accepts shared-use friction (people and dogs co-mingling off-leash under voice control) that Seattle policy has not incorporated since the 1997 OLA ordinance. Portland lists 30+ legal options for off-leash access; Seattle lists 14 dedicated OLAs (12 fully fenced, two partially). A Seattle analogue would be adopting time-zoned or voice-control access in a designated subset of existing parks, which is the approach proposed on [the opinion page](#).

SOURCES: [Portland PP&R – Find a dog off-leash area](#) · [PP&R Policy PRK-1.22 – DOLA rules](#) · [Portland Parks Levy](#) · [PP&R funding sources](#) · [Multnomah County Animal Services](#)

San Francisco, CA: dog play areas inside a federal-lands dispute

San Francisco Rec & Park's own catalog lists [36 designated Dog Play Areas \(DPAs\)](#), a mix of fully fenced enclosures and voice-control zones within larger parks; [TPL ParkScore 2025](#) counts 42 dog parks in SF using its own methodology. The 5.03 / 100,000 and 2.8× per-capita figures throughout this site use the TPL count for apples-to-apples comparison with other peers. Golden Gate Park alone contains four DPAs. SF's dog-park history is also the most heavily litigated of any peer: the GGNRA (federal) versus city-level dispute over Fort Funston, Ocean Beach, and Crissy Field off-leash access has run for nearly two decades.

36 DOG PLAY AREAS ACROSS THE CITY

2.8×

SF's per-capita rate is 2.8× Seattle's; federal GGNRA lands are off-limits for off-leash use.

FOUR DPAS IN GOLDEN GATE PARK ALONE

4

SF has sited DPAs inside large flagship parks; Seattle has no OLA inside Green Lake, Volunteer, Discovery, or Lincoln.

CAPITAL VIA VOTER GO BONDS

\$487M

Prop B 2020 Health & Recovery Bond: park capital funded by voters rather than annual operating appropriations.

Governance

City-run (SF Rec & Park). [SFDOG \(San Francisco Dog Owners Group\)](#) is the long-standing volunteer advocacy org and participates in the Dog Advisory Committee. Rules require picking up waste, keeping dogs under owner control, professional dog-walkers limited to eight dogs per person, and dogs must be licensed and vaccinated.

Funding

San Francisco does require dog licenses ([Health Code §41.15](#): every dog over four months, fees from about \$23 to \$163 depending on term and alteration status), but license revenue goes to Animal Care & Control, not to parks. (Through July 2026 this card said SF had no mandatory license; corrected September 2026.) Operating costs sit inside the Rec & Park general fund plus the Prop C Open Space Fund (property-tax set-aside). Capital comes from GO park bonds: [Prop A 2000](#), Prop B 2012 (\$195M), and [Prop B 2020 \(\\$487M\)](#). Additional capital comes through philanthropy via the SF Parks Alliance.

Access standard

SF uses TPL's 10-minute walk standard for parks generally; SF ranks #6 on TPL ParkScore with near-100% of residents within 10-minute walk of any park. There is no OLA-specific walkshed.

COMPARISON WITH SEATTLE

SF's defining complication is the [GGNRA Dog Management Plan](#), the federal-lands restriction on off-leash access that Seattle does not have. SF's 36 DPAs exist in part because federal land is off-limits for off-leash use and the city built dedicated city-level alternatives. Seattle has no equivalent federal-lands complication.

SOURCES: [SFRPD – Dog Play Areas](#) · [SFRPD Bonds & Initiatives](#) · [Prop B 2020 Health & Recovery Bond](#) · [GGNRA Dog Management Plan \(NPS\)](#) · [SFDog volunteer advocacy](#)

Vancouver, BC: the elected Park Board

Vancouver's Park Board has been the only independently elected parks body in a major Canadian city: seven commissioners elected by Vancouver voters, running parks independently of City Council. In December 2023 the mayor moved to ask the province to dissolve the elected board; 2026 news reports indicate it was not dissolved and that the mayor's party would instead contest the October 2026 board election. That status is from news coverage, not a primary source, and is not archived here. The Park Board passed the [People, Parks, and Dogs: A Strategy for Sharing Vancouver's Parks](#) in 2017, the most detailed OLA planning framework among the eight peer cities.

36+ OFF-LEASH AREAS, MANY TIME-ZONED

3.0×

Vancouver's per-capita rate is 3.0× Seattle's; some sites shift status seasonally.

VOTERS ELECT THE PARK BOARD DIRECTLY

7 seats

Only major Canadian city where park commissioners answer to voters rather than the mayor.

~\$2.10M

2023–2026 four-year OLA-specific capital cycle.

Governance: the distinguishing feature

Vancouver's [Park Board](#) is elected citywide every four years. Parks decisions, including OLA site selection, designation changes and programming, go through commissioners who are directly accountable at the ballot box, rather than through a mayoral department. This is the largest governance contrast with Seattle, where Seattle Parks & Recreation (SPR) is a mayoral department.

Recent builds (2023–2026)

Under the Park Board's [2023–2026 Capital Plan](#), Vancouver has opened or is completing: [Heather Park OLA](#) (13,000 sq ft, opened 2025), [Granville Park OLA](#), [Emery Barnes Park OLA](#) renewal and expansion, and a renewed Cooper's Park OLA. That is approximately \$2.10M in OLA-specific capital across the four-year cycle, with ~\$1.30M spent in 2024 alone.

Notable: time-zoned beach access

Vancouver uses **seasonal time-restricted beach access** (Spanish Banks, Sunset Beach, Kits Beach) where dogs are allowed off-leash only outside summer peak hours. This time-zoning model is one of the reference points for the shared-use-hours framing described on [the opinion page](#).

COMPARISON WITH SEATTLE

Two structural differences. First, governance: decisions by elected commissioners rather than a mayoral department. Second, time-zoning: the same stretch of Vancouver beach can host dogs off-leash in winter mornings and be dog-free in summer afternoons. Seattle's framework has no equivalent concept of temporal shared-use; parks are either on-leash at all times or OLAs at all times.

SOURCES: [People, Parks, and Dogs Strategy](#) · [2023–2026 Capital Plan appendix](#) · [Vancouver Park Board structure](#) · [Heather Park OLA project page](#) · [Heather Park opening announcement \(May 2025\)](#)

Washington, DC: the only peer with an OLA-specific statute

DC operates [16 designated dog parks](#) across all eight wards, all fully fenced. DC is the only peer with an OLA-specific enabling statute: the 2005 Dog Park Establishment Act (DC Law 16-175) defines what a Dog Park Area is, requires fencing, requires a recognized "Friends of" group to sign an MOU for stewardship, and requires environmental sign-off per site from DOEE.

DOG PARKS ACROSS ALL 8 WARDS

16 / 8

16 fenced dog parks; every ward covered.

THE ONLY PEER WITH AN OLA STATUTE

DC Law 16-175

Seattle's OLAs exist under a 1997 parks ordinance; DC's 2005 Act legally defines what a dog park is and what stewardship it requires.

FRIENDS GROUPS REQUIRED BY LAW

1 per park

Every DPA requires a recognized Friends group with a signed MOU.

The statute that defines the system

The [Dog Park Establishment Act of 2005](#) is the clearest example among the eight peer cities of OLAs being legally defined rather than policy-defined. It requires:

- Each Dog Park Area must be fenced.
- Each DPA must have a recognized **Friends of Group** that signs an MOU with DPR for day-to-day stewardship (cleaning, minor maintenance, community rules enforcement).
- DOEE (Department of Energy & Environment) must sign off on each site for environmental impact.
- \$2 of each dog-license fee goes to the [Animal Education & Outreach Fund](#), a spay/neuter fund, not OLAs. Pet licenses do not fund dog parks directly.

Funding

DPR general-fund operating for ongoing maintenance. Capital for new DPAs is per-project through the District Capital Improvements Plan (recent builds such as Texas Avenue DPA have come in around \$1M each). No user fees or permits.

Access standard

DC uses the 10-minute walk to a park standard (TPL-aligned). DC has ranked #1 on TPL's ParkScore most years since 2019, in part because of dense park coverage across all eight wards. Dog-park coverage is placed ward by ward.

COMPARISON WITH SEATTLE

Seattle's OLAs exist under a 1997 Parks ordinance without statutory-level definition, without a required stewardship structure, and without required per-site environmental review. Any future effort to formalize the relationship between Seattle's COLA and SPR could draw on DC's [2005 Act](#) and Arlington County's CCA Guidelines as existing peer templates.

SOURCES: [DC DPR — Dog Parks](#) · [DC Law 16-175: Dog Park Establishment Act of 2005](#) · [DC Code §8-1810.01 Animal Education Fund](#) · [DC Health dog licensing](#)

Minneapolis, MN: the permit-fee model

The [Minneapolis Park & Recreation Board \(MPRB\)](#) operates nine off-leash dog parks, and is the only major US peer that treats OLAs as a user-pays service. Every dog using any of the nine OLAs must carry an annual permit; permit revenue is the primary funding source for OLA operations and maintenance through MPRB's dedicated Off-Leash Dog Park Enterprise Fund.

USERS FUND OPERATIONS DIRECTLY

\$38 / year

Minneapolis resident annual permit; the only US peer where OLAs are funded primarily through user fees.

PERMIT REVENUE RING-FENCED

Enterprise Fund

Revenue goes to the Off-Leash Dog Park Enterprise Fund, a dedicated OLA budget line.

INDEPENDENT PARK BOARD

Own taxing authority

MPRB is a separate taxing district with its own elected commissioners, outside City Council.

Permit structure

MINNEAPOLIS RESIDENT, FIRST DOG	\$38 annual
MINNEAPOLIS RESIDENT, EACH ADDITIONAL DOG	\$27 annual
NON-RESIDENT, FIRST DOG	\$66 annual
NON-RESIDENT, EACH ADDITIONAL DOG	\$38 annual
DAILY PERMIT (ANY VISITOR)	\$5 per dog
HOURS	6 AM – 10 PM
ORDINANCE	PB2-18 , a dedicated ordinance for off-leash areas

Governance

Like Vancouver, Minneapolis has an **independently-elected park body**: the MPRB is a separate taxing district with its own elected Board of Commissioners. Park Board decisions, including OLA siting, permit rates and rule changes, sit outside the City Council's jurisdiction.

Funding

Operations: the Off-Leash Dog Park Enterprise Fund is a ring-fenced budget line funded almost entirely by permit revenue. MPRB publishes the fund's revenue and expenses in its annual CAFR. Capital for new OLAs comes from MPRB's general capital budget (property-tax-funded), separate from the Enterprise Fund.

COMPARISON WITH SEATTLE

Minneapolis's permit system is the only live US precedent for OLA permit revenue funding OLA operations. If every one of roughly 180,000 dogs in Minneapolis carried a \$38 annual permit, that would generate ~\$7M/yr, more than twenty times the \$328,345 Seattle budgeted for off-leash areas in 2023. Whether a permit model is politically viable in Seattle is a separate question; it exists as a live precedent.

SOURCES: [MPRB – Dog Parks](#) · [Minnehaha OLA / permit info](#) · [Minneapolis pet licensing \(separate from MPRB permits\)](#) · [MPRB 2018 CAFR](#)

New York City: the shared-use hours model

NYC operates both dedicated fenced dog runs and a city-wide [Off-Leash Hours policy](#) formally codified on April 10, 2007 (informally since ~1986). In designated areas of participating parks, licensed and vaccinated dogs may be off-leash from park-opening until 9 AM and from 9 PM until park-close. The designated footprint spans dozens of parks across all five boroughs.

SHARED-USE HAS RUN FOR TWO DECADES

19 years

Formally codified 2007; informal operation since ~1986.

DOGS OFF-LEASH OUTSIDE PEAK HOURS

9 PM – 9 AM

Parks remain dog-friendly at low-traffic times and leash-only when busy.

PARTICIPATING PARKS IN FIVE BOROUGHES

dozens

Central Park alone has 23 dog-friendly zones.

How it works

Participating parks designate specific zones where dogs may be off-leash during the two daily windows. Outside those windows, normal leash rules apply and are enforced by NYPD, NYC Parks Enforcement Patrol, Department of Health, and Department of Sanitation. Dogs must be licensed and currently vaccinated for rabies; owners must be present and in control. Central Park has 23 dog-friendly areas (no enclosed dog runs). Prospect Park uses 5–9 AM and 9 PM–1 AM. Forest Park, Riverside Park, Van Cortlandt, and dozens of neighborhood parks participate under the citywide framework.

Outcomes evidence

NYC does not publish a longitudinal evaluation: no official report with trend lines for citations, complaints, or injury rates. What stands in for it is durability, nineteen years of formal operation across multiple administrations, no reversal, and no sustained move to repeal the policy. NRPA's November 2018 *Parks & Recreation* law-review treats the NYC model as the mature US example; Boston and Chicago run parallel variations.

COMPARISON WITH SEATTLE

NYC runs shared-use off-leash hours across dozens of parks alongside its dedicated dog runs. Seattle runs 14 fenced OLAs with no shared-use hours, no voice-control areas and no time-zoned access. A Seattle pilot of this model, instrumented to track citations, Find It Fix It complaints, injury reports, and post-session cleanliness audits (as [the opinion page](#) proposes), would produce quantitative outcomes data of a kind NYC's 19-year history does not supply.

SOURCES: NYC Parks – Off-Leash Hours Policy Approved (April 10, 2007) · NYC Parks – Dog-Friendly Areas directory · NYC Council – Dog Run & Off-Leash Area Locations · NRPA Parks & Recreation – Courtesy Hours (Nov 2018) · NYC Rules §161.03 – Control of Dogs

Austin, TX: the acreage-headline caveat

Austin is cited in several popular "most dog-friendly cities" rankings for its large off-leash acreage (~682 acres). That figure is not apples-to-apples for peer comparison: Austin counts large natural-area parks with voice-control designation, rather than the fenced dedicated OLAs that Seattle, Portland, and most peer cities count. The fenced-OLA comparable is closer to ~80 acres, one-eighth of the headline.

APPLES-TO-APPLES WITH SEATTLE

~80 ac

Fenced off-leash acreage, the figure used for cross-city comparison.

HEADLINE TOTAL (ALL DEFINITIONS)

682 ac

Includes 293-ac Walnut Creek Metro Park and natural-area voice-control sites.

~2× SEATTLE PER CAPITA

0.78 ac / 10,000

Fenced OLA acreage per capita vs Seattle's 0.38. On dog-parks-per-100,000 (TPL), Austin's 1.28 is below Seattle's 1.82.

[Austin Parks & Recreation](#) maintains a directory of 16 off-leash areas that distinguishes fenced dog parks, voice-control dog zones, and natural-area off-leash sites. Cross-city headline rankings work if everything on that list is included; capital-cost-per-acre

comparison to Seattle or Portland fenced sites does not.

The [peer-cities.csv](#) carries both numbers for Austin and uses the fenced-only figure (ola_acres_total_est = 80) for per-capita math, with Walnut Creek Metropolitan Park's 293-acre voice-control footprint called out as the biggest single inflator. Any peer-city comparison on this site that cites Austin uses the adjusted figure.

NOTES ON INTERPRETATION

When Austin is cited as a comparison city, which figure is being quoted matters. The 682-acre number is real but not directly comparable to Seattle's fenced 30.7 acres. The ~80-acre figure is the fenced-only comparator, and on that basis Austin has roughly 2× Seattle's fenced-OLA acreage per capita (0.78 ac/10,000 vs 0.38). On dog-parks-per-100,000 (TPL's count), Austin trails Seattle (1.28 vs 1.82).

SOURCES: [Austin PARD – Dog Parks & Off-Leash Areas](#) · [TPL 2025 ParkScore Austin](#) · [data/peer-cities.csv](#)
(provenance column documents the adjustment)

Boise, ID: layered access in a smaller city

Boise has roughly a third of Seattle's population and more than four times the dog parks per capita, using each city's own published count. This peer is relevant because the supply gap is not explained by city size or density alone.

FENCED PERMANENT

7

Fenced-only, apples-to-apples with Seattle's 14, still ~1.7× per capita on the same population denominators. (TPL counts the combined 18 below.)

SEASONAL / TIME-WINDOWED

11

Designated-hours off-leash access at existing multi-use parks. Boise PARD's published count of 18 = these 11 + the 7 fenced; the 7.60 / 100,000 figure used in Part I uses the combined 18.

POPULATION

240,000

Roughly one-third of Seattle's 816,000.

Boise's off-leash system has two layers Seattle does not: **seven fenced permanent** sites comparable to what Seattle counts, plus **eleven additional parks with designated off-leash hours** in the existing multi-use park network. The seasonal program (Ann Morrison Park, Optimist and Simplot Sports Complexes) allows dogs off-leash during winter months when sports fields are inactive.

NOTES ON INTERPRETATION

A common response to Seattle's OLA count is that the city is too dense to build more dog parks. Boise is smaller rather than denser, so a population-scale argument is testable here. Boise runs 7 fenced sites for 240,000 people; Seattle runs 14 for 816,000. The gap narrows when fenced-only methodology is applied uniformly, but Boise's seasonal program then adds 11 more sites. The two-layer model (permanent fenced plus time-windowed shared-use) is the design choice Seattle has not used.

DATA NOTE

peer-cities.csv carries the combined count (18) for headline per-capita math. For fenced-only comparability to Seattle, use 7. Both figures are in the Boise PARD directory; the `counting_methodology` column flags the mix.

SOURCES: [Boise Parks & Recreation – Dogs Off-Leash Parks & Areas](#) · [data/peer-cities.csv](#)

Observations across the eight peers

Four observations emerge from the per-city detail above:

1. **No peer publishes a dog-park-specific walkshed standard.** Every peer uses the same 10-minute / half-mile standard that TPL, NRPA, ULI, NPS, and CDC use for parks generally. SPR's 2.5-mile OLA-specific standard is 5× the distance used by peer cities for parks overall.
2. **Two cities have elected park bodies (Vancouver, Minneapolis).** Those are also the two cities with the most detailed OLA planning documents and, in Minneapolis's case, the only dedicated OLA revenue model among the peers.
3. **DC is the only peer with OLA-specific legislation.** Seattle's OLAs exist under a 1997 Parks ordinance with no statutory definition, no required stewardship structure, and no required environmental review per site.
4. **Shared-use models are widely precedented.** Portland (voice-control), San Francisco (voice-control zones), Vancouver (time-zoned beaches), New York (Off-Leash Hours), Austin (voice-control natural areas), and Boise (seasonal time-windowed) each run a form of shared-use that Seattle does not currently use.

CROSS-PEER PATTERN

Six of the eight peer cities operate at least one form of shared-use, time-zoned, or voice-control access alongside fenced dedicated OLAs: Portland (voice-control), San Francisco (voice-control zones within larger parks), Vancouver (time-zoned beaches), New York (Off-Leash Hours), Austin (voice-control natural-area sites), and Boise (seasonal time-windowed). Seattle's all-fenced, single-designation model is not represented in this peer set.

THIS IS THE OPINION PAGE

Every other page on this site is factual. This one is signed editorial — principles, opinions, counterarguments, and a policy recommendation from the site's author. Data claims link back to the factual pages.

OPINION · SIGNED EDITORIAL · SEPTEMBER 2026

Seattle will not build its way out of this. *It needs a policy change.*

This is my take on what the data on this site shows, and what the city should do differently. This page is my opinion — everything else on the site is intended to be a factual reference.

BY **ANDRE VRIGNAUD**, QUEEN ANNE · 20+ YEARS USING SEATTLE'S PARKS WITH DOGS · PARTICIPATED IN SEATTLE PARKS & RECREATION'S (SPR) 2014–2017 PEOPLE, DOGS AND PARKS STRATEGIC PLAN LIVE INTERVIEWS



SEATTLE DOG PARK POLICY IN A NUTSHELL.

I'll be upfront — I own dogs, I walk them in Seattle's parks, I run them off-leash, and I have a strong opinion about how the city has managed off-leash access. The rest of this site is deliberately neutral. This page isn't. What follows is four principles I think most reasonable Seattle residents can get behind, three opinions that fall out of the data, the best arguments against me, and a recommendation I've been sharing with the city, council candidates, and SPR since 2014.

WHY THIS SITE EXISTS

I've been collecting data on Seattle's off-leash situation for twenty years. When [Axios Seattle](#) asked for thoughts on the latest round of this debate, I realized I could stop pasting numbers into Nextdoor threads and put them somewhere permanent — so I used Claude to turn my messy notes into this site. The data pages are fact. This page is opinion. If you take one thing away, take this: the current policy is demonstrably broken, and doing the same thing for another decade won't change anything. The specifics of my proposal matter far less than that.

The broader argument: *this is a hard problem.*

This is a hard problem, with no clean answer that leaves everyone satisfied. Park space in a dense, land-scarce city is finite, and the people asking for more of it all have legitimate claims — dog owners, soccer leagues, community gardeners, neighbors who want a quiet lawn, kids who want a playground, runners, cyclists, birders. Several of them are right at the same time.

I have empathy for the council members, mayors, and SPR staff who've taken a run at this over the last two decades. They've held listening sessions, commissioned studies, drafted plans, spent years trying to site new dog parks — finally funding two more, now expected in 2027 and 2028, after a thirteen-year gap — and absorbed the complaints from everyone who didn't get what they wanted. Sit down with this in good faith and you run into the same walls every time — land, money, competing uses, neighborhood opposition. And any real change here upsets someone: more access for dogs feels like a loss to people who'd rather be in parks without them, and the status quo leaves 150,000+ dogs and their owners exactly where the rest of this site documents.

I don't have the perfect answer. But after twenty years of running the same playbook — study, listen, plan a park, repeat, with the first new off-leash areas (OLAs) since 2013 still not under construction — the data on this site shows the approach isn't closing the gap. It isn't even keeping pace. At some point, continuing to run a strategy that measurably isn't working becomes its own choice. The alternative I think is worth a real look is a time-zoned shared-use model, borrowed from cities that have run it for decades.

Part One: four principles

These aren't numbers — they're values plus factual observations. I think most reasonable Seattle residents, dog owners and non-owners alike, can sign on to them.

P1 Seattle will never build its way out of the OLA shortage.

Zero net dog parks added since 2013 — thirteen years and counting — while the population grew 34% from 2010. The two funded sites won't open before 2027 and 2028. Even if SPR eventually builds every site on its current list, the per-capita gap to Portland, San Francisco, and Vancouver BC doesn't close. Seattle is physically constrained: dense, land-scarce, expensive parcels, already-extensive parks to maintain.

SUPPORTING DATA ON THIS SITE

[Residents per OLA, 2010–2026](#) · [Peer-city per-capita comparison](#) · [Per-capita OLA acreage](#) · [Trust for Public Land \(TPL\) 2025 ParkScore](#)

P2 The little buildable land Seattle has should not go to dog parks first.

Seattle's in the middle of a long housing-affordability crisis and an ongoing homelessness emergency. When a rare parcel of city land comes loose, the case for housing, shelter, or services is stronger than the case for a new fenced dog park. I own dogs and I still believe this. Any serious plan to improve off-leash access has to start from the assumption that we're *not* getting more than a handful of small new OLAs over the coming decade — and that even a substantial funding increase *would not be enough* to close the gap. The land isn't there; no dollar figure conjures it into existence.

P3 Seattle has more dogs than children, and the investment gap reflects that poorly.

Yes, kids should be prioritized over dogs. A city with 157 playgrounds and 14 dog parks is making a choice about who its parks are for, and on that axis the choice is right. A 1:1 split would be absurd.

The *magnitude* of the gap has gone past any reasonable prioritization. Even at the conservative 150,000 floor, dogs outnumber Seattle's ~115,000 under-18s — yet SPR runs 157 playgrounds against 14 fenced OLAs, the off-leash budget line has never reached **half of one percent** of SPR spending, and they occupy **0.46%** of the city's parkland ([the numbers](#)). Prioritizing kids is right; arriving at a tenth of one percent of the budget, in the years before the current construction money, for a population the size of all dog owners is how we got here.

SUPPORTING DATA ON THIS SITE

[Playgrounds for kids vs OLAs for dogs](#) · [OLA share of the SPR budget](#) · [OLA share of parkland](#)

P4 People who don't want to be around dogs have a right not to be. So do kids who want a clean field.

Non-negotiable. Every dog owner I respect accepts this. Kids who are afraid of dogs, adults who don't want a strange dog in their face, picnickers, joggers, people using the park for a dozen other reasons — none of them signed up to share space with an unfamiliar off-leash dog. A playfield with dog feces on it, or a baseball diamond where someone's loose dog just ran through left field, is a system failure on every axis. The current setup, where about 38% of dog owners self-report illegal off-leash use, fails these residents directly: non-owners have a city full of parks that are technically dog-free but in practice aren't, and dog owners have a few tiny, often-unsafe OLAs. Both groups lose. Whatever fix comes next has to give each use reliable time in the park, and protect non-dog use at least as well as the current system pretends to.

SUPPORTING DATA ON THIS SITE

[SPR's own 2015 survey on illegal off-leash use](#) · [7,015 enforcement contacts 2014–2026](#)

Part Two: three opinions that fall out of the data

01 The current rules have failed, and Seattle is doubling down on the part that isn't working.

In 2014 the Seattle City Council asked SPR to rethink off-leash policy. SPR spent over a year running surveys and in-person interviews with dog owners, parents, Citizens for Off-Leash Areas (COLA), and neighborhood groups. The consistent feedback was that the pre-2014 policy was unworkable, enforcement was structurally insufficient, and other cities had already tried shared-use or time-zoned models worth studying. The [resulting People, Dogs and Parks Strategic Plan](#) kept the same framework, added one full-time animal-control officer, and declined to pilot any shared-use approach. In the years since, the OLA count hasn't moved, and illegal off-leash use has if anything grown with the dog population.

The city's answer has been to expand enforcement. But more officers won't change behavior, because the binding constraint isn't headcount — it's authority. Animal Control Officers are not police: they can't compel identification or detain, so by Finance & Administrative Services' own 2022 report to Council, officers now “issue verbal warnings on all first contacts” ([the documented detail](#)). Deterrence is the product of two numbers — the probability of being cited and the size of the penalty — and in Seattle both sit near the floor. The probability is tiny (well under 1% per dog per year, and only 21 actual citations in all of 2024), and the penalty is capped: first offenses are \$0 or \$54, the practical ceiling is about \$162, and pushing fines higher just turns them into a regressive access fee the wealthy absorb ([Q2](#)). And no amount of patrol manufactures a legal place to run a dog where none exists.

It does cost real money, and since July 2026 we know how much. The Park District approved three officers in 2023, and SPR was billed for three from the start — **\$456,173 in 2024 alone**, on invoices computed from a flat 40-hour week rather than from hours worked — while the Animal Shelter was telling SPR it could field one and a half to two officers. SPR's own manager reviewed the output in 2024 and recommended cutting the program. Leadership sent it back at three. The dollar amount matters less than where it goes: into a

lever the city's own agency says doesn't move behavior ([enforcement: funded, billed, deployed](#)). Redirect that spend to a clean-park compliance model — time-zoned shared use plus post-session cleanup, per the [recommendation](#) below — and you'd put a far larger presence in parks at the moments they actually need it.

SUPPORTING DATA ON THIS SITE

[Contacts, citations and cost per year](#) · [No evaluation exists](#) · [Kinnear case study](#)

02 Fines will never work — not at any amount Seattle could plausibly adopt.

The numbers: 7,015 off-leash enforcement contacts between January 2014 and April 2026, of which 3,151 were actual citations, against a dog population of at least 150,000. At the city-wide average that's well under a 0.5% chance per dog per year of being cited, and falling. Treat that as a rough figure, not a statistic: owners who never off-leash have zero exposure, owners at high-patrol parks face more, owners where rangers don't patrol face close to zero. What the data does support: **about 89% of contacts were first offenses** at \$0 or \$54. Second offense is \$109, third \$136, fourth-plus \$162. Even at the [code's](#) ceiling it gets absorbed by higher-income owners as a de-facto access fee, and raising it further hits a regressive-enforcement problem — the same \$500 fine that's meaningful to a lower-income owner is a rounding error to a wealthy one. The fine-based model is structurally mismatched to the behavior.

SUPPORTING DATA ON THIS SITE

[Full enforcement analysis](#) · [data/enforcement-citations.csv](#)

03 Dog owners will keep running dogs off-leash under the current rules. For rational reasons.

People break the law here because the legal option is often worse. Nine in ten Seattle residents have no legal OLA within a 10-minute walk ([walkshed analysis](#)). Where one exists, it's often too small to use safely — [seven of 14 are under one acre](#), three under a quarter-acre; Kinnear (0.124 acre) posts a sign asking anyone with more than three dogs to go elsewhere. Several sit in or next to [areas with chronic safety concerns](#) that make them effectively unusable, especially for women, after dark, or alone. It's a supply failure producing a compliance failure, and the city's own enforcement agency said as much to Council in 2022: “The lack of available Off Leash Areas could encourage pet owners to take their dogs off leash in regular City parks” ([FAS, June 2022](#)). No amount of enforcement addresses the underlying cause.

Part Three: the best arguments against me

These are pulled from a 147-comment [April 2021 Nextdoor thread about Queen Anne Playfield](#) where neighbors on both sides engaged substantively. Every argument here was made by a real neighbor, not a strawman. Where the

counterargument is correct, I say so.

c1 The objections I mostly agree with.

"Dogs are not allowed on this playfield. The rules are clear. Follow them." Correct: [SMC 18.12.080](#) is unambiguous and athletic playfields are dedicated to organized play. My argument isn't that individual rule-breaking is justified. It's that the rule has failed at the system level, and the fix is policy change. *"Having a dog is a privilege, not a right. Don't expect public resources to subsidize that choice."* Agreed in the narrow sense, and the wrong frame for a policy question: SPR's own plan estimates 150,000 dogs in the city, roughly one for every four residents, and a city that allocated [a tenth of one percent of its parks budget](#) to a constituency that size, before the current round of construction money, has an allocation problem, not a rights problem. *"The ratio of dogs to children isn't a basis for the OLA budget."* Correct; it's a scale indicator, not a prescription, and I'm not arguing that a quarter of the parks budget should go to OLAs. *"There's no land, and if there were it should go to housing."* Yes, and yes — see P2, and the twenty years the Queen Anne Community Council's Parks Chair has spent watching sites at MacLean Park, David Rogers Park and Smith Cove get rejected. That's exactly why my recommendation isn't "build a lot more OLAs." *"Lobby for change. Don't break the law."* The first half is completely fair; a parent at softball practice didn't set SPR's OLA allocation. On the second: people have lobbied, for decades, and the city's answer has been to [expand enforcement of a failing law](#). At some point "lobby harder" stops being a serious response.

c2 "Off-leash dogs cause real harm to other park users. I've seen it."

Confirmed — multiple times, by non-advocates, at the same park. In the thread referenced above, one neighbor documented a small off-leash dog running at an 8-year-old's feet at Big Howe. Another described a flag football game at Queen Anne Playfield being paused several times because a single off-leash dog kept running into play. A softball parent described her daughter's practice where "every practice the girls are stepping in dog poop." These are real, and they strengthen the case for a structured shared-use model rather than weaken it. The current setup produces these incidents *despite* the law, because [enforcement is structurally insufficient](#). A time-zoned model with dedicated cleanup staff directly addresses each of these by reserving prime athletic hours for athletic use and pairing the off-leash window with visible compliance staff.

c3 "Fine, but don't fantasize that a shared-use pilot will actually be enforced any better than the current rule."

Fair and concrete. If the city can't enforce "no dogs ever on athletic fields," why would it enforce "no dogs on athletic fields from 9 AM to 9 PM"? Two answers. First, the *shape* of the rule is different — a time-bounded window is something an owner can plan around, which the current blanket rule isn't. Second, the [recommendation](#) redirects the enforcement budget away from citations and toward on-site compliance monitoring at the

transition hours and post-session cleanup. You can't enforce every park every minute of every day. You *can* enforce a handful of designated parks at two specific transition points per day. That's tractable, and it's what [New York has done for nearly twenty years](#).

WHERE THIS PAGE COULD BE WRONG

The shared-use recommendation hasn't been piloted in Seattle, and its transferability from NYC, Boston, and Chicago isn't proven under Seattle-specific conditions (hills, rainfall, seasonal daylight, homelessness-response pressure). If a pilot ran and failed, the right response is to say so, document why, and try the next thing. My argument is that the current approach has measurably failed, and piloting a well-precedented alternative is a smaller ask than what the city is currently making — expanded enforcement of the approach that's already failing.

Part Four: SPR's own access standard proves the point

SPR's 2017 *People, Dogs and Parks Strategic Plan* defends current OLA coverage with an access claim that, once you look at it, is the clearest evidence of the framework's failure: most Seattle residents live within **2.5 miles** of an OLA. The Green Lake loop is [2.8 miles](#). SPR is effectively arguing that walking the Green Lake loop one-way to reach your dog park, and then walking it back, counts as reasonable access.

[Trust for Public Land's industry-standard metric](#) is **0.5 miles** — the same 10-minute walk SPR happily cites when noting 99% of Seattleites live within a 10-minute walk of a park, and the standard NRPA, the Urban Land Institute, the National Park Service, and the CDC all use. **SPR uses the tighter standard when celebrating its park system, and one 5× more permissive to paper over the OLA-specific failure.** It goes further than that. SPR told the City Council in December 2021 and again in August 2022 that "among the top 12 park systems in the country, TPL ranks Seattle in the top 5 in terms of access to dog parks per capita." Thirteen days before the second presentation, SPR's own policy staffer asked the deck's author to "point me to the source of that info." The records SPR released in July 2026 contain no reply and no source, and the claim went to Council unchanged ([PRR C266465](#)). TPL's published figure puts Seattle at 1.82 dog parks per 100,000 residents, below every West Coast peer. The absence of a reply in a records release isn't proof none was sent. But when the department's access claims to Council are the thing under examination, that's the record.

Part Five: what Seattle should actually do

Given the principles and the evidence, the realistic path forward is to change the policy about how dogs and people share the parks Seattle already has, rather than keep building small fenced OLAs. The model is New York's, which has run time-zoned off-leash hours formally since 2007 and informally for far longer. What its record shows, and doesn't, is laid out on [Part III](#).

THE RECOMMENDATION

A time-zoned shared-use policy for Seattle's parks.

Adopt a shared-use model similar to [New York City's long-standing off-leash hours policy](#) — early morning and evening windows in designated parks during which dogs may be off-leash under owner control, with the rest of the day reserved for traditional park use. Pair it with a different enforcement posture focused on shared-use compliance, not leash-law violations.

- 01 Designate shared-use parks by neighborhood.** Not every park participates. Parks with heavy children's programming — active playfields during league season, for instance — stay fully leashed

24/7. Parks that already show up in [the enforcement data](#) as places people off-leash anyway become eligible candidates.

-
- 02 Time-zone the access.** A model like NYC's — off-leash from park-opening to 9:00 AM and from 9:00 PM to park-closing — gives owners practical morning and evening windows and reserves prime daytime hours for general park use. Pilot it. Adjust the hours per park based on observed use.
-
- 03 Pivot enforcement from fines to compliance.** Redeploy SPR Animal Control and park rangers to monitor participating parks during off-leash hours — confirming owners are present, dogs are under control, and the park is left clean. That's a different job description from “drive 6,662 acres hoping to catch someone.”
-
- 04 Add clean-park staffing — call it poop patrol.** A dedicated crew does post-session sweeps of shared-use parks at the transition back to leashed hours. If a participating park is repeatedly found uncleaned, it can lose shared-use designation. That collective threat is the real enforcement mechanism — it gives every responsible owner at the park a stake in cleaning up after the minority who don't. Off-leash culture in practice runs on social pressure. Tickets and fines still apply to individual violators who get caught, but the enforcement that actually moves behavior is peer pressure plus a credible threat of losing shared-use status at the park level. A \$54 ticket handed out hours after the fact by an officer who wasn't there doesn't change anyone's behavior.
-
- 05 Fund it with expanded dog-license fees and redirected enforcement spend.** Seattle's dog-licensing revenue is modest. A meaningful increase, dedicated to the [Seattle Animal Shelter](#) and this new clean-park program, is far more politically viable than a fines increase, and it avoids the regressive-enforcement problem.
-
- 06 Keep the small dedicated OLAs.** Kinnear, Plymouth Pillars, Magnuson, and the rest don't go away. They stay as all-day off-leash options for people who want them. They just stop being the *entire* answer to a city-wide demand they were never sized to handle.
-
- 07 Measure and publish outcomes.** Track citation counts, Find-It-Fix-It complaints, injury reports, and post-session cleanliness audits by park. If a pilot park is underperforming on non-dog-user experience,

pull it. If it's working, expand. This is exactly what the City has never done for the program it runs now, and what NYC's record lacks. Seattle's evaluation could become the analysis that doesn't yet exist.

This approach was raised during the 2014–2017 SPR process, was supported by COLA and multiple participating community members, and was set aside as too hard to enforce. The [data this site has assembled](#) suggests the current approach is *also* too hard to enforce — 7,015 enforcement contacts over thirteen years, 3,151 of them actual citations, against 150,000+ dogs. If we're going to have a policy that's difficult to enforce either way, we should pick the one that could actually work if we did.

Part Six: what I'd ask of the City Council and the Mayor

This argument has been made to the city before. Many times. This is a request for one specific thing the Council, and the Council alone, can deliver.

The most recent city-commissioned effort to rethink this was the 2023–24 [SPR Off-Leash Area Expansion Study](#), produced at the Council's request explicitly to re-examine the approach. Read its recommendations alongside the 2017 *People, Dogs and Parks Strategic Plan* and the two documents are the same proposal in different cover pages: *identify a handful of additional OLA sites where geometry and funding permit, and increase enforcement against off-leash violations*. That was the pre-2014 plan. It was the 2017 plan. It is the 2024 plan. It has measurably failed to close the gap at every iteration, and the City has never once measured whether the enforcement half works.

Before the next study begins, the Council should put on the record that the 2023–24 Expansion Study returned an almost identical plan to the 2017 strategic plan, that the plan has measurably failed to close the gap at both junctures, and that returning a third time with the same framework is not an acceptable deliverable.

The charge to SPR — or to whichever body runs the next study — should explicitly require the production of at least one genuine alternative for Council consideration. A shared-use time-zoned pilot is one such idea. It's not the only one. Residents, peer cities, and practitioners outside SPR will have their own proposals if invited to offer them. Which specific alternative lands on the table matters less than that at least one does. A third round built on the same two levers — *build a few more OLAs, fine the off-leash violators* — is not an acceptable deliverable. Either or both might be components of a larger plan. Neither can be the core of it.

The Council has the standing here that individual advocates and SPR itself don't. SPR works with the mandate it's given. If the mandate keeps asking for a version of the same answer, it will keep getting a version of the same answer. Making “same plan, different

cover page” an unacceptable outcome is the one thing only the Council can do.

Acknowledgments: the people who have been trying

This page argues that Seattle has failed at the OLA question. It hasn't failed because nobody tried. A few of the people who have, by name.

[Queen Anne Community Council Parks Committee](#) — two-plus decades of organized volunteer advocacy on Queen Anne parks, including the hilltop OLA question. Don Harper, who chairs the committee, has been the most visible single voice on it. QACC secured the 2008 levy funding that ultimately produced Kinnear and Magnolia Manor, and has attempted sites at MacLean Park, David Rogers Park and Smith Cove. Still at it.

[Citizens for Off-Leash Areas \(COLA\)](#) — the 501(c)(3) that has organized volunteer advocates, maintained OLA surveys and inventory data, and participated in every major SPR planning process since the 1990s. Every advocate who comes to this issue fresh builds on their work.

Magnuson Off Leash Group (MOLG) — for twenty-plus years, MOLG's volunteer stewardship made Magnuson the functional model of what a neighborhood-governed OLA can be. The group's public presence has since gone dark, but the [recommendation](#) on this page borrows explicitly from the model it built.

Seattle Parks and Recreation staff — this page is critical of SPR's policy choices, and SPR has been asked to do an impossible job in one of the densest, most land-constrained cities in the country, balancing kids, leagues, dog owners, wildlife, and a housing emergency on every square foot. The 2014–2017 process was sincere and the staff who ran it worked hard. My criticism is narrower: the resulting plan repeated the pre-2014 framework rather than piloting an alternative, and it's being repeated again. SPR is the right partner to run the pilot that tries something else.

Elected officials who've engaged substantively — then-candidate and later Councilmember Andrew Lewis (District 7, 2019–2023) was the most visible elected voice on this issue during his term. If you're a current council member or staffer, the [records-request directory](#) is the list of questions we're asking SPR.

Dog owners who have changed their behavior, and park users who haven't given up — every owner who drives out of their way to a real OLA, every parent who keeps bringing their kid to the playfield anyway, every coach still running practice. The status quo is a tax everyone pays, and it doesn't have to stay that way.

CORRECTIONS AND CONTRIBUTIONS WELCOME

This page, and the site overall, will be updated when better data comes in or when I've gotten something wrong. If you have primary sources, corrections, or additional data — especially on Seattle's land availability, dog population, or peer-city shared-use outcomes — email seattledogparkdata@ozymandi.as or file an issue on the [repo](#). If you're one of the people named above and would like a correction, an addition, or a removal, just say so.

— Andre Vrignaud

NOTES ON THIS PAGE

This page is opinion. The principles, opinions, and recommendation above are mine. The data claims underneath them link back to the factual pages on this site, to public records, or to published primary sources.

Relationship to the 2014–2017 SPR process. I participated in the *People, Dogs and Parks Strategic Plan* live interviews as a community member. I'm not and have never been an SPR employee, a COLA board member, or an elected official. My views are personal.

On the “more dogs than children” figure. The 150,000-dog floor used throughout this site is conservative. [Part I's methodology note](#) walks through three independent estimates — a Seattle Open Data licensed floor (~26,700 active licenses), an AVMA-derived demographic estimate (~249,000), and the SPR 2023 Expansion Study range (187,000–400,000). The 150,000 floor sits below all of them by design.

The data, and *how it was counted.*

Every figure on this site comes from a public record or a script in the repository. This page collects the raw files, the methodology, and the per-page data notes that used to sit at the foot of each report, so the report pages stay short and the working detail stays findable.

Primary data

the CSV files

Methodology & caveats

the four that bite

The Gap

raw comparison data

The Gap

data notes

Access

data notes

Enforcement

data notes

Budget

raw budget table

Budget

data notes

Peer Cities

data notes

Primary *data*.

All underlying data lives in the GitHub repo under [/data](#). Plain CSVs; no database, no build step, no login required. Download any file, run your own numbers, and tell us if we got something wrong.

seattle-olas.csv	14 existing OLAs
seattle-timeseries.csv	population / budget / OLA count, 2010–2026
peer-cities.csv	Portland, SF, Vancouver BC, Austin, etc.
planned-olas.csv	funded & planning
kinneer-timeline.csv	20-year incident chronology
enforcement-citations.csv	7,015 off-leash enforcement records, PRRs C049204 (SPR) + C263949 (FAS)
enforcement-by-park-year.csv	citations aggregated by park & year
SOURCES.md	primary sources, cited

Methodology & *caveats*.

This site favors explicit methodology over headline-friendly numbers. Every finding on the report pages links back to its underlying CSV and, where applicable, to the script that produced it. The master reference is [METHODOLOGY.md](#), the "show your work" index. A few caveats readers should also carry:

- **Walkshed (now network-based).** Previously a straight-line estimate of ~33% of residents; replaced April 2026 with a proper network-distance analysis: **11.7% of Seattle residents** live within a 10-minute walking path of an OLA, computed via [scripts/compute_walkshed.py](#) (osmnx against Seattle's full OSM walk network) and [scripts/population_coverage.py](#) (2020 Census block-group overlay, area-weighted). SPR's published 2.5-mile standard covers 76.6%.
- **Peer-city OLA counts differ in definition.** Seattle counts only dedicated OLAs (12 fully fenced, two partially); Portland includes unfenced voice-control areas; Vancouver BC includes time-restricted shared-use areas. Direct comparison requires caveats.

- **OLA-specific budget.** SPR's Park District "Maintaining Parks & Facilities" line funds both OLAs and P-Patch community gardens and is not broken out. The \$100,000/year Cycle 1 figure is OLA-only because SPR stated it publicly; Cycle 2 figures are combined.
- **Dog population.** Triangulated from three independent sources: [~26,700 active dog licenses](#) (Seattle Open Data, hard floor implying ~90–135,000 actual), an [AVMA-derived demographic estimate](#) of ~248,900, and the [SPR 2023 Expansion Study](#) range of 187,000–400,000. The site uses 150,000 as a conservative floor for per-dog math; see [Part I methodology](#) for the full triangulation.

FROM: [THE GAP](#)

The Gap: raw comparison data

Exact figures from Trust for Public Land's 2025 ParkScore, except Vancouver BC (not in the U.S. dataset).

CITY	POPULATION	PARKLAND ACRES	% CITY AREA	DOG PARKS	PER 100,000	\$/CAPITA	PARKSCORE RANK
Seattle, WA	816,600	6,662	12.6%	14	1.82	\$418	8
Portland, OR	660,000	13,029	15.8%	38	5.74	\$274	9
San Francisco, CA	870,000	6,398	21.4%	42	5.03	\$561	6
Vancouver, BC (est.)	662,000	~3,000 ha	~11%	36	5.44	n/a	n/a
Austin, TX	1,025,000	18,437	9.0%	13	1.28	\$211	54
Boise, ID	240,000	~3,400	~10%	18	7.60	n/a	n/a

Seattle time series: population vs. OLA count

YEAR	POPULATION	OLAS	RESIDENTS / OLA	SPR BUDGET (ALL FUNDS)	OLA IMPROVEMENT \$
2010	608,660	11	55,333	—	—
2016	704,400	14	50,314	~\$156M	\$100,000
2017	724,745	14	51,768	\$163M (ops only)	\$100,000
2019	753,700	14	53,836	\$247.7M	\$160,757
2020	737,015	14	52,644	\$261.9M	\$338,000
2021	733,400	14	52,386	\$228.1M (COVID)	\$322,912
2023	779,200	14	55,657	\$328.2M	\$569,561
2024	797,700	14	56,979	\$320.7M	\$584,343
2025	816,600	14	58,329	\$339.4M	\$1,829,717
2026 (proj.)	~832,000	14	59,429	\$506.9M (proposed)	\$1,845,706

FROM: [THE GAP](#)

The Gap: data notes

About this data

Population and budget data are current through Seattle Parks & Recreation's (SPR) 2025–26 proposed budget and Washington Office of Financial Management (OFM) April 2025 estimates. Peer-city comparisons use the Trust for Public Land (TPL) 2025 ParkScore. Any of the figures below that are approximate, contested, or derived rather than citable are flagged in the "Data notes" at the bottom of the page. Corrections and better primary sources are welcome; see [the overview](#).

Dog park count methodology. Trust for Public Land and City of Seattle both count 14 OLAs. Definitions of "dog park" vary between cities: Portland counts unfenced designated off-leash areas, Vancouver BC counts 36 including time-restricted unfenced areas, and Seattle counts only dedicated sites (12 fully fenced; Magnuson and I-5 Colonnade partially). Adjusting for these definitional differences does not close the per-capita gap.

OLA opening years (corrected September 2026). Opening years follow SPR's [People, Dogs & Parks Plan](#) (Aug 2017): eight sites from the 1996–99 pilot, I-5 Colonnade, Plymouth Pillars and Regrade in 2005, Denny and Magnolia Manor in 2012, Kinnear in 2013. The plan separately records Kinnear as made permanent in 2014 and Magnolia Manor in 2015 (year_permanent in [seattle-olas.csv](#)); the plan's own Section 7 table gives Magnolia Manor's second date as 2016. Through July 2026 this site used dates taken from SPR's individual park pages, which put the last opening in 2009 and gave a 2010 count of 14; both were wrong, and the headline that rested on them (a 17-year gap dating from 2009) has been corrected to thirteen years since 2013. The 2010 baseline is 11 OLAs, matching the plan's reference to "the 11 off-leash areas in existence" at the 2011 SPR study.

Planned sites. Through July 2026 this site said both funded OLAs would open in late 2026. SPR's project pages now give construction starting late 2026 or early 2027, with Othello complete in fall 2027 and West Seattle Stadium in winter 2028; the verbatim statements are archived in [sources/spr-ola-project-status-2026.md](#). SPR's pages give the Park District two-OLA line as \$3,103,000, and that money is booked inside the Maintaining Parks & Facilities line rather than beside it ([PRR C264837](#)). Ravenna Park was selected for design only; its construction is unfunded.

OLA improvement budget. The Park District's "Maintaining Parks & Facilities" Budget Summary Level (BC-PR-50000) funds both dog off-leash areas *and* community P-Patch gardens. The budget books report the two together, but SPR books them as separate Master Projects and released the split for 2023–2026 in July 2026 ([PRR C264837](#)). Cycle 1 is \$106,000/year per SPR's 2017 plan. No OLA-only record exists for 2019–2022.

SPR budget comparisons. Seattle's 2016–2018 SPR budgets of ~\$156M–\$168M are General Fund + core operating only; from 2019 forward the published figures are all-funds (operating + capital). To avoid methodology drift, the stat tile at the top of this page uses the 2019→2025 all-funds comparison (\$247.7M → \$339.4M, +37%). The log-scale budget chart in Finding 04 plots both eras on one axis with the methodology shift noted.

Dog population estimates: three independent sources bracketing the same range.

Seattle does not universally license dogs, so dog-population figures are estimates. This site triangulates three:

- **Licensed floor:** [26,652 active dog licenses](#) (rounded to ~26,700 in prose) as of the April 1, 2026 snapshot of Seattle Open Data dataset [j.guv-t9rb](#) (published by Finance & Administrative Services [FAS] / Seattle Animal Shelter). A hard lower bound, because every

dog counted is a real paid license. Widely estimated to represent 20–30% of actual dogs, implying ~90,000–135,000 total. Per [PRR C264029](#), annual dog-license issuance fell ~21% over 2014–2025 (24,309 → 19,219), so the licensed share is declining over time. See the licensing finding above.

- **AVMA-derived demographic estimate:** [American Veterinary Medical Association \(AVMA\) 2025 Pet Ownership Sourcebook](#) reports 45.5% of U.S. households own a dog, averaging 1.5 dogs per dog-owning household. Applied to Seattle's [364,627 households \(ACS 1-year 2023\)](#): $364,627 \times 0.455 \times 1.5 \approx 248,900$ dogs. Limitation: AVMA publishes state-level data in the paywalled Sourcebook, so the rate used here is the national figure as a Seattle proxy.
- **SPR upper bound:** the [SPR 2023–24 OLA Expansion Study](#) cites estimates ranging from ~187,000 to "upwards of 400,000."

All three estimates cluster between ~90,000 and ~400,000. The site uses the **AVMA-derived ~248,900** as its canonical dog-population number and names the **150,000 conservative floor** whenever a claim benefits from understating. The public records request to the Seattle Animal Shelter ([PRR #6](#), released June 2026 as [C264029](#)) **has now been answered**: it provided 2014–2025 licensed counts and revenue, and confirmed SAS holds **no** compliance or dog-population estimate of its own. See the licensing finding above.

Vancouver BC. Because Canada is not in the TPL ParkScore, Vancouver's data comes from its own Park Board documents (36 OLAs per the "People, Parks & Dogs Strategy") and current population estimates. Vancouver does not publish OLA-specific budget data in a format comparable to Seattle's.

Boise. Boise has led [TPL's dog-park-per-capita category](#) in recent years (7.6 per 100,000 in the 2025 ParkScore). It is not a true peer city in size or density, but is included as the national-best benchmark.

Playground count. Seattle's 157 playgrounds is from the TPL 2025 ParkScore data. This includes playgrounds in parks and schoolyards with joint-use agreements.

Primary sources

[Seattle Parks & Recreation budget books \(2021, 2023–24, 2025–26 proposed\)](#) · [Seattle Park District Cycle 1 \(2015–2020\) and Cycle 2 \(2023–2028\) financial plans](#) · [SPR "People, Dogs, and Parks Plan" \(2017\)](#) · [SPR "Off-Leash Area Expansion Study" \(2023–2024\)](#) · [Washington State OFM April 1 official population estimates](#) · [Trust for Public Land 2025 ParkScore Index \(city-level PDFs\)](#) · [Vancouver Park Board "People, Parks & Dogs Strategy" \(2017\)](#) · [Citizens for Off-Leash Areas \(COLA\) Seattle](#) · [Parkways \(SPR blog\)](#) · [Seattle Dog Spot](#) · [Cascade PBS](#) · [KUOW](#) · [The Urbanist](#) · [West Seattle Blog](#)

FROM: [ACCESS](#)

Access: data notes

About this data

Off-leash survey data referenced below is from Seattle Parks & Recreation's (SPR) 2015 owner survey of 3,970 dog owners, published in the 2017 [People, Dogs and Parks Strategic Plan](#) (p.17). The survey reported illegal off-leash use by setting: 39% in local parks and 38% in large parks

(weekly to monthly), 36% on park trails. This page blends the three to **about 38%** (their unweighted mean, 37.7%, rounded). That decade-old behavioral survey is the most recent public version and needs a current replacement. The Find-It-Fix-It complaint figure is now a primary source: the records request ([PRR #2](#)) has been answered as [C263990](#): ~3,010 “Nuisance Dogs in a Park” reports in 2025, replacing an earlier partial-year secondary figure for 2024. Corrections and better primary sources are welcome; see [the overview](#).

10-minute walkshed methodology. TPL defines the 10-minute walk as a half-mile service area along the public road network, cut by physical barriers (highways, tracks, rivers without bridges). TPL publishes the “99% of Seattle residents” figure using this methodology for all parks; TPL does not publish a dog-park-specific version. The OLA walkshed figures on this page (11.7% at 10-min, 76.6% at 2.5-mi) are computed in-repo: [scripts/compute_walkshed.py](#) runs osmnx against Seattle's OSM walk network (projected to UTM 10N; physical barriers respected) to compute per-OLA isochrones; [scripts/population_coverage.py](#) intersects the union with 2020 Census block-group population clipped to the Seattle city boundary. Each walk-area boundary is drawn as an alpha-shape ($\alpha=0.003$) over reachable network nodes. An alpha-shape hugs the street network's actual concavities rather than bridging across them the way a simpler convex outline would. A 0.3 km² area floor applies, and a convex-hull fallback for OLAs at the edge of OpenStreetMap (OSM) coverage (Westcrest is one). Output at [data/walkshed/population_coverage.csv](#); full methodology in [METHODOLOGY.md](#).

Citations outside the walkshed. The 71.9% figure counts enforcement records placed at one of 37 geocoded parks (4,299 records; 3,089 outside). Including the ~695 street-address records that geocode to a Census location, the figure is 73.4% (3,631 of 4,948). The site quotes 71.9% everywhere and reserves 73.4% for this note. Computed by [citation_walkshed_analysis.py](#); output in [citation-rate-by-walkshed-status.csv](#).

Fair-share deficit by ZIP. Fair share = a ZIP's licensed dogs × the citywide ratio of OLA acres to licensed dogs (30.66 ac / 24,393 dogs, about one acre per 800 dogs), using ZIPs wholly inside the city; deficit = actual OLA acres minus fair share. Ranked by acres short, the top five are 98103, 98122, 98107, 98116, 98105; ranked by dogs per OLA acre, 98109 and 98119 lead. Earlier versions of this page called SLU and Queen Anne the two largest deficits; that described the dogs-per-acre ranking, not the acre shortfall, and was corrected in September 2026. Table: [dogs-and-olas-by-zip.csv](#).

Amenities. Through July 2026 this page said 2 of 14 OLAs had lighting and 9 of 14 had water, attributed to SPR site pages that were not archived. The water figure now follows the City's own statement to Council (FAS SLI response, June 2022, PRR C266465 Bates 00524: “only one OLA provides water”); the lighting figure follows the only in-repo source, a 2021 COLA user survey. Neither has been confirmed by SPR; corrections welcome.

Peer-city acreage table. Seattle ~31 ac (14 sites, 0.38 ac per 10,000 residents; median 0.9 ac; largest Magnuson 9.0). Portland ~85 ac across 38 sites, mostly unfenced voice-control (1.29; largest fully fenced site Gabriel Park ~5 ac). San Francisco ~120 ac across 42 mixed sites (1.38; its largest commonly used off-leash area, Fort Funston, is GGNRA federal land whose off-leash access has been contested; the largest city-managed dog play area is ~4 ac). Vancouver BC ~168 ac across 36 sites, largely time-restricted beaches and fields (2.54). Austin ~80 fenced-comparable acres across 13 sites (0.78); the ~680-acre total sometimes cited externally includes the 293-acre Walnut Creek voice-control natural area. Values ±20% is reasonable; no peer city publishes a single authoritative inventory the way Seattle does.

Peer-city OLA counts. The methodological differences are real and material. Portland's 38 DOLAs (TPL 2025) include 20+ unfenced voice-control areas; Seattle counts zero unfenced sites. Redefining Seattle's approach to include unfenced designated sites (as several other cities do) would raise its count, though SPR has publicly stated a preference for fenced sites on liability and environmental-impact grounds. The comparison in this report uses each city's TPL ParkScore count.

OLA acreage and opening years. Per-OLA acreage is pulled from SPR's Dog Off-Leash Areas ArcGIS FeatureServer (April 2026) and cross-checked against SPR individual OLA pages; see [data/seattle-olas.csv](#). Opening years follow SPR's 2017 *People, Dogs & Parks Plan* (last opening: Kinnear, 2013); see the chronology note on [Part I](#).

Kinnear Park timeline. Drawn from contemporaneous reporting: Seattle Weekly (2007), Seattle Times (2008), Aussiedoodle Adventures (2020), Fix Homelessness (2023), KOMO News (2025). The 2008 Dewey Potter quote is verbatim from the Seattle Times piece.

“Dogs per OLA” calculation. Using the widely-cited 150,000 dog-population floor divided by 14 OLAs gives ~10,700 dogs per OLA; SPR's 2023 Expansion Study cites higher estimates (up to 400,000), which would raise the ratio to ~28,500.

Primary sources

[TPL 2025 ParkScore Seattle PDF](#) · [TPL ParkServe methodology documentation](#) · [Seattle Parks & Recreation individual OLA pages](#) · [SPR Off-Leash Area Expansion Study recommendations \(Parkways blog, Feb 2024\)](#) · [SPR People, Dogs and Parks Strategic Plan \(2017\)](#) · [KOMO News on Kinnear \(April & May 2025\)](#) · Seattle Weekly “Ruff Trade” (2007) · Seattle Times Queen Anne encampment clearing coverage (2008) · Queen Anne & Magnolia News OLA expansion coverage (Nov 2023) · [Portland Parks & Recreation DOLA list](#) · [Sniffspot](#) and [BringFido](#) (cross-referenced)

On framing. SPR foregrounds the city's overall park access, which is genuinely strong, and OLA investment has recently increased. TPL appropriately weights total park access more heavily than any single amenity. This report presents the specific slice of data that describes the off-leash system, computed on the same standards TPL and SPR use elsewhere. Related opinions and policy recommendations are kept on a separate [opinion page](#).

FROM: [ENFORCEMENT](#)

Enforcement: data notes

About this data

Citations on this page run from **January 1, 2014 through April 17, 2026**, combining two Seattle public-records requests (PRRs) to cover the full period: [C049204](#) for 2014–2018 and [C263949](#) for 2019 through April 17, 2026. Headline figures use “**Dog Loose in Park**” (DLP) citations, Seattle's off-leash violation under the [Seattle Municipal Code \(SMC\) 18.12.080\(A\)](#), so every year is measured the same way. Where 2019 appears in both requests, the fuller C263949 record is used. 2026 is a partial year (through April 17) and is marked as such on every chart. **New:** Finding 4 and the complaint figures in Finding 3 add **resident “Nuisance Dogs in a Park” complaints** (Find It Fix It, 2024–26, [PRR C263990](#)) as a separate, resident-reported read on off-leash activity: reports filed, not verified incidents. The page also cites Seattle dog-license counts ([PRR C264029](#)) for scale. **Citations vs. warnings (September 2026).** Every record carries a `case_result`: 3,151 Citation, 3,191 Verbal, 648 blank, 25 voided or dismissed. Through July 2026 this page called all 7,015 “citations”; it now calls them contacts or records and reserves “citation” for the Citation result. Verbal warnings appear only from 2018 (the 2014–2017 files record citations only), so cost per actual citation is shown from 2018.

Source & method

Citation records come from two Seattle public records requests. **C049204** (filed 2019-08-29, produced 2019-10-15 by SPR) covers Dog Loose in Park citations 2014-01-01 through 2019-10-15. **C263949** (filed 2026-04-17, produced May 2026 by Seattle FAS) covers all parks-related violations 2019-01-01 through 2026-04-17. Raw files and documenting READMEs are at [data/prr-responses/](#). The consolidated CSV ([enforcement-citations.csv](#)) is built by [build_enforcement_datasets.py](#) and checked by [verify_enforcement_data.py](#).

Why DLP-only, and the 2019 overlap

This page restricts to Dog Loose in Park citations across both requests so each year is measured identically. C263949's broader categories (license, scoop, permit-at-large, etc.; 517 additional post-2019 rows) stay in the consolidated CSV under `violation_category` but are not in the year series. Both PRRs contain 2019: C049204 ends 2019-10-15 (partial), C263949 covers the full year. The build uses C263949's full-year 2019 as authoritative, so the rebuilt 2019 figure (1,181 DLP) is higher than the legacy site's 1,029 (which was Jan–Oct only).

2026 is a partial year

C263949 ends April 17, 2026, day 107 of the year, about 29%. Charts mark 2026 as partial. Where a full-year comparison is needed, the annualized equivalent ($\text{YTD} \div 0.293$) is shown as a dashed marker, not treated as actual. The cost-per-citation and per-FTE lines stop at 2025 to avoid the partial-year denominator inflating the most recent point.

Headcount & cost assumptions

This page separates two numbers that are easy to conflate. **Funded ACO headcount** rose from one Animal Control Officer II (2016–2022, per the 2016 and 2021 MOAs) to **three** from 2023, when the Seattle Park District Board funded two additional positions. The 2023 MOA (Project PRF1602) billed SPR **\$454,652/yr** for three FTEs, \$151,551 each. The [2026 MOA](#) (signed May 2026) re-prices the same three positions to **\$528,279/yr** (\$176,093 each; top rate \$44.79→\$54.46/hr). Per officer the cost tracks wages, not scope (\$152,399 in 2021 → \$151,551 in 2023 → \$176,093 in 2026).

Lump sum or pay-as-used? It depends on the agreement. The 2023 MOA billed a flat 240 hours per pay period (three full FTE) with no actual-hours qualifier, and SPR's quarterly ledger backup (PRR C266465, Bates 00485 and 00653; extracted to [enforcement-moa-billing.csv](#)) shows it was billed that way: 40 hours × \$44.79 × 3 staff per week, computed from the weekdays in each month, **\$226,528 for the first half of 2023** (Q3–Q4 not produced) and **\$456,173 for 2024**. The 2025 MOA (signed July 2025) and the 2026 MOA switched to "up to three" officers billed on *hours actually worked*, with a \$508,695 and then \$528,279 cap; what SPR has been billed under them is not in the record (SPR noticed in September 2025 that no charge had posted). The SPR-side partner, a Facilities Maintenance Worker, left for a Park Ranger post in 2023 and was never replaced ("There is no current FMW working with the Animal Control Officers," SPR memo, Sept 2024, Bates 00360); the 2026 MOA pairs officers with existing Park Rangers instead. SPR publishes no per-partner off-leash line; the 2023 budget book's Park Safety Program package implies roughly \$73,000 per added maintenance laborer, below this page's ~\$140,000 estimate for the 2016–2022 pairing.

The cost series above therefore uses three bases, stated in [build_enforcement_metrics.py](#): 2014–2015, 0.5 ACO imputed from PRR context; 2016–2022, 0.75 then 1.0 ACO at the 2021 MOA rate plus the same FMW share at \$140,000 (\$292,399/yr combined from 2017); **2023–2024, the billed amounts** (\$453,056 annualized; \$456,173); 2025–2026, one officer at the 2025 and 2026 MOA rates (\$169,565; \$176,093) with no FMW. The 2025–26 rows are the softest: they assume one deployed officer because the Animal Shelter said it could field 1.5–2 and SPR said one was on parks, but actual-hours billing could put the real figure anywhere up to the cap. Through July 2026 this page held 2023–26 at one officer plus a maintenance worker and called the three-officer money unspent; the ledger corrected both.

Why citation output can fall while patrols continue (full detail)

An Animal Control Officer II holds a limited “special commission” that lets them issue citations, serve warrants, testify in court, retrieve state licensing records, and enter posted property, but it does **not** let them compel identification from someone who refuses, and neither ACOs nor their paired SPR partner (a Facilities Maintenance Worker under the 2023 MOA, an existing Park Ranger under the 2026 MOA, neither of them sworn police) can detain. Because a name is required to write an infraction, an owner who declines to identify themselves can lawfully be given only a verbal warning.

In its September 2022 report to the City Council, Finance & Administrative Services (FAS) stated the position directly: “only sworn officers have the sufficient level of commission to retrieve identification from resistant residents,” that Seattle Police “have historically assisted ACO IIs in obtaining identification” but “recently... have been unable to assist,” and that absent SPD help “SAS will continue to be unable to issue citations for leash law violations from people who refuse to show identification.” FAS reported it had “adjusted its approach... by issuing verbal warnings on all first contacts,” and that residents “regularly ignore officers’ requests for identification or simply walk away or flee when contacted” and use neighborhood social-media groups to share patrol locations. The records do not isolate what caused the post-2020 decline, but this is a city-documented mechanism by which patrols can be present and citation output still fall. Source: [FAS response to SLI FAS-003-B-001](#), Sept 30 2022, pp. 3–4 ([PRR C265341](#)).

Why the repeat-offender share hasn’t grown: several explanations fit

Two readings sit on top of each other and the records can’t pull them apart: the citation may genuinely change behavior, so few owners reach a second offense, *or* low volume simply means an officer rarely meets the same person twice. Two mechanical effects push the first-offense share up regardless of behavior: as citations fell after COVID, repeat encounters fell with them; and the crowd keeps refreshing, with new puppies, residents, and visitors arriving constantly. The avoidance and one-officer-against-a-large-crowd dynamics that suppress repeat citations are the same ones that hold total output down (see [Finding 1](#)). Any claim that enforcement is, or is not, “working” on repeat behavior would read more into this dataset than it can support.

Location quality

Of the 7,015 DLP citations, about 89% are confidently attributable to a named park (top contributors: Discovery 564, Magnuson 367, Volunteer 328, Woodland 291, Golden Gardens 227). The rest are street-address citations (geocoded separately, used in the walkshed heatmap in Finding 3) or blank locations (excluded from spatial analysis). Park-name canonicalization is documented in [METHODOLOGY.md](#).

FROM: [BUDGET](#)

Budget: the raw budget table

The full year-by-year data is in [data/budget-detail.csv](#), with a source column on every row. SPR totals are all-funds figures where available; the OLA-only column is populated where SPR publicly disclosed a split and left blank (visibly) where it was not. Where only the combined OLA + P-Patch line is available, that value is shown in its own column.

YEAR	CYCLE	SPR TOTAL	OLA + P-PATCH COMBINED	OLA-ONLY	OLA SPENT	OLA AS % OF SPR
2016	Cycle 1	\$156M	—	\$106,000	—	0.068%
2017	Cycle 1	\$163M	—	\$106,000	—	0.065%
2018	Cycle 1	\$168M	—	\$106,000	—	0.063%
2019	Cycle 1	\$247.7M	\$160,800	no record	—	—
2020	Cycle 1	\$261.9M	\$338,000	no record	—	—
2021	Cycle 1	\$228.1M	\$322,912	no record	—	—
2022	Cycle 1	\$287.7M	\$355,347	no record	—	—
2023	Cycle 2	\$328.2M	\$569,561	\$328,345	\$315,049	0.100%
2024	Cycle 2	\$320.7M	\$584,343	\$333,478	\$218,996	0.104%
2025	Cycle 2	\$339.4M	\$1.83M	\$1,568,818	\$368,398	0.462%
2026	Cycle 2	\$506.9M	\$1.85M	\$1,574,370	\$150,593	0.311%

FROM: [BUDGET](#)

Budget: data notes

About this data

SPR total budget figures are drawn from published Seattle budget books. Since 2019, SPR's Maintaining Parks & Facilities line item (Budget Summary Level [BSL] **BC-PR-50000**) has funded both off-leash areas *and* P-Patch community gardens, and the city has not published the OLA-only share in its budget documents. Cycle 1 (2015–2020) OLA-only figures are from SPR's public statements. Cycle 2 OLA-only amounts for 2023 and 2024 are from Parkways coverage; 2025–2026 OLA-only splits are not publicly disclosed. A public records request for the missing OLA-only detail has been filed and is awaiting response (see [PRR #3](#)); this page will be updated when SPR responds. Every figure below has its source linked; approximate or combined figures are flagged explicitly.

SPR total. “All funds” figures where available (2019 onward); 2016–2018 are general-fund + operating only, which is why the step between 2018 and 2019 looks large: about half of it is methodology, not real growth. 2026 is the proposed budget; 2025 is the adopted + CIP. Primary source: [Seattle City Budget Office archives](#).

OLA-only line. Cycle 1 is \$106,000 a year, the Cost of Services figure at p. 19 of the [2017 People, Dogs and Parks Plan](#); pp. 3 and 5 of the same plan give the range as \$103,000–\$117,000. Cycle 2 figures are the adopted budget for Master Project MC-PR-51002 “Improve Dog Off Leash Areas,” released by SPR in July 2026 in response to [PRR C264837](#). Multi-year totals quoted on this site (\$5,625,926 budgeted, \$1,053,037 spent, \$4,362,265 available) are the grand totals SPR’s own table states. Summing the individual years gives figures one or two dollars different, because SPR’s rows are rounded to whole dollars; the source’s totals are used rather than a re-derivation.

Two corrections came with that release, and both are worth stating plainly. **First**, this site previously carried \$126,000 (2023) and \$129,000 (2024) as the OLA-only figures, attributed to Parkways and press coverage. No source for those numbers was ever located, and the primary record puts the figures 2.6 times higher. They were removed in September 2026. **Second**, this site previously said the OLA share was not published and could not be known. It is not published in the budget books, but SPR tracks it and produced it on request; the two are not the same thing. **2019–2022 remain genuinely unavailable:** the request covers 2023 onward, and no OLA-only record exists for the earlier years.

Combined OLA + P-Patch. The post-2019 line values (\$160,800 through \$1.85M) include both OLA maintenance and P-Patch community-garden maintenance. The **2021–2024 combined figures are the City-adopted appropriations** from the 2023-Adopted/2024-Endorsed budget book (obtained via [PRR C265589](#)), replacing earlier proposed-budget values; 2025–2026 remain proposed. There is no allocation methodology to publish: the two are separate Master Projects, MC-PR-51002 and MC-PR-51001, booked apart at source, and together they account for the whole budget line.

Which of the two is larger depends on the measure, and the three available measures disagree. On adopted budget, off-leash areas are larger in all four years (57.6% of the line in 2023, 85.7% in 2025). On revised budget, P-Patch is larger in 2023 and 2024 (60.5%, 64.7%) and off-leash areas in 2025 and 2026. On money actually spent, off-leash areas are larger in 2023, 2025 and 2026, P-Patch in 2024. Any single claim about which is bigger has to name its measure. An earlier version of this page inferred from the withdrawn \$126,000 figure that P-Patch was the larger share; that inference does not survive the primary record.

Cycle 2 capital. SPR’s project pages give the two-OLA construction line as [\\$3,103,000](#), for West Seattle Stadium and Othello; Ravenna Park was selected for design only and its construction is unfunded. **This money is not separate from the budget line above.** SPR states it is booked inside BC-PR-50000, within MC-PR-51002, which is why the OLA-only figure steps from about \$330,000 in 2023–2024 to about \$1.57M in 2025–2026. Earlier versions of this page showed the capital as a separate \$1.73M-per-year addition on top of the combined line, which double-counted it; that treatment was removed in September 2026. Roughly \$600,000 had been spent by 7 July 2026, all of it on planning and design.

Per-dog figure. Uses the 150,000 Seattle dog-population floor from Seattle Humane / Cascade PBS coverage. SPR’s 2023 Expansion Study cites higher estimates up to 400,000; the higher estimate would make any per-dog spending figure proportionally smaller.

Peer cities. Dog-park-specific budget lines were not found in published budget documents for Portland, San Francisco, Vancouver BC, Austin, DC, or Minneapolis (operating) as of April 2026 search. Minneapolis's MPRB publishes the OLA Enterprise Fund in its CAFR; the other cities do not separately report. See <data/peer-cities-budget.csv>.

Corrections and contributions. Primary-source corrections or access to peer-city dog-park budget data welcome; email us at seattledogparkdata@ozymandi.as or via the [issue tracker](#).

FROM: [PEER CITIES](#)

Peer Cities: data notes

About this data

Peer-city off-leash-area (OLA) counts use different definitions and are not directly comparable without adjustment. Seattle counts only dedicated OLAs (12 fully fenced; Magnuson and I-5 Colonnade partially); Portland includes unfenced voice-control areas; Vancouver BC includes time-restricted beach and field access; San Francisco mixes fenced and voice-control zones; Austin's headline figure is inflated by large natural-area voice-control sites. Each city section above flags the relevant definition. The underlying data, with both raw and adjusted figures where applicable, is in <data/peer-cities.csv>.

Sourcing. Peer-city operational detail (hours, fees, bonds, statutes, governance) rests on the linked external pages as read in April 2026 and is not archived in this repository. Two items carry known recency risk and are flagged where they appear: Portland's 2020 parks levy (five-year term through 2025), and Vancouver's elected Park Board (a 2023 dissolution push, reportedly dropped in 2026). The SF licensing claim was corrected against the Health Code in September 2026. The City of Seattle's own peer table, from the FAS Director's June 2022 report to Council (PRR C266465, Bates 00524), puts Seattle at 1.9 OLAs per 100,000 residents against Portland 4.9 and San Francisco 6.5; TPL puts the same three at 1.82 / 5.74 / 5.03. Seattle's figure is stable across both counts; the peers' are not.